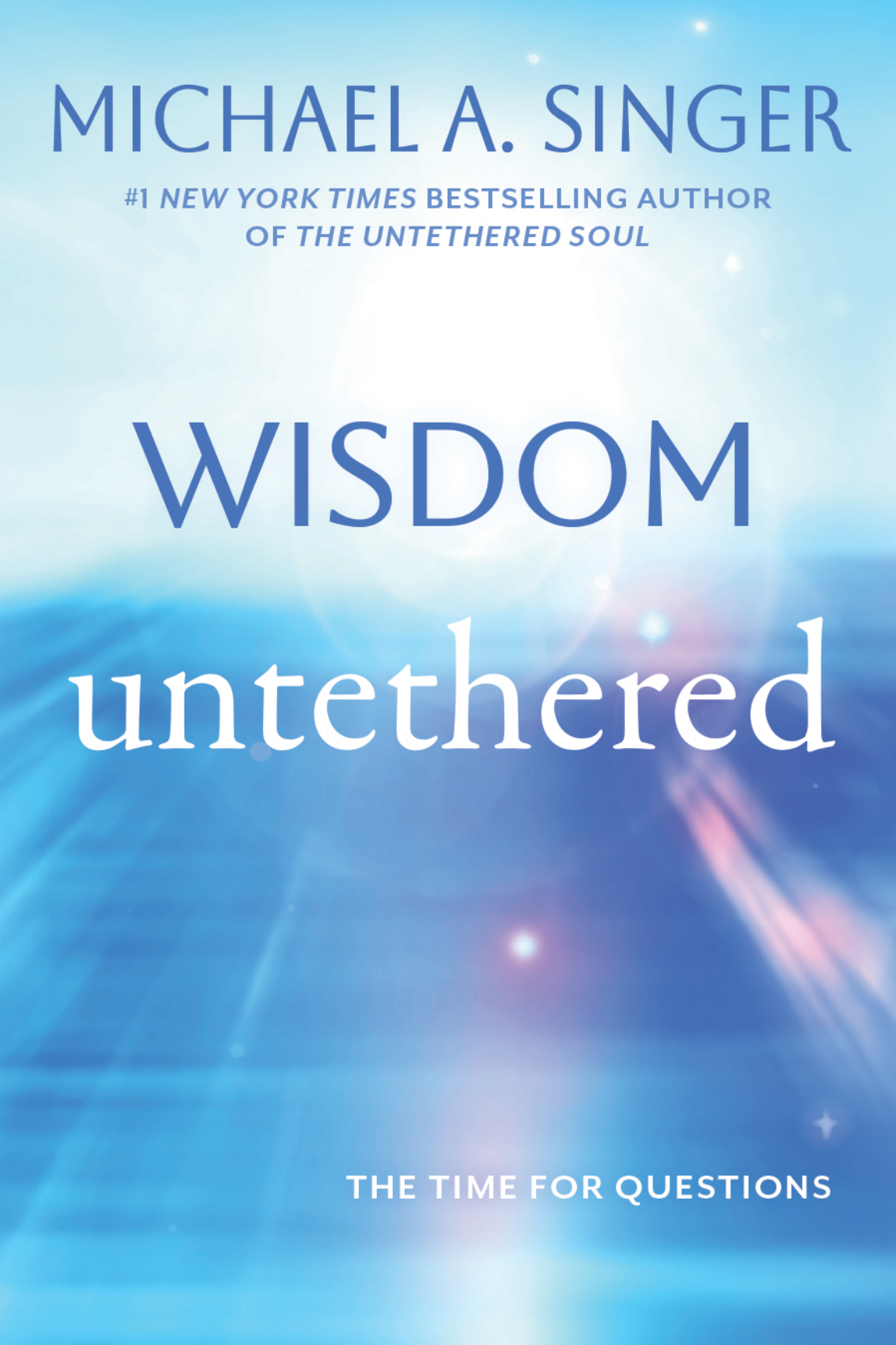




MICHAEL A. SINGER

#1 *NEW YORK TIMES* BESTSELLING AUTHOR
OF *THE UNTETHERED SOUL*

WISDOM
untethered

THE TIME FOR QUESTIONS

WISDOM untethered

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To the Masters

Contents

Preface	vii
THE FOUNDATION	1
1 The Mind	3
2 Emotions	11
3 Ego and Self-Concept	21
4 Witness Consciousness	31
STARTING THE JOURNEY	41
5 Samskaras	43
6 Desires and Preferences	53
7 Resistance and Acceptance	61
8 Surrender	67
WALKING THE PATH	77
9 Letting Go	79
10 Growth and Transformation	89
11 Dealing with Fear	99
12 Karma, Free Will, and the Law of Attraction . .	109
13 Spiritual Practices	117
14 The Real Spiritual Teacher.	127

RIGHT ACTION	133
15 Decision Making	135
16 Career and Work Life	143
17 Relationships	151
18 Engaging with the World	161
 THE ASCENT	 169
19 Love and Compassion	171
20 Freeing Your Inner Energy	181
21 Consciousness and Awareness	189
22 The Meaning of Life and Death	197
23 Beyond Mind: Intuition, Prayer, and God.	207
 Acknowledgements	 215

Preface

People walk through life carrying a longing to be at peace and free, both outside and in. It is not difficult to see that this longing manifests differently in every heart. This is not a human shortcoming; it is the miracle of consciousness expressing itself through people's countless unique experiences.

When you first hear the teachings of spiritual awakening and inner surrender, you naturally hear them through the filter of your past. As you progress along the path of opening up and letting go of your past stored impressions, what once seemed complex and difficult becomes surprisingly clear and straightforward. As this transformation takes place, questions naturally arise.

What you will find in these pages is the outpouring of two hundred questions from fellow seekers who have tasted the possibility of liberation and want to understand it more deeply. These questions span every aspect of life: relationships, work, how we navigate our thoughts and emotions, and how we ultimately learn to release the inner blockages that have kept us bound.

These are not theoretical inquiries. They come from people who are doing the real work—people who have felt the friction of letting go and have glimpsed the expansiveness on the other side. Their questions help illuminate the many ways in which the mind tries to reassert control, how the heart can open and close, and how the journey unfolds layer by layer, deeper and deeper.

I have come to see that these questions are an integral part of our spiritual journey. Each person's question is a doorway into greater understanding, a mirror reflecting where we are in our own growth. When you explore these questions and their responses, you are not just reading someone else's process; you are given the chance to look freshly at your own.

This book is meant to be a companion on your path. My hope is that you will discover in these pages the reassurance that you are not alone. You walk with others who are inspired to embrace life's challenges and willing to learn what it means to surrender in the moments that matter most.

Ultimately, life itself is asking you a single question: Are you willing to let go? As you engage with the questions in this book, you will find your own answers arising from the seat of awareness within you. That is where true wisdom is found—untethered by the mind, untouched by circumstance, and waiting to be discovered.

All you have to do is be willing to let go.

—Michael A. Singer

THE FOUNDATION







CHAPTER 1

The Mind

The most important thing you can do in life is recognize that you are not your mind. That voice in your head—it never stops talking. It narrates, it judges, it worries, and it tries to control everything. What if you could simply watch it instead of getting caught in it? The truth is, your mind is a beautiful tool, but it was never meant to be who you are. In this chapter, we're going to take a deeper look at your questions about the mind—how it works, how it pulls you in, and, most importantly, how to step back into the seat of awareness where real peace begins. You don't have to fix your mind. You just have to stop letting it run your life.

1-1

How can I use the mind as a tool to escape negative thoughts or feelings?

If you want to use the mind to rise above negativity, you first have to recognize that the mind itself is layered. There's the lower mind, which reacts based on past experiences, and the higher mind, which has the ability to lift you out of those conditioned patterns. You have a choice: you can either let the mind keep running its old programs, or you can consciously direct it toward higher thoughts. That's what positive thinking is—it's using the mind to uplift itself. There's nothing wrong with that. It's a valid and powerful technique.

When you notice that your mind is starting to spiral into negativity, immediately engage it with something higher. Use affirmations, a mantra, or you can keep it simple and tell yourself, "I can handle this." Just keep saying "I can handle this" over and over again. No matter what's happening, no matter what thoughts are arising, just keep reinforcing that you can handle it. What you're really doing is redirecting the mind's energy. Instead of letting it drag you into the muck, you're lifting it up to a place where you can stay centered.

At the highest level, the real work is not about battling the mind—it's about learning to relax in the face of whatever it's doing. You won't always be successful, especially in the beginning. That's okay. Start with the little things. When someone cuts you off in traffic, when the weather isn't how you want it, when someone says something that rubs you the wrong way—practice relaxing. Just let go. Your mind will try to pull you into the reaction, but you don't have to go there. If you stay relaxed, the energy that was about to get caught in negativity will actually rise up inside you. This is the transmutation of energy.

Over time, as you keep letting go instead of feeding the negativity, the negativity itself will start to dissolve. The mind will naturally quiet down because it will no longer be receiving reinforcement. The more you relax, the more the mind releases its grip. One day, you'll look back and realize that the very things that used to disturb you no longer have the power to do so. That's freedom. That's the result of having done the real work.

1-2

How do I handle the narration in my mind that creates doubt, guilt, or fear?

If you wish to work with your mind to rise above these lower thoughts, you have to see why that aspect of your mind has so much power over you. If you look closely, you'll see that it's because, deep down, you're afraid you won't be okay. You believe that if you make the wrong decision, or if things don't go your way, it will somehow determine your well-being. That's why the mind keeps talking—it's trying to find a way to make you feel okay.

The important realization is that it's your mind causing the problem in the first place. You're asking a mind filled with doubt, fear, and insecurity to give you advice about how to be at peace. Do you see how absurd that is? The more you engage with it, the louder it gets. It can never give you the answer, because it is the problem.

Don't try to silence the mind. Instead, step back and watch it. See its patterns. Notice how it pulls you in with fear and uncertainty, making everything seem urgent and important. When you truly see what's happening, you

stop taking the mind so seriously. You stop believing that its endless complaints and apparent solutions hold the key to your happiness.

You don't have to fix the mind. You don't have to resolve every thought or feeling. You just have to realize that you are not your mind. The moment you do that, you're free. Decisions can unfold naturally, without struggle. Life can take care of itself. Your job is not to control everything. Your job is to learn to relax back into the seat of awareness and let go of the false belief that your well-being depends on getting what the mind wants.

1-3

How can I shift from personal to impersonal thinking?

The impersonal mind refers to the deeper, more peaceful thought patterns that are not about your personal desires and fears. The bridge to the impersonal mind is to start training yourself to see the bigger picture. You must work with your thoughts to get off your addiction to thinking about yourself and on to thinking with a much larger frame of reference.

Every moment is an opportunity to shift your perspective. When you're sitting in your car, before you start the engine, stop for a second. Notice that you're on a little planet spinning in the middle of nowhere. That's reality. Then start the car. When you arrive at your destination, before getting out, stop again. Recognize that you just moved across a small stretch of space on the surface of a vast planet, and now you're about to step into another moment of your life. Do this every time you walk through a doorway, every time you pick up the phone, every time you engage with the world. It only takes a second, and it will train your mind to see beyond its narrow, self-centered concerns.

If you don't do this, what will your mind do? It will worry. It will desire. It will dwell on the past. That's just how the mind operates if it's left unchecked. But the mind can be trained. Just like you can train a dog to sit, you can train your mind to rise above the personal. At first, you might have to be firm: "Be still! Quiet down!" Eventually, it becomes natural. Instead of being lost in thought, you start to recognize the deeper reality of every moment. In that reality, there is peace.

1-4

Isn't the mind helpful sometimes? Which part of my mind do I listen to?

It is not a matter of choosing which voice of the mind to listen to; it is about sitting quietly deep inside and not being distracted by the noise the mind is creating. You have made great progress if you realize that your personal mind does not always give good advice. You must be comfortable not listening to all the personal chatter it's creating. Once you can sit comfortably within, despite any noise the personal thoughts and emotions are creating, you will have achieved clarity. Now you can see what is going on at all levels of your being without being distracted by it. In this state of clarity, you will know which thoughts are helpful for interacting with the world unfolding before you.

You don't have to listen to every thought. You are perfectly capable of seeing a thought for what it is: a temporary expression passing through your mind. You can certainly choose to listen to some of these expressions if they are of assistance to you. Especially your purely intellectual thoughts. The intellectual, analytical mind can be very good in that realm. But if you think that you are your thoughts, and you react to every thought you have—you'll be in big trouble!

No one is suggesting that you ignore all your thoughts. Just start with the ones that have no value and rob you of your joy in life. You'll be surprised to see how many of your thoughts fall into this category. For example, what is the advantage of being bothered by thoughts of the past? The past is over; it had its day. If it wasn't pleasant, thank God it's over. Why keep hanging out with thoughts that bring back the disturbance you felt when the event happened? That has no value, only cost. People get lost in such thoughts all the time, and these thoughts ruin their lives.

Since you are not your thoughts, you can learn to release these thoughts if they come up and focus on the beauty of life around you. Focus on more constructive thoughts that are raising you instead of tearing you down. This is true for all the personal, disturbing thoughts like: *No one likes me*, or *I can't believe I said that; I feel so uncomfortable*. Wouldn't it be nice if we weren't haunted by thoughts of the past or bothered by constant self-judgement? What if we could always appreciate that we are alive and able to experience reality as it passes before us?

If you practice letting go of nonbeneficial thoughts, you will find that you in there, the one noticing the thoughts, have an intuitive wisdom that is deeper than your thoughts. We're not talking about things like mathematics—your mind is very good at purely analytical topics. But with matters of life as they manifest before you, especially with interactions with other people, the thought-free, peaceful wisdom that comes when the mind is still is a much better guide. Your thoughts may not be able to figure it all out, but you will still know what to do. This deeper wisdom is found by centering in the awareness of being, not in the noisy thoughts of the personal mind.

1-5

How do I apply the teachings of letting go when I have an anxiety disorder? Is it really the same process as for those who don't have psychological illness?

It is important to understand that the Self—consciousness—is transcendent to all mental, emotional, and physical states. Since it is transcendent to the psyche, it is transcendent to the anxious psyche. Anxiety, no matter how deep, is just a state that the psyche is capable of getting into. It has nothing to do with the Self. The Self is the one that is in there noticing.

For example, how do you know you're feeling anxiety? This is actually a deep question. You know because you are in there experiencing the anxiety. You are not anxious—you are watching an anxious psyche. The problem is, you tend to get drawn into it, just like everyone tends to get drawn into their psyche.

If you have been diagnosed with an anxiety disorder, the assistance of a professional therapist can be very helpful. Fortunately, in the end, the process of stepping back and observing the mind is exactly the same for you as it is for anyone wanting to grow spiritually. Your growth is to be able to sit in the witness and learn to be comfortable with everything you see. If you are having a good day, be comfortable having a good day. If you're having a bad day, relax your shoulders, relax your belly, relax your heart, and say, "Oh, look, this is what it means to be experiencing anxiety." The Self is watching the psyche, and what you'll see is that you really can sit within the Self and simply watch, even if the psyche isn't doing well. To the extent that you are able to sit in the Self, you will start to feel spiritual energy come in from

behind. Even in the midst of an anxious psyche, you can feel uplifted; you can feel the joy of Self.

1-6

I have done destructive things in my life and caused trouble for others. I can't seem to let go of the guilt and don't know how to fix things for the people I hurt.

We are sorry to hear you're struggling with regrets about your past decisions and actions. Life is a place souls are sent to evolve, and that is exactly what you are doing—evolving. If you learned to play the piano, and you made mistakes at early recitals, but now you play wonderfully, should you feel guilty about your previous mistakes? Or should you look back and be grateful for the lessons you learned?

It is the same with life. You have the right to learn and work through your stuff. Regrets hold you back from evolving beyond your past. In the end, you should be grateful for your past since it helped you to wake up spiritually. You cannot undo the past, but you can take the lessons you learned and let them shine forth as beauty in the present. If someone were to ask you whether you would make the same mistakes again, you would tell them, “No, I would never do that again.” Well, then, you have learned. You are allowed to learn and grow through life.

Raise yourself and offer the most beautiful aspect of yourself to every person you meet. Do not hold yourself back with issues from the past. Bring light into the present. When these thoughts and emotions of regret come up, don't suppress them; use affirmations to raise them. Repeat regularly: *I am a being of great light. I have learned to bring love and peace into this world. Or, I am born anew every day. My past pain has awakened me, and I am ready to raise myself and others around me.*

1-7

I find myself swinging between higher consciousness and getting pulled back into my mind. How do I handle this back-and-forth?

When you keep getting pulled back into your personal mind from a higher state of consciousness, understand that this is completely natural. This is what

growth looks like. If transformation were as simple as touching a higher state and staying there permanently, enlightenment would be effortless. That's not how it works. You wake up to a greater awareness, and then you see—really see—what's going on inside. You notice how your mind pulls you in, how your emotions rise and fall, and how old patterns grip you. That's progress. The fact that you can see it happening means you are no longer lost in it.

The reason you continue to get pulled in is because throughout your life, you've stored unresolved experiences that you didn't want to deal with. Instead of facing them, you pushed them away, and now they've built up inside you. Every time you get pulled back into your mind, it's because something inside is being stirred up. A thought, a situation, even a simple word can trigger all that stored energy to resurface. When it does, you have a choice: You can resist it by willfully pushing it back down, or you can recognize that this is your moment of growth. You don't need to fight it. You need to relax and let it pass through.

If you truly want to handle this back-and-forth, shift your perspective. Instead of seeing these fluctuations as a problem, see them as part of the process. When you find yourself back in your mind, don't resist it, don't judge it—just observe it. Breathe. Relax your body. Instead of getting caught up in resistance, let the energy flow. Each time you let go instead of reacting, you are cleansing yourself. You are breaking free.

You must understand that the goal is not some perfect high state where nothing ever pulls at you. The goal is to become so open, so clear inside, that no matter what arises, you remain centered. Growth is not about clinging to peace; it's about letting go of whatever is blocking you from it. If you commit to continuously letting go, there will come a time when your lower self stops pulling you down. Instead, even your lower self will begin reaching up toward the light. When that happens, the struggle is over—not because nothing ever comes up again, but because you have learned to let it pass without resistance. Keep letting go and watch what happens.

1-8

How can I balance intellectual curiosity with spiritual growth?

Your mind naturally wants to analyze, to figure things out, to seek knowledge, and that's fine. But real growth happens when you stop trying to fit

life into your mental constructs and instead surrender to the unfolding of life itself. If you truly want to grow, don't just chase knowledge—seek truth. Truth is not found in the intellect alone; it's found when you let go of the part of you that clings to preferences, opinions, and the need to control outcomes.

First seek the highest—seek God and liberation. In doing so, everything else will naturally fall into place. That means letting go of the part of you that constantly grasps for understanding everything. You don't need to understand everything with your mind. The greatest understanding doesn't come from thinking; it comes from the quiet mind that transcends thought. When you release yourself from the need to figure everything out, you will find yourself naturally aligned with something much greater than the mind.

The mistake people make is believing that they need to reconcile spirituality with intellectual pursuit, as if the two are separate. They're not separate. The highest realization is not found by rejecting the intellect, but by going beyond it. If you use the mind to serve something higher—if your curiosity is rooted in a sincere yearning for truth, rather than personal identity—you will find harmony. But if you stay caught in ego-driven analysis, doubt, and attachment to ideas, you will only create obstacles for yourself.



CHAPTER 2

Emotions

Emotions are not your enemy—they are simply energies moving through you. But for most people, emotions become a source of struggle because they resist them, identify with them, and try to push them away. The truth is, your heart is capable of feeling the entire spectrum of life—from sorrow to joy, from fear to love—and there's nothing wrong with any of it. The real question is: Can you stay open enough to let it all pass through without clinging or closing down? In this chapter, we'll explore your questions about what it means to live with an open heart, how to relax through emotional waves instead of being swept away by them, and how every emotion, no matter how strong, can become a step on your path to freedom—if you're willing to let go.

2-1

How do I differentiate between suppressing emotions and allowing them to pass through naturally?

When you feel an intense emotional sensation rising within you, and your body starts to tighten up, the key is not to fight it. Don't get lost in trying to control it or force it to relax. The moment you start thinking, *I need to get rid of this tension—maybe I'm not doing it right*, you've already engaged with the mind's resistance. That very effort to make it go away is what keeps it there. Instead of resisting tension, just relax the area around your heart. Don't focus on the disturbance; focus on relaxing the heart.

Witness consciousness means you are simply aware of what is happening inside you without trying to change it. If tension arises, you don't have to suppress it, fix it, or analyze it—you just remain aware it is there, breathe deeply, and relax the heart. Let the disturbing emotion come up. In doing so, you create space for it to pass. You're not ignoring it, you're not pushing it away,

and you're not getting pulled into it. You are just watching. The moment you stop resisting, it can naturally begin moving through you.

The reason emotions feel overwhelming is because the mind pulls your consciousness into them. It wants you to engage. If you stay centered and just relax and observe, the energy will eventually release on its own. You don't have to do anything except allow it to come and go. You'll notice that, without your interference, the tension you once thought you had to fix will dissolve by itself.

This is the difference between suppressing and allowing. Suppression is when you push the feeling away, try to control it, or judge it. Allowing means you let it be there without interference, trusting that it will pass. If you truly commit to this, you will find that your consciousness naturally begins to rise above the disturbance, and what once felt heavy will become light. The more you practice this, the freer you become.

2-2

How do I deal with low-level tension and anxiety?

The fact that you're noticing this disturbance is an important first step. The key is to not fight with it but simply relax through it. The moment you start struggling with it—trying to push it away or figure out how to get rid of it—you're actually making it worse. It's like a lake that has ripples. If you go in there and try to smooth them out with your hands, you only create more ripples. If you leave it alone, the water naturally settles on its own. Your mind and heart are the same way. When you resist what you're feeling, you stir it up. When you relax, it begins to settle.

When you wake up in the morning and feel tension, don't go into the mind and start analyzing it. Don't ask, *Why do I feel like this?* or *How can I make this go away?* That's just another layer of disturbance. Instead, simply notice it. *Ah, there's some anxiety.* Just let it be there, and then relax behind it. You are not the anxiety; you are the one who is aware of it. If you can learn to sit behind it without reacting, you'll see that it comes and goes all on its own.

The mistake people make is thinking they need to fix their inner experiences. You don't. You need to learn to let them pass through. Anxiety, fear, uncertainty—these are just natural energy fluctuations caused by the ego. They don't need your interference. Can you relax and allow them to be there

without getting involved, watching them rise and fall like waves in the ocean? That is the practice.

Have you noticed that almost everything you worry about never even happens? Look at your life—how many of the things you’ve worried about actually became real problems? Very few. Yet you’ve spent all that time lost in worry, when instead, you could have simply let go and lived in peace. The next time tension comes up, see it, acknowledge it, and then choose to relax. Just let go, again and again. If you do this, in time, you’ll see that anxiety doesn’t have to control you. It can just be another passing experience, like clouds in the sky.

2-3

How do I handle overwhelming feelings of loss and sorrow when someone I love dies?

When you feel flooded with feelings of loss and sorrow, the first thing you need to understand is that there is nothing wrong with those feelings. Your heart is capable of experiencing an entire spectrum of emotions: love, loss, joy, sorrow—all of it. The real question is not whether your heart will feel these things; it absolutely will. The question is whether you can handle it. Can you allow yourself to fully experience what your heart is expressing, without resisting it or getting lost in it?

Your heart is like an orchestra, playing all kinds of music. Sometimes it plays a beautiful, uplifting symphony, and sometimes it plays the deep sorrow of a funeral march. Why resist any of it? Why not appreciate the fullness of what it means to have a heart that can feel so deeply? You wouldn’t listen to a powerful, tragic piece of music and wish it didn’t exist; you would recognize its beauty. The same is true for your own emotions. The heart expresses, and your role is to honor that expression, not to suppress it or fight with it.

The problem comes when you identify with these emotions so strongly that they paralyze you. You say, “I feel so much love that it hurts.” Why should love ever be a problem? Love is beautiful. Even sorrow is beautiful—it means you have cared deeply about something. The key is to step back just a little, to create enough space between you and the emotions so that you can fully experience them, without being consumed by them. Instead of saying, “I can’t handle this,” relax through it. Let the energies of those emotions rise

up to you, let them express, and then let them pass. If you resist, you get stuck. If you hold on, they leave scars. But if you simply allow them to flow through, they complete their cycle and move on.

This is exactly how you handle the death of a loved one. Rather than getting lost in overwhelming feelings, appreciate the depth of love that your heart is capable of. You don't need to shut down or push away the sorrow. You need to be open enough to let it move through you. If you do this, your love will lift you, not weigh you down. Your heart will become a channel for the natural flow of life, rather than a place where emotions get trapped. In that openness, you will find a deeper connection—not just to your loved one, but to the very source of love itself.

2-4

Should I actively trigger suppressed emotions to release them?

No, you don't need to actively trigger suppressed emotions to release them. That's not how this works. You don't go down into the mess and try to dig it up—life will bring up exactly what needs to be released when it's time. Your job is not to go searching for buried pain; your job is to build the strength and clarity to handle it when it naturally arises.

Think of it like fruit ripening on a tree. If you force it off too soon, it's not ready, and it takes a lot of effort to ripen it artificially. You're interfering with something that happens best on its own. The same is true for emotional purification. That pain, those suppressed emotions—they will surface when they are meant to, and when they do, you must be willing to let them pass through. That means staying centered, breathing, and not getting pulled down into them.

The mistake people make is thinking they need to do something with these emotions, like stir them up or force them out. In truth, you are simply watching something inside of you that is trying to release. If you start engaging with it, you're only reinforcing its grip. Instead, relax. Let it come up when it needs to, and when it does, let it go.

You can even talk to the energy that is trying to release. You can say, “I see you. I know you’re there. I’m sorry I shoved you down all those years ago. You’re welcome to come up whenever you’re ready, and I will do my best to let you go.” That’s a completely different relationship than trying to rip it out of yourself. That’s love, compassion, and surrender. If you stay with that openness, in time, everything will release exactly as it needs to.

2-5

How do you know when you’ve worked through emotional pain?

When you’ve truly worked through emotional pain, you don’t have to think about it anymore— it’s gone. You don’t sit there and analyze whether you’ve moved past it; you simply notice that it no longer arises in you the way it used to. There was a time when certain situations, thoughts, or memories would trigger something inside you, and now they don’t. It’s like driving home from work and realizing something happened today that once would have bothered you, but now you didn’t even think to be bothered. That’s how you know.

It’s not about making yourself forget or forcing yourself to be okay. It’s that the charged energy that used to cause disturbance has been neutralized. The white lines on the road are not calls to action—yet you see them. They are there, but they don’t demand your attention. That’s what happens when you’ve fully let something go. It becomes like any other passing experience. It once distracted your attention, but now it no longer controls your inner state.

Think about things from your past that you used to be obsessed with but have completely faded from your mind. When you were a child, maybe you had a toy that was everything to you. Then one day, you outgrew it. It didn’t take effort, and you didn’t have to make a decision to move on—you just did. That’s what happens when you truly process and release emotional pain. It’s not that you suppress it, and it’s not that you fight with it. It simply flows into the vast ocean of life and no longer pulls on you.

If the pain happens to come up again, that’s okay. Just take a moment to notice—*Wow, this used to really bother me, now it barely affects me.* That’s growth. That’s how you know you have worked through an emotional blockage.

2-6

I feel deep shame about some of the things I've gone through in my life. How do I free myself from these feelings and stop being consumed by them?

In your mind and heart, there are stored impressions from the past, called *samskaras*. The shame you describe is due to a deep samskara trying to release, and that is causing the feeling of shame expressing itself in your mind and emotions.

How do you release a deep samskara? Love it; welcome it; worship it. It is what stands between you and God—so it is very holy. Don't push it back down; welcome it up. And don't be afraid of it, or you will never let it go; you will just keep protecting yourself from it. Understand that it is just suppressed negative energy from your past trying to finally get out. You don't want it down there—help it release. If there is pain, relax through the pain and give it the room it needs to pass through.

Do not try to raise yourself by pushing your disturbed self away. Raise yourself by raising the shame up—offer it to God, to the Universe. Literally, hold it in your hands and offer it up. Don't be ashamed that you feel shame. Rejoice that it is surfacing. Give it whatever time it needs and let it go with compassion. If you are willing to do this, you will open yourself to the cleansing process.

2-7

How can I handle overwhelming emotions and thoughts when they feel too strong to manage?

When emotions and thoughts become overwhelming, you have to understand that the time to deal with them isn't when they hit full force—it's every single day leading up to that moment. You don't wait until a powerful wave crashes over you to learn how to swim. You prepare in calmer waters, little by little, so that when the waves do come, you know how to stay afloat. Every moment of your life presents you with an opportunity to let go—small annoyances, frustrations, and irritations. If you practice releasing these little things, when something big comes along, you'll already know what to do.

When you feel strong emotions rising up, don't immediately get involved. Just notice. Watch them come. Watch how your mind starts talking. It wants

to grab on to the emotions and spin stories about them. Stay centered for as long as you can. Breathe. Relax. If you get pulled in—fine. But come back as soon as you notice you fell. Don't judge yourself, and don't fight with yourself. The mind will try to convince you that you must do something about these emotions, that you have to control them, but you don't. You just have to be able to let them pass through you.

Here's the key—don't identify with them. The emotions are not you. The thoughts are not you. They are just passing energies. The only reason they seem overwhelming is because you have made them personal. What happens when you stop doing that? They come, and they go. Just like everything else in life. Instead of getting lost in them, you stay behind them. You remain seated in your true Self, simply observing.

This is a process, and it takes time. But if you commit to it by working with the smaller things in your everyday life, you will find that even the strongest emotions can come, and they won't take you down. One day, you'll notice that there's no longer a gap between noticing the tendency to fall and coming back—you remained conscious throughout. You have become established in the seat of Self, completely free.

2-8

I've been going through a lot of pain since my divorce. Should I continue allowing myself to feel this grief, or am I keeping myself stuck in suffering?

The feeling of loss after a divorce is difficult for anybody, and it takes time to heal. This is how a spiritual person navigates the process: They go through the human pain, just like any other person, except they do not resist the experience. They constantly ask themselves, "Who notices the pain?" They are aware of the pain, but they are much more interested in where the awareness is coming from. If the heart hurts, they honor the heart's right to feel these real feelings, and they just deeply relax and breathe through the heart. Just as if the heart had nostrils, you can breathe the pain upward, toward the point between your eyebrows (the spiritual eye). This creates a sense of openness and acceptance.

Ultimately, a spiritual person honors what their human aspect is going through, while at the same time using the experience to explore witness consciousness. Constantly be aware that you are not the pain; you are the one

experiencing the pain. If it helps, from a centered position, reach down inside to get a big handful of the pain, and offer it up to God. Stretch your inner hands up way over your head and let the pain go out into the Universe. Behind it all is the peace of knowing that all things pass in time, if you let them. And because you went through them consciously, you become a greater being. This is how an evolved spiritual person goes through difficulty—and it is also how you evolve spiritually.

2-9

When heavy emotional pain arises, how can I increase my capacity to relax and release it?

When you experience heavy emotional pain, it is important to understand what is actually happening inside you. Just like your body has an immune system that works to expel impurities, your psyche has an innate intelligence that is always trying to free itself from what has been suppressed. The pain you feel is not a sign that something is going wrong; it is a sign that something is trying to release. These deep-seated impressions, stored from past experiences, do not want to stay buried inside you. They are rising to the surface so they can leave. Instead of resisting them, you need to learn how to let them go.

Your job isn't to fight with what comes up or try to figure it out. You don't have to analyze it, label it, or even understand it. Your job is simply to relax and allow the process to unfold. It's like giving birth—yes, it can be painful, but that pain is part of something beautiful. Just because it's painful doesn't mean it's bad. Every time you feel resistance to what's coming up, that is your moment to relax, to lean away from the disturbance, and to allow it to pass through you. The more you practice this with the little things, the more you will be prepared when the bigger ones arise.

The highest approach is to actually welcome what comes up, no matter how difficult. You don't have to enjoy it or feel comfortable with it; you can just appreciate that it is leaving. Do you really want to hold on to the things inside you that disturb you the most? Do you want to keep them buried, where at any time they can unexpectedly take over your inner state? Wouldn't you rather let them go forever?

The moment something painful arises, you can shift your perspective. Instead of recoiling from it, you can say, “Thank you. It is time for this to leave.” You don’t have to force yourself to handle it perfectly—even a small shift toward openness will help.

If you truly commit to this process, you will eventually experience something profound. As you continue to relax through the energy of old pain, you will reach a point where it begins to break free. What once felt like overwhelming suffering will transmute into something entirely different—pure, uplifting energy. People have described moments where they stayed open through deep pain, and suddenly that energy shot upward and became bliss. That is the natural flow of energy when it is no longer blocked by resistance. This is the journey of true inner freedom: welcoming what arises, relaxing through it, and allowing it to pass. Every moment of discomfort is an opportunity to become free.



Ego and Self-Concept

The most persistent obstacle to your inner freedom is not the world outside—it's the self you've made up inside. The ego is not who you are; it's who you think you are. It's a collection of memories, preferences, and past disturbances that you've wrapped around yourself like armor. Then you spend your whole life protecting that armor, afraid that something might get through. But what if you didn't need that protection? What if who you really are doesn't need defending at all? This chapter explores your questions about the nature of the ego and the false self-concept you've built, and it invites you to begin the profound journey of letting it all go. You don't have to fix the ego; you just have to stop serving it. When you do, what's left is something vast, beautiful, and free—your true Self.

3-1

What is the purpose of the ego?

The ego is not some higher, divine creation with a grand purpose—it is a defense mechanism. It was born out of fear and identification, first with the body, then with the mind, and eventually with a self-concept that you built over time. At its core, the ego exists to protect something that doesn't even need protecting: a made-up version of yourself that you've been holding on to. The real you doesn't need defense, but the ego doesn't know that. It reacts as if every word, every look, every moment of discomfort is an existential threat. It spends its life controlling, manipulating, and trying to ensure that nothing happens that might disturb it.

The reason the ego feels so real to you is because you've been feeding it your whole life. You spend more time defending your self-concept than you do defending your actual body. Think about it—if someone says something negative about you, you feel deeply hurt, even though no physical harm was

done. If someone ignores you, you feel rejected, as if you've been attacked. The ego has convinced you that its survival is your survival, but that's not true. You don't need a made-up self-concept. The only reason you suffer so much is because you are identified with it.

What happens if you stop defending the ego? What if you stop protecting this false sense of self? At first, it will feel scary because you've never done it before. But the moment you begin to let go, you realize something amazing: You don't need to build walls around yourself. Life is not against you. You are not this fragile being that needs constant defense. You are something much greater, something vast and free. The ego was just a veil, a mask you created out of fear. Letting it go is not losing yourself—it is finding yourself.

If you truly want to be free, you have to stop serving the ego. You don't have to destroy it or fight it; you simply stop feeding it. You stop giving energy to its insecurities, its endless need for validation, its resistance to reality. When you do that, something incredible happens. You become open. You become light. You start experiencing life directly, without the constant interference of that voice inside. When that happens, you will look back and wonder why you ever thought you needed the ego in the first place.

3-2

What does it mean to let go, and how does that relate to the ego and identity?

Your question is very beautiful because it means you're starting to notice what's actually going on inside. Letting go isn't some mystical process—it's the most natural thing in the world. Right now, you hold on to certain experiences and store them inside of you. When an experience happens, instead of letting it pass through, you cling to it. When you do that, you start to build a house out of all that stored baggage—brick by brick, thought by thought. That house is what you call your ego. It's not some external entity controlling you; it's just the accumulated stuff you've identified with. The moment you let go, the walls start to fall.

Why do you hold on to this house of stored thoughts? Because you think it's you. You've built this whole self-concept based on what you like and don't like. That's why when life comes at you, you feel defensive. If something doesn't match the identity you've created, it threatens you. That's why certain things trigger you while others don't—because they hit something you've

stored. But you're not that stored stuff; you're the one watching it. You're the consciousness that sees it all passing through. When something hits your stuff and you feel a reaction coming up, that's your moment. That's the moment you get to choose: Do I reinforce the ego by resisting what's coming up, or do I let go and free myself?

Letting go doesn't mean suppressing or pushing things away. Nor does it mean pretending you don't feel something. It means you stop resisting. The moment comes, the feeling arises, and instead of tightening around it, you relax. You let it disappear as if it were written on water. That's what real freedom is—not controlling life so it doesn't disturb you, but getting to a place where nothing has the power to disturb you.

Please don't overthink this. Just watch. Notice when something inside gets triggered, and instead of getting lost in it, relax. Let it pass. You don't need to analyze it, fix it, or make it mean something. You only need to let go. Every time you let go, you create space for something higher. Little by little, that space becomes your natural state. That's what it means to be free. It's not something you achieve—it's what's left when you stop clinging to what you are not.

3-3

Is letting go of the ego the ultimate goal of spiritual growth? How do I handle situations where the ego drives my reactions?

Yes, letting go of the ego is central to spiritual growth. The ego is a collection of thoughts and stored blockages that create a false self-concept. By observing the ego without reacting or suppressing it, you align with your true Self, which is pure awareness. Situations that provoke the ego are opportunities to release its influence. If you want to work on letting go of ego, practice not always defending yourself—let go inwardly and remain in the seat of witness consciousness.

Remember that when something feels personal, it's often your ego feeling attacked. You should practice letting go of small irritations daily. Over time, this practice will help you handle larger challenges. Always take a moment to distinguish between constructive actions and ego-driven reactions. Even when someone's actions warrant a response, formulate that response from clarity, not as a reaction to a hurt ego.

An evolved being does not try to eliminate or suppress the ego, as it is a natural construct of samskaras from the past. Instead, they work to release the blocked energy that sustains the ego. This process, known as *transmutation*, involves raising the energy coming up as ego and transforming it into a higher expression, such as love, compassion, and acceptance. By observing your energy patterns and addressing their root causes, you can redirect this energy constructively. This work liberates you from the limitations of ego-driven behavior and allows you to experience unconditional peace and fulfillment.

3-4

I struggle with insecurity and worry about how others perceive me. I realize that this worry is unnecessary, but I don't know how to let go of it.

Your question is very poignant and is a very human struggle we all share. The bottom line is that as long as you see yourself as separate from others and believe you are the self-concept you have created in your mind, you will continue to worry about what others think of you. You worry about this because your self-concept is something you made up, and it is easily challenged by the opinions of others. Let go of the whole model, and all worries of what others think of you will disappear. The deeper you let go of yourself, the more connected you will feel with everyone and everything else. The sense of “other” will start to fade away, and you will begin to experience that there is no difference between any other person and yourself. We are all the same, back behind the self-concepts we have made up.

In essence, you are not who you think you are. Be daring and decide to stop defending the self-concept you created—let go of yourself. Every time you feel this worry of other people's opinions come up, relax and release, and remind yourself that you are not your mind, you are not your heart, and you are not your body. You are something very great—you are pure love and oneness. The love and presence of your true Being is unconditional and complete. It cannot be diminished by anything.

3-5

Am I worthy of love, and how do I recognize my worth?

If you're questioning whether you're worthy of love, you need to take a step back and look at what's really happening. You are sitting in the middle of an entire universe that created and sustains you. Your heart is beating, your lungs are breathing, the sun is shining—everything around you is supporting your very existence. Does that sound like a universe that decided you're unworthy? No, it sounds like a universe that is overflowing with love, constantly giving to you without question. Where is this idea of unworthiness coming from? It's coming from your psyche, from a small voice in your mind that is telling you a story that you're believing.

Your mind has created a little box, and within that box, it whispers, *Am I really worthy? Am I really loved?* That voice is not reality. That voice is just old conditioning: thoughts and emotions left over from past experiences. You have to recognize that your mind is not qualified to determine your worth. The same mind that tells you one minute that you're amazing will, the next minute, tell you you're not enough. Why would you take that seriously? You are already infinitely worthy. Existence itself is taking care of you every moment, no matter what your mind says.

If you want to be free from this false sense of unworthiness, neither fight with the mind nor believe it. Just step back and gently talk to it like you would to a small child throwing a tantrum. Say, "It's okay. I hear you. But I'm not going to let you run my life." Take the hand of that scared part of you and lift it up.

The Bhagavad Gita says we should raise the self with Self and not trample down the self. You are the higher Self—the consciousness that is aware of all this chatter in the mind. Stop feeding yourself the false belief that you are unworthy and then looking outside for validation of your worth. Your worth is not something that needs to be earned or proven. It is something you allow yourself to experience by letting go of what is blocking it.

3-6

How do I differentiate between pursuing opportunities and acting out of ego?

To differentiate between pursuing an opportunity and acting out of ego, you have to look deeper than just the surface of your desires. The ego is personal—it's made up of your past experiences, your likes and dislikes, and everything you've built inside to protect yourself. If you feel a strong need to prove yourself, or if you feel like you have to get something to be okay, that's ego. The personal self is always trying to manipulate life to match its preferences. But life doesn't work that way. Life is simply unfolding in front of you, and your job is not to control it but to learn how to serve it.

When an opportunity presents itself, it's not something you have to chase or create, or like or dislike; it's simply there. If you're caught up in your personal mind, you'll constantly be trying to control which opportunities to take based on what you think you want. Have you ever noticed that what you thought you wanted often turns out to be wrong? The mind is not psychic; it doesn't actually know what will bring you fulfillment. If you step back from your personal preferences and just serve what unfolds in front of you, life has a way of carrying you exactly where you need to be.

The reason this seems so difficult is because the personal self is still involved. In reality, the only question is whether you are serving your ego or serving life. If you're asking, *Should I do this or not?* and the answer is tied to what you personally want or don't want, that's ego. If an opportunity comes, and you don't feel a personal grasping for it but instead a natural opening to serve what's in front of you, then it's not ego—it's simply life guiding you.

The highest way to live is to surrender to life's unfolding. Instead of trying to make decisions based on your mind's endless chatter, quiet down and let life show you the way. Stop thinking that you need to figure everything out. You don't. Avoid using the intellect to satisfy personal desires or fears. Focus instead on serving the unfolding of life. Life built this entire universe without your help—it can certainly handle the details of your path. If you relax and let go of your resistance, life itself will take you exactly where you need to go, and you won't have to wonder whether it's ego or opportunity—you'll just know.

3-7**How can I balance letting go with maintaining personal boundaries?**

You have to understand that what you call personal boundaries is actually just a structure built by your ego. Your mind has created a set of conditions that say, "I am okay as long as people don't cross this line." But who decided where that line is? You did. Or rather, your past experiences, fears, and conditioning did. You're essentially saying, "If life stays within this narrow framework, I will remain comfortable." But life doesn't care about your framework. Life is vast, unpredictable, and uncontrollable. The real question is, do you want to spend your life defending your ego, or do you want to be free?

Letting go of your boundaries feels difficult because you've identified with them as if they are an extension of yourself. They aren't—they are simply walls your mind has built to avoid discomfort. What happens when someone crosses them? You close. You tighten. You get upset. That is certainly not freedom. If you keep reinforcing these boundaries, you're actually strengthening the very thing that causes you to suffer—your ego. Just look at your life. Look at how many times you've felt disturbed, offended, or hurt because someone crossed a boundary you set. Did that feel good? Did it bring you peace?

You have to start recognizing that the only reason you feel disturbed is because something inside of you is resisting reality. When someone says or does something that crosses your so-called boundaries, you have two choices: you can resist and suffer, or you can use the situation to learn to let go and remain open. Remember, the problem is never outside of you; it is always inside. It's your own reaction, your own resistance, that's causing the disturbance. If you can recognize that, you can begin to work with it. Instead of saying, "How do I maintain my boundaries while letting go?" start asking, "Why do I have these boundaries in the first place? Who set them, and what would happen if I let them dissolve?"

This doesn't mean you let people walk all over you. Quite the opposite. True strength is being so open, so unshakable, that nothing disturbs your inner peace. If someone acts in a way that is hurtful or unkind, you can respond from clarity, not from defensiveness. You don't need to create a wall of boundaries to protect yourself. You just stay centered in the seat of

awareness and act from there. You do what needs to be done, but without all the inner drama. What you'll find is that life becomes much lighter because you don't get stuck in past disturbances. You're just here, experiencing life as it unfolds, without resistance.

Don't be afraid to let go of your boundaries. They are not keeping you safe—they are keeping you small. Do your best to let life in. Watch what happens when you stop protecting yourself from something that was never really threatening you in the first place.

3-8

I have been reading about “spiritual bypassing,” where people use spiritual practices to avoid dealing with deep emotions or trauma. Could your teachings on relaxing and releasing just be another form of spiritual bypassing? Am I truly healing, or am I just avoiding my pain?

“Spiritual bypassing” is just another term for resisting or suppressing the *samskaras* when they come up. “I’m a child of God, pure and positive. I should not be feeling painful vibrations; therefore, I push them away so I can stay positive. I use mantra to get away from negative energy because I don’t want to be negative.” That is spiritual bypassing, and it is not really spiritual and not so healthy.

In drastic contrast, if you recognize disturbing vibrations from the past when they come up, and relax in the face of them, you are giving them the opportunity to release—not outwardly, but inwardly. Relaxing and releasing is not a way of avoiding pain; it is a way of letting the discomfort pass through you. The additional benefit of doing this is that you learn how to relax through difficult current situations instead of storing even more pain inside.

Welcome the purification you need to go through. This is the opposite of spiritual bypassing; it is spiritual cleansing. A truly spiritual being uses spiritual practices to remain centered as painful experiences pass through. They don’t use practices to avoid or push the pain away; they welcome the pain and remain completely open as it releases. That is the purpose of relaxing and releasing, and over time, it leads to the highest states.

3-9

Why do so many spiritual seekers get caught in the trap of spiritual bypassing?

The spiritual path is about being willing to face the energies you have stored within yourself so that they can be released. It is never about avoidance. It is not about holding emotions and thoughts at bay and saying you are above them. Where people get confused is when they mistake suppression for transcendence. Suppression happens when you push the negative energy away and try to rise above it. Transcendence happens when you let the energy pass through without getting involved in it. You experience all the emotions and thoughts that come up as the stored blockage is released, but you don't let them define you. You give them room to pass through inside, without resisting them.

Ultimately, spirituality is about letting go of the entire ego construct. Many people get lost because they develop a spiritual ego, which is just ego with a self-concept of being spiritual. The spiritual ego does the types of things that are called "spiritual bypassing" in today's vernacular. The bottom line is, if you don't like what's coming up inside and you use will to push it away, that is avoiding spiritual growth. If on the other hand, you welcome the discomfort and use your will to relax and remain open while it passes, that is real spiritual growth. That growth leads to true liberation.

3-10

How do I reconcile spiritual ego with true spiritual progress?

If you truly want to be more sincere in your spiritual growth, then understand this first: You are not here to be perfect. If you were perfect, you wouldn't be here. Earth is a place where souls are sent to evolve, and the way you evolve is by facing the experiences that challenge you. You evolve by letting go of the parts of you that can still distract you from your seat of conscious awareness. It is not about making yourself into some ideal version of yourself. That creates spiritual ego. It is about relaxing and releasing the parts of you that still believe they need something from this world in order to be okay—including needing people to think you are spiritual.

Always remember: The struggles you face, the times you fall, and the moments you forget are not failures—they are exactly why you are here. Every single situation that tests you is an opportunity to let go. Just like a child learning to ride a bicycle—you will fall. But in that falling, you learn balance. You don't fight the falls; you don't make them wrong. You use them to grow. Likewise, when life challenges you, don't resist the challenges. Allow them to refine you.

The key to sincerity is to truly do the best you can. That's all that is ever being asked of you. The best you can is the holiest thing in your universe. If you put your whole heart into it, whatever comes back to you is exactly what you need to learn from. There is no shame in growth. There is no blame in not being perfect. There is only the process of letting go, step by step, as life shows you where you are still holding on.

If you make God, truth, and self-realization the polestar of your life, then everything you experience will lead you toward it. There's no need to worry about where you are or how far you have to go. You just have to be willing. Be willing to release what is pulling you down. Be willing to surrender your personal self to something greater. Be willing to die to the small self so that something vast and infinite can take its place. That is sincerity. That is the path.

Witness Consciousness

There is a place inside of you that has never been disturbed by anything that's ever happened. It doesn't get anxious. It doesn't get excited. It simply sees. That place is your true Self—the seat of witness consciousness. Most people spend their lives lost in the voice in their head, reacting to thoughts and emotions as if they were real. But you are not that voice—you are the one who hears it. In this chapter, we'll explore your questions about what it means to live from that deeper place—the place where you can watch the mind without getting pulled into it, observe emotions without being consumed by them, and experience life without constantly trying to control it. Witness consciousness is not something you create; it's who you already are. The moment you stop clinging to the noise, you fall back into the clarity of simply being.

4-1

How do I cultivate focus and witness consciousness in my daily life?

To cultivate more awareness in your daily life, you don't simply force yourself to concentrate harder. That's not how it works. You cultivate more awareness by letting go of what's distracting your awareness. That's the key. You're already capable of being completely present and walking through life with total clarity. You could do that right now, but something is distracting you from it. Something inside keeps pulling your attention away.

Instead of fighting for more focus, work on letting go of what takes your focus away. Life is constantly giving you opportunities to see this. You get in your car, and suddenly, you're worried about getting a flat tire because last week your friend had one. Why? There's no greater probability of getting a flat now than any other time you've driven. But your mind has grabbed on to that past experience and is projecting it onto the current situation. That's the

moment to practice being present, remaining in witness consciousness. Don't fight the thought; just calmly notice it and let it go.

Letting go is not just for the big things in your life. It is a powerful technique for building awareness in every moment. You can always find situations where you're about to react—perhaps with worry, frustration, or inner tension—and instead, simply relax. Take that moment to let go of the pull the negative thought or feeling has on your awareness. Practice relaxing and releasing. That is how you cultivate awareness. It is not about controlling your mind; it's about releasing the things that steal your focus in the first place.

Right now, this very second, you are capable of being fully present. The only problem is that you're getting involved in your distractions rather than releasing them. Every moment of your life presents an opportunity to let go of something that is distracting your awareness from remaining fully present. If you commit to letting go, the expansion of your consciousness will take care of itself.

4-2

What is the concept of “falling behind things” in your teachings?

When something negative happens in life, you immediately feel a reaction inside—fear, guilt, shame, embarrassment. The natural tendency is to resist the experience because it doesn't feel good. You might suppress it, rationalize it, or even act out in response—but all of that is just avoiding what's actually happening inside of you. The key is to become aware of what you are experiencing. Before you react or suppress, just notice what you are feeling. That moment of awareness is witness consciousness, and it is everything.

So, what should you do when you notice the reaction? Nothing. You don't fight with it, and you don't try to make it go away. That's what the personal mind wants to do—it wants to control everything. The real work is at the level of consciousness. Instead of engaging with the feeling, relax. Let it be there. It's not about fixing the energy you're feeling; it's about changing your relationship with it. You are not the energy—you're the one who's noticing it. If you stop resisting and allow the energy to rise up and pass through, you will begin to notice that you are behind the energy you are experiencing.

You are the experiencer, and it is the experience. Eventually, the distance between subject and object becomes great enough that you are no longer relaxing away from the experience, you are relaxing into the experiencer. That is the essence of falling behind.

The mind thinks it should be doing something with this energy, but all that does is reinforce the fact that you can't handle it. If you fight with it, suppress it, or try to analyze it, you stay engaged with it. If you relax and let it move through, it will release. You don't have to get rid of it—you just have to be willing to relax and handle the discomfort. Over time, you'll start to notice that what used to disturb you doesn't anymore. You don't have to carry all this inside of you.

This is what it means to fall behind things. You are not lost in the disturbance; you are simply letting it pass through while you remain seated in awareness. That is how you let go. That is how you free yourself.

4-3

I don't see how my personal life is “not personal.” I accept that events outside my influence are impersonal, but how does this apply to my immediate life, like my family, work, or my belongings?

Thank you for asking your beautiful question about the statement that things are not personal. To begin with, from the point of view of the conscious witness, nothing is personal. It's all just what you are experiencing. All clouds are the same—they are clouds. But if one reminds you of when you were flying a kite with your dad, that cloud becomes personal. Obviously, the cloud is no different than any other cloud, but you took it personally, so it seems personal. “Personal” is something your mind did to the cloud after it came into your psyche.

This is a difficult subject because we are not ready to look at things objectively. We are very invested in the personal mind. A first step is to understand, at least intellectually, that “personal” is something our mind does to a moment in creation that is simply unfolding in front of us. When you learn to transcend the personal, everything becomes miraculous, simply because it even exists. In this environment of total openness, true unconditional love and peace take over where personal used to be.

4-4

If you sit in witness consciousness all the time, do you stop experiencing human emotions such as love, fear, and worry?

When you sit in a state of witness consciousness, you absolutely do experience emotions. Witnessing and experiencing are actually the same thing. When you sit in a state of awareness, you fully experience the world around you, as well as the thoughts in your mind and the emotions in your heart. You let it all come and go without clinging to it or resisting it.

The distinction between being in the seat of the witness versus lost in the personal mind lies in what you find yourself doing with what you are experiencing. In the seat of witness consciousness, you are no longer reacting to your inner experiences, judging them as good or bad, or storing them inside. You cease to create an alternate reality in your personal mind of what you want or don't want to be happening. Ironically, you will find that in that state, every experience you have will touch you more deeply because you are no longer pushing your experiences away or clinging to keep them.

This state of awareness is not a dry, cold place where you don't feel emotions. It is a vibrant, beautiful place where all emotions are permitted to come and go, leaving you clear and fulfilled. Over time, because you are not resisting and storing the lower emotions, the higher energy flows of love, inspiration, and awe will naturally replace the more reactive human emotions.

4-5

I have been working on watching my thoughts, and it is working to some extent. But the more I watch them, the more I feel caught in them. How do I break free from this cycle?

Thank you for sharing your experiences with witness consciousness. The difference between watching the mind and true witness consciousness is enormous, but very subtle. It is the difference between "watching" and "seeing."

Watching is a willful act that you are doing inside your intellectual mind. This is not the personal mind; it is the intellectual mind watching the personal mind do its thing. There is nothing wrong with this; in fact, it keeps the focus of consciousness from dropping into the personal mind. For example, imagine the personal mind is complaining about something.

Instead of getting involved in the process of complaining, you apply will in order to relax, step back, and simply watch the process, rather than being lost in it.

But true witness consciousness—simply seeing—is deeper than that. Can you glance at a wall in your house, with all its furniture and decorations, and instantly just see it? Don't think about it or do anything about it—just instantly see it. That is a form of witness consciousness. You do not need your intellectual mind, your will, or any act of doership—it is simply the totally natural process of just seeing what is in front of you. When you can just see what is going on inside you with the same effortless ease, you are in the state of witness consciousness. There is no watching—there is just effortless seeing.

How do you get to the freedom of true witness consciousness? Instead of struggling to stay out of the mind, relax and release the pull the mind has on your seat of awareness. By relaxing very deeply, you are detaching your center of Self from the struggle of staying behind the mind. You are, in essence, saying you care so little about what the mind is doing that you can just relax behind it without interacting with it. If you truly let go during this deep relaxation back into the seat of Self, you will begin to feel freedom, peace, and spiritual energy. Don't expect it; just let go of your struggle to control the mind. In essence, don't try to win the tug-of-war—just let go of the rope.

4-6

My mind reminds me that I am supposed to be watching the mind. Isn't that just mind too?

As you become more centered in the seat of witness consciousness, you will find that there are subtle layers of the mind. The mind is not really the enemy, but we tend to be completely lost in the noisy personal mind, which causes quite a bit of suffering. As you have noticed, the mind can also help by reminding you to go deeper. It can and does voice wisdom, such as, *Remember to go back to the seat of witness consciousness*. However, this is still the mind, and you are still experiencing it. You might hear your mind say, *Oh no, I've been following my thoughts again. It's time to step back into my seat of consciousness*. You, who are aware that this is the wise mind talking, are still separate from it.

The witness does not talk or even willfully listen. It is simply effortlessly aware of what it's aware of. Those wise thoughts that feel deeper than the others are still thoughts. They are to be honored, but they are not you. In meditation, it is not necessary to stop the chatter of the mind. Meditation is about sitting behind the mind and letting it come and go—letting it be noisy, quiet, wise, or crazy—without being distracted by it. When you can sit behind every voice of the mind and simply observe it, nonreactively, as mind, then you are firmly seated in witness consciousness. From that seat, over time, you come to know the nature of your being, which is pure love, far beyond even the wisest thoughts of the mind.

4-7

What part of me is speaking when I'm in a conversation with someone? How do I know if my words are coming from a place of genuine presence, as opposed to conditioned responses?

I can offer some pointers that will help you see what is going on. First, before you start speaking to someone, take a moment to see what is going on in your mind and your heart. You might see some anxiety coming up. If so, I would ask you to notice what thoughts are being created in the face of that anxiety. Don't try to do anything about it; just notice your feelings and the resulting thoughts. Since you are a conscious, aware being, it does not take any effort to see your thoughts and emotions. They are right there in front of you—you can't miss them. They are very powerful and prominent inside of you. The one who is noticing the thoughts and emotions is the essence of your being. Thoughts and emotions can change, but it is still you in there noticing they have changed. You are the witness who sees what is going on in there.

Once you have established yourself in this seat of objective awareness, you are ready to see what happens when you start speaking. Almost without exception, you are going to see that your inner thoughts and emotions are going to guide what comes out of your mouth. If your thoughts and emotions are defensive, your spoken words will be defensive. These thoughts and emotions are just the reactive sum of your learned experiences. If a friend told you something positive or negative about someone yesterday, your thoughts and emotions about that person today will tend to reflect that. If you actually

speak based on these past personal impressions, your outer voice will be expressing the reactions of your inner thoughts and emotions.

So, what is your alternative to a purely personal discourse? If you work on yourself enough, you will be able to stay centered in the witness before, during, and after the conversation. You will be able to notice your thoughts and emotions as they arise and let these purely learned reactions pass through without influencing what you are saying. You don't suppress or deny the existence of these inner thoughts or emotions; you just let them pass by, like you do with the wind.

If you take that moment to let go, then you can be standing face to face with the other person without all the inner noise governing what is going on. Now, you can speak from your deeper heart and your deeper intellectual understanding. Your words will no longer be personal reactions; they will be real expressions of the deeper part of your being. These communications will not be based on trying to get something; they will be based on real love, understanding, and compassion. You will be communicating in order to serve others, not to serve yourself.

4-8

What is the difference between using a mantra and practicing witness consciousness to release blockages?

If you want to release a blockage, you have to understand the nature of what's happening inside you. There are two primary approaches you can take: using a mantra or practicing witness consciousness. Both can be powerful, but they work in different ways.

A mantra is something you actively do with your mind. When you repeat a mantra over and over, you create a layer within the mind, almost like a song that gets stuck in your head. That mantra stays with you, and when disturbances arise, you have a choice—you can either place your consciousness on the disturbance or shift it back to the mantra. The very act of redirecting your focus to the mantra allows you to let go of the disturbance. It gives your mind something uplifting to hold on to, rather than being pulled into the chaos of thoughts and emotions.

Witness consciousness is different. It's not about doing something with the mind. It's about stepping back and realizing that you are not the mind;

you are the awareness that observes the mind. The thoughts come and go, the emotions rise and fall, but you are the one watching them. You don't have to fight with your mind, and you don't even have to listen to it. Instead of engaging with what the mind is saying, whether it's a mantra or a complaint, you simply remain as the witness. When you are fully established in this state, you don't need to shift to anything; you are already free.

The key difference between practicing mantra and witness consciousness is that with mantra, you are giving your mind a positive place to rest—training it to hold on to something higher, rather than getting lost in disturbances. With witness consciousness, you go beyond the mind entirely. You sit in the seat of awareness, untouched by what the mind is doing. It's like the difference between trying to manage the waves on the surface of the ocean versus sinking deep beneath them, where everything is still.

Both are valuable, and either can help you let go of blockages. What matters most is your intention. If your goal is to release and rise above the noise inside, then whatever practice you do with sincerity will serve you. Whether you use mantra to redirect your mind or witness consciousness to transcend it, you are taking steps toward freedom. The fact is, they both lead to the same place. If you do mantra properly, over time it will take you far beyond awareness of mind, just as witness consciousness does. Ultimately, what's important is that you're doing something to lift yourself beyond the disturbances, rather than trying to manipulate or control the outside world to feel okay. Let go, turn inward, and allow the process to unfold.

4-9

I carry a deep blockage that has significantly impacted my life. I am doing better but sometimes I lose it. If I try to sit in the witness, I actually feel more tension and discomfort. How do I release such a deep samskara?

Thank you for your sincere question. The discomfort you are feeling when you witness your inner state is because you are still doing instead of just being. Witness consciousness is not the willful act of looking at or focusing on your thoughts or emotions—it is simply the act of seeing them. There is no tension or struggle involved.

Obviously, you know that you have thoughts and emotions. How? They are there, and you notice them. If they tend to distract you and pull you in,

and you have to pull yourself out to see them objectively, that is an act of will and can create tension. You don't have to first focus on a thought, hold it, and then try to let it go; you can just let it go without touching it. That is witness consciousness.

Practice relaxing when there is nothing pulling you in. Then notice when your awareness starts to get pulled toward a distraction. The instant you feel that pull, continue relaxing; don't do anything except relax. Just release the tendency to get pulled in. Don't struggle, just relax. That is real letting go. You don't grab the distracting object and then let it go; you simply relax and let go as the primary act. Eventually, you will experience all of this as a very subtle energetic shift in your energy flow. Energy was flowing up; now it is being pulled in a different direction. Relax and let go; it will continue flowing up. Do this regularly and the subtle energy shifts through your mind and heart will become more pronounced. The more you practice letting go of the pull, the more witness consciousness will become your natural, effortless state.

In the meantime, you are doing fine. When you get pulled in, some blocked energy that has been suppressed gets to release by expressing itself. You feel better, temporarily. Just say thank you, pick yourself up, and deal with what comes next.



STARTING THE JOURNEY







CHAPTER 5

Samskaras

The real problem in life is not what is outside of you, but what is inside of you. And that stuff has been stuck in there for a very long time. These stored inner impressions are called samskaras. They are leftover energy from past experiences you weren't willing to fully feel, so you pushed them down. Now they sit inside you, waiting to be triggered by life. That's why emotions can feel so overwhelming—because they're not just about the present moment; they're hitting something deeper. The good news is, you don't have to analyze or understand every samskara to release it. You just have to be willing to relax and let go when it surfaces. This chapter addresses your questions about that process: how to recognize when a samskara is being activated, how to stop resisting it, and how to allow that stuck energy to finally pass through. This is the inner work that leads to freedom—not by avoiding what's inside you, but by finally letting it go.

5-1

What does a blockage feel like, and how do I know when I have successfully let go? How do I know if I am truly releasing the energy or just suppressing it? Is there a specific sensation that indicates a successful release of a samskara?

When things unfold in your life that hit your blockages, it is usually quite clear. For example, if the outer event is hitting something you have stored as negative, you may feel a disturbed emotional reaction such as fear, anger, or defensiveness. You may also experience tightening in your belly and chest. There is a sensation of tightness and resistance; you may even feel a sensation of heat. The mind gets very active trying to do something about the difficult energy that's coming up. The mind comes up with ideas for what to say or

do to try to fix the situation, so that you don't have to experience the disturbance. These are some of the inner reactions to your stuff getting hit.

More importantly, what does it feel like to release a samskara? The very second you notice that your stuff is being hit, you relax very deeply. Relax your shoulders, chest, belly, and any other areas of the body that have tightened. It's important to know that this may not actually cause the emotions and sensations to subside, but it gives you room to simply be aware of them, rather than getting involved. You relax in the midst of the emotional reactions in the heart and the noise of the disturbed mind, even if your heart and mind continue reacting. And what you will notice is that as you relax, the reactions tend to not be quite as intense or strong.

The physical sensation that occurs when you relax and release may be different depending on how strong the blockage is. If there is a major experience of tightening, then the release might only feel like a slight softening around the edges of the tightness. It is very much like relaxing in the midst of stretching the body, as in a yoga asana. There is a point where the body starts to resist the stretch, and you feel the tightening. But as you relax and release around the edges of the resistance, there is a sense of opening, and the muscle will begin to give a little. The same is true for your blockages—you are relaxing on the edge of the energy that you're holding inside yourself. The more you relax, the more space there is for that energy to release, because you aren't holding on to it so tightly.

Some blockages can be very strong, and the process of relaxing and releasing needs to be applied every time the blockage gets hit. It could take a while, even years, for a blockage to fully release. But over time, it will continually get weaker and weaker. The more you can simply be okay with the blockage being hit, the less you will care about it one way or another. If you don't care, then how long it takes to go away does not matter because you have already left it for a deeper place within yourself.

5-2

How can I stop storing new samskaras when daily life constantly triggers emotional reactions?

When daily life triggers emotional reactions, the first thing to understand is that you never start by forcing yourself to be someone you're not. The

moment you think, *I should be witnessing, I should be leaning back, I should be relaxed*, you're already making it about expectations—about an image of where you think you're supposed to be. That's not helpful. What's helpful is honestly recognizing what you're experiencing and simply relaxing in its presence. No judgement; just immediately relaxing. That's already a huge step in your growth. That's the doorway to witness consciousness.

Now, can you feel the tendency to get pulled in? That pull is real, and it's very powerful. It's not just an idea—it's an actual force that pulls your consciousness down into it. Instead of fighting it or suppressing it, just notice it. Notice how it comes up and tries to take you with it. That's enough for right now. Just seeing it, and recognizing its pull without immediately reacting to it, is the beginning of the real inner work. You don't have to push it away, and you don't have to go down into it. Just sit in the middle, breathe, and stay as centered as you can. If you fall, fine. Just get back up and try again.

This isn't about suppressing emotions. People often misunderstand that. If an emotion is there, of course you feel it—that's reality. The question is: Are you being pulled down into it, or is it coming up to you? That's the difference. If you let it come up to you, it's still being expressed, but you're not losing yourself in it. You're not feeding it more energy. You're simply letting it arise and release without resistance. That's a very high state, but you don't get there by force—you get there by letting go. This requires the realization that for something to pull on you, you have to be holding on to it. The moment you stop holding on, it starts to release on its own.

Start with the simple stuff. When you feel the pull, don't try to win some big battle—just see if you can stay present for a few minutes without getting lost in it. That's it. If you can do two minutes, you can do three. And over time, something amazing happens; you stop getting caught, and those samskaras begin to lose their grip. But don't force it—let it happen naturally. Just keep relaxing and releasing and you will be amazed by the inner changes.

5-3

How do I release pain from my heart? Breathing and releasing doesn't seem to work for me. I am not sure how to let go of emotional pain.

First, please understand that there is a real difference between wanting the pain to stop and wanting to actually release it. Most people think that if they

practice witness consciousness, pain should instantly go away. That is not true. Just as physical pain is not itself the problem, but your body communicating that there is a problem, emotional pain is not itself the problem; it's just your heart telling you that it has a problem. A wise person doesn't want to just stop the pain; they want to get rid of the underlying problem altogether, so the pain is gone for good.

The first step in dealing with emotional pain is to change your relationship with your heart. Begin by thanking your heart for communicating that it's having a problem with something. This is a means of accepting the pain and not trying to push it away. Once you have come into acceptance of the pain, you can focus on the cause of the pain. In just about every situation, you will find that the pain in your heart is due to a disturbing past situation that you suppressed, a *samskara*. You didn't want to feel the discomfort pass through you, so you pushed it away with your power of will. This caused it to be stored in the heart, which blocked the energy flow through the heart. Inevitably, the *samskara* will attempt to resurface again and again, and it gets pushed back down each time because of the pain and difficulty it elicits.

To work with the *samskara*, you must learn to relax in the face of the heart's release of pain. You can start by talking to the heart and welcoming the release, or by thinking about the advantage of finally getting all this junk out of you. What matters is that you are not pushing the pain back down. This act of acceptance will create the room needed to allow the cause of the pain to release. Eventually, you will welcome the pain because it is the doorway that leads to inner freedom.

The key is to accept the pain in the heart as a messenger that something is wrong. Treat your heart with compassion and caring, as you would a child in your care. Be willing to let the pain pass so that you can come face-to-face with the problem itself. This is what's meant by working with the heart directly. You do not need the thoughts of the mind in order to solve the problems of the heart. The heart wants to purify itself, but you won't let it because you are afraid of the process. The greatest gift you can give yourself is to learn to become comfortable with the experience of the heart purifying. In time, the heart will thank you by singing beautiful songs of love and joy to you—all the time, unconditionally.

5-4**Can I let go without understanding what the blockage is?**

It is certainly possible to let go of a samskara without knowing specifically what it is or why you stored it. A samskara is simply blocked energy. When it comes up, you can relax and release without having to mentally process it. You are simply letting go of the disturbance without getting the mind involved with the “who,” “what,” “why,” and “when.”

Of course, it is certainly okay to know what the samskara is and why you stored it, but you don’t have to. You will find, as you let go of more and more of your blockages, the mind will become comfortable with the process and will no longer need to understand it all. In the end, you are not just letting go of the samskara around the specific past event—you are letting go of your inability to handle the disturbance caused by the cleansing process. Once you are comfortable relaxing through that level of discomfort, you will be able to handle discomfort of that level with all new and old situations.

5-5**How does letting go relate to discomfort and growth?**

When you sit with discomfort, what you’re really doing is facing the parts of yourself that you’ve spent your whole life pushing away. That vibration you feel—that subtle, uncomfortable energy—has always been there beneath the surface. You’re usually just too busy distracting yourself to notice it. The moment you stop and allow yourself to feel it, you begin to see how much effort you’ve been putting into resisting it.

The key is to stop pushing it away. When you let go, you’ll see that what was once unbearable can’t actually hurt you—it’s just energy passing through. The discomfort only feels overwhelming because you’re resisting it. If you stop resisting, it will rise up, get closer to your consciousness, and then pass through. That’s what real growth is. It’s not about getting rid of discomfort; it’s about learning to relax through it.

At first, it’s very scary not to protect yourself from the energy release. You’ll feel fear, but instead of running from it, you learn to let it be. There is nothing physically touching you that can hurt you. Learn to see it as just inner energy vibrating at an uncomfortable rate. Truth is, you feel shifts in

your energy flow almost every moment of your life. You just don't pay attention unless it's strong enough to distract you from what you are doing. Every time you feel this discomfort—whether it's frustration, fear, or pain—you have a choice: you can push it away and keep it buried, or you can say, "Come up. I want to see what's really down there." If you do that, something incredible will happen: the fear will lose its grip, and you'll begin to feel lighter.

That's how you grow. You don't grow by avoiding discomfort—you grow by getting comfortable with it. The more you let go, the more life opens up for you. Instead of living in fear of what might come up, you become willing to face anything. You realize that no matter what happens, you'll be okay, because you're no longer controlled by the things you once pushed away. Now you are on the path to total freedom.

5-6

What personal approach do you take when releasing samskaras?

There are many techniques for releasing samskaras. I am a naturopath in most things, so that is the path I follow with samskaras. My experience is that they will come up by themselves when they are ripe to be released. The question is: Are you willing to let them go when they come up? Since they were generally stored with pain, they will come back up with pain. You have to be willing to handle the disturbance they create without pushing them back down. If you keep your inner hands off them, in time they will release the energy they need to release and then fade away. When they are permitted to pass through, their energy is free to continue its journey through the universe.

The only reason the samskaras got stuck in you is because you resisted their passing through. Once you can let them go, they have no reason to stay inside you. Over time, you will realize that less samskaras means more flow of the energy known as *shakti*—more love, more passion for life, more inspiration, and a closer walk with Spirit. Eventually, you will learn to enjoy the disturbance samskaras create when they pass through, because it is "the pain that ends all pain."

How does one withstand the pain of an activated samskara? Relax and release. Just like in a yoga asana, or during a deep massage, relax through the tendency to resist. The only difference is that with a samskara, the entire dance is inside. The moment you feel the energy get weird inside, let go,

relax, and lean away from where you see the disturbed energy. Over time, this simple technique of relaxing and releasing will allow room for the samskaras to release on their own. And please don't put any new ones in! Relax and release through the issues of today that previously would have gotten stuck in you. Do it right then and there, the moment the resistance starts. Don't wait for even a moment—it will just get harder to let go as each moment passes.

Try to put aside fifteen minutes in the morning and fifteen minutes in the evening to clean out. Start the day clean; don't bring stuck stuff from yesterday into today. Then finish the day with nothing new inside. If you want to call this meditation, that's fine, but relentlessly let go of whatever comes up. And don't limit this to your time on the meditation pillow or yoga mat; do it every moment of every day. That's how you let go of samskaras—you let them go! If you do this, in time, a beautiful flow of upward energy will arise within you. It will feed you from inside every moment of your life. You will become whole and complete—self-effulgent. This is the awakened shakti. It will draw you into it and take you the rest of the way home.

5-7

How do I tell if worrisome thoughts in my mind are just samskaras resurfacing or are valid instinctual reactions to a situation?

Instinct is very separate from the mind. When letting go of the personal mind, you do not have to worry that you won't experience instinctual responses. If a semitruck is approaching and you are out walking in the middle of the road, you do not need your mind to tell you that you had better get out of the way. Instinct is very quick and direct—you will run first and think about it later. The basic survival instinct is quite independent of the personal mind.

Where people have trouble is when their past stored experiences, their samskaras, end up creating responses that are not instinctual, but driven by the samskara itself. Because the emotional response is so quick and strong, it can feel like instinct, but it really is the energy of the samskara getting hit. For example, let's say you had a job when you were in your twenties, and the only time you were ever called in to speak with your boss privately, you got fired. You resisted the experience, and it got stored within you. Now, years later, you are doing great with your current job, and you are called in to talk with your boss. That meeting could be about anything, but the stored experience

naturally gets hit, and you get this feeling of anxiety. Your mind tells you, *I don't know, something doesn't feel quite right about this. Maybe I better not have this meeting.* This is not an instinctual response that is warning you—it is your stuff getting hit.

Because most of our reactions are driven by samskaras, any time you are not sure if you're listening to your personal mind or instinct, it is always better to first let go of your inner reaction. Let go of the fear and anxiety as much as you can, and don't let it drive your actions. You don't have to find your "real self" to know what to do. Just let go inside, and be willing to let life show you what is needed in every situation. Things will unfold, and if you are not acting out of reaction, what is being asked of you will become very clear.

5-8

How can I work with strong physical sensations, like a racing heart, that occur during intense triggers?

When a strong physical sensation arises because a samskara is triggered, the first thing to understand is that it has the right to be there. Just like when you stub your toe and it naturally hurts, when energy that has been stuck inside of you gets activated, it naturally causes turbulence. That's all that is happening. The energy is hitting a blockage, and the body is responding. The problem isn't that it's happening; the problem is that you don't want it to happen.

Instead of resisting, try something different—welcome it. Just like you would comfort a scared child, you can hold space for this energy: "It's okay. You're safe. Come on up." You don't need to fight with it or make it go away. Let it express itself without pulling you down into it. The moment you resist, you give it more power. If you simply relax, breathe, and allow it to pass through, it won't stay.

You don't need to understand why it's happening. You don't need to analyze where it came from. Just let go of the part of you that wants to control it. It's just energy moving. The less you interfere, the more it will release on its own. Over time, as you keep welcoming these experiences instead of resisting them, you'll notice they lose their grip on you. They come, they pass, and you remain untouched.

That's your practice. You don't need to do anything but stay aware, breathe, and relax. Let the energy do what it needs to do, and you'll see—it will pass right through you.

5-9

If I have a positive experience, how do I prevent it from getting stuck and keep moving forward? What is the best way to deal with positive samskaras?

If you have a positive experience, the first thing to understand is that you don't have to worry about it getting stuck. From the highest perspective, you want to let everything go so you can be fully present and clear in the moment. But you're not there yet, and that's okay. For now, it's enough to focus on letting go of the negative samskaras—don't complicate your growth by worrying about whether a positive experience is sticking.

If a positive experience uplifts you, raises your energy, and helps you let go of something, then great—enjoy it. There's nothing wrong with appreciating a beautiful moment. Where you have to be careful is when you start craving to have it again. If you get attached to a positive experience, and start manipulating situations or people in order to recreate it, then you've turned it into something that can actually cause disappointment and suffering. That's when a positive experience can hold you back instead of moving you forward.

Just say thank you. You had a beautiful experience in which something aligned with your preferences: wonderful. Appreciate it, acknowledge it, and then move on. If you cling to it, you block yourself from what's next. If you can simply be grateful and keep going forward, life will continue to bring you more.

Ultimately, you will see that if you hold on too tightly to one positive experience, you close yourself off to the next one. For all you know, the next one might be even more profound. If you're open, everything becomes a positive experience. The key is to stay in the flow of life—always letting go, always moving forward.





CHAPTER 6

Desires and Preferences

You walk through life with a constant whisper inside, telling you what you want and what you don't want—what should happen and what shouldn't. These desires and preferences feel so personal, so justified, but they're actually just the residue of past experiences stored inside of you. You think you're choosing them, but in truth, they're choosing you. The more you listen to them, the more your life becomes a struggle to make reality match your inner needs. But what if you didn't have to do that to be okay? What if you could let go of the need for things to be a certain way—and still be completely okay inside? That's where real freedom begins. In this chapter, we'll explore your questions about what it means to watch your preferences without letting them define you, and how to shift from a life of grasping to a life of peace.

6-1

How do I deal with recurring preferences and their root causes?

Preferences are the surface manifestation of deeper blockages and attachments. When a preference arises, whether for something or against it, acknowledge the preference with a sense of curiosity. Allow it to surface without suppressing or indulging it. This will allow you to look past the preference itself and be able to see its source. The source of your preferences is that your natural energy flow is blocked, causing you to need something outside yourself to compensate. In essence, preferences are the attempted solution for making you okay.

So, when preferences arise, accept them without trying to analyze or suppress them. Practice observing preferences without acting on them, and try to consciously relax in the face of the discomfort they may bring. Over time, as you practice welcoming preferences in this way, their deeper roots,

which were implanted in the past, will naturally come up and dissolve. Each moment of release brings you closer to your authentic self, unburdened by external dependencies.

6-2

How do I handle anger and preferences when I'm unhappy with someone's behavior?

If you find yourself getting disturbed by someone's behavior—whether it's a coworker, a boss, or anyone else—you have to start by looking inside. Don't start by blaming them. Start by asking yourself, *Why can't I handle this?* The other person is being who they are, acting out of their own patterns and conditioning, just like you are. The real question is: Why is this bothering you? What inside of you is reacting negatively to their behavior? If you don't ask that question, you'll end up jumping from one situation to another—new jobs, new relationships—always hoping the outer world will change so you can finally be okay. But it won't. Life is going to keep putting these things in front of you until you decide to work on what's happening inside.

If you want to use the situation to grow spiritually, you can start practicing letting go of the part of you that gets disturbed. This isn't about pretending to be okay—it's about genuinely working with yourself so that you don't get thrown off by every little thing. If you can't handle the driver in front of you, how are you going to handle a difficult coworker? If you can't handle your coworker, how are you going to handle your partner, your kids, or your family? Every situation that disturbs you is a chance to grow, to see what's inside you that's resisting reality. The truth is that life is not going to stop being life just because you want it to be different. The real work is inside.

Does that mean you should stay in a job or relationship that isn't right for you? Not necessarily. But before you make any decisions, you need to own what's happening inside of you. If you leave just because you can't handle the situation, life is going to bring the same lesson back around in another form. Instead of running, start by working with yourself. Let go of the need for things to be a certain way for you to be okay. If you want true strength, practice facing the little things now.

Ultimately, the question is: Do you want to grow? If you always insist that life must conform to your preferences, you will spend your whole life struggling. If you're willing to use every disturbance as a way to release what's holding you back, you will find real freedom. The highest spiritual masters don't avoid life—they embrace it fully because they are no longer resisting it. If you want to handle difficult situations, start by letting go of the part of you that can't handle them. That's the real work, and if you do it, you will see that all of life can be used for your awakening.

6-3

How do I let go of my preferences and opinions without denying my individuality?

You don't have to deny your preferences or opinions, but you do have to learn how to relate to them correctly. There are many different aspects of your being. There's your body, emotions, and thoughts—and then there is you, the consciousness that is aware of all of these. The mistake is thinking that your preferences define you. They do not. They are simply conditioned responses based on past experiences, just like Pavlov's dogs salivating at a bell. You had an experience, it got stored inside, and now that past impression is shaping how you react. The question is not whether you have preferences—the question is, what do you do with them?

If a preference arises, neither suppress it nor blindly follow it. Simply notice it. If someone offers you two foods, one that always upsets your stomach and another that you love, of course you'll have a preference. That's fine. But if you're starving and someone offers you food you're unfamiliar with, do you let your preference stop you from eating? That's the difference. You don't let preference control you; you use wisdom to make decisions in spite of your preferences, not because of them.

If a strong preference or opinion arises, sit back and observe. Watch the part of you that insists, "I want this" or "I don't want that." See it for what it is—just a pattern playing out. If you cling to it, it owns you. If you fight it, it owns you. Instead, let it pass through, and allow life to unfold beyond the limits of your personal conditioning. When you stop letting preference dictate your actions, you don't lose yourself—you free yourself.

6-4

Aren't there some preferences that are universal? For example, who wants to get a terminal illness? If something like that happens, how do we deal with it spiritually?

If you have a terminal illness, it has nothing to do with preference. It's not always easy to accept, but you need to come to terms with the fact that the body is ill and is going to pass fairly soon. Either you do not accept that fact, which will cause more psychological suffering on top of the physical issues, or you do your best to let go of the inner resistance and work to find peace in your final days. That is using the situation for your spiritual growth.

On the other hand, if you do not have a terminal illness, but your mind is causing suffering because of the possibility that you might get one, this is where your preference is causing unnecessary suffering. In this situation, look inside and see why you would do such a destructive thing. Nothing is wrong, but since you don't want it to be wrong later, you suffer now. In other words, life is not doing this to you; you are doing this to yourself. You need to look deeper and see why your mind would do such a thing.

What you will see is that you are blocked due to past experiences that you have held inside. These blockages are preventing your natural energy flow and leaving you weak and worried about your future. If you remove these underlying blockages, you will be filled with energy and strength, and experience great love and inspiration. When that is your inner state, there are no desires or fears—you are too filled with deep contentment, no matter what is happening. You know that you can handle whatever happens, so why worry about it?

Learn to embrace life and participate in her events with acceptance, passion, and the love of getting to experience your years on the planet. Please don't ruin your life because it doesn't match your preference system.

6-5

You teach about how our personal preferences can distort reality. What about our personal values? Do values serve a purpose in one's spiritual journey, or are they also just preferences?

Your question shows that you have a very good objective understanding of the concepts formed in your mind and heart. We are programmed by our environment. If you grew up in a culture that lived off hunting, you would not think anything about eating meat. If you grew up in one of Gandhi's ashrams, you would find the killing and eating of animals immoral. Furthermore, you would not hold these values just for yourself; you would use them to judge others as well.

Since we all have had different life experiences, it is natural that we have different values. But surely there are some universal values that are right for everyone. For example, the First Commandment says: *Thou shalt not kill*. Still, we humans have found many exceptions to that divine commandment. We kill in "righteous" wars (for instance, working to stop Hitler), we execute prisoners, and so on. No matter what your values are, surely not everyone agrees with them.

So how do you live a life without values? You don't. You have values, just as you have a body, a mind, and a heart. Spirituality is not about living a life without these, nor is it about living life without values. It is natural that you have formed values over the course of your life, and they can change based on new experiences. Accept that this is going to naturally happen, but also accept that others have formed different values they feel just as strongly about as you do yours. That is the key to growing beyond your personal self. You have a personal self, but you can objectively transcend the concept that your view of things is right. It is just your personal view, and others see things differently. Strive to be the one that understands why there are these differences, accepts their reality, and works to bring harmony.

By all means, live and work for your values, but be open to others. Do not let your values cause your heart to close to the rest of the world.

6-6

What is your take on striving to satisfy your preferences?

There is a natural harmony in all of life. Every aspect of life serves the whole. Plants grow out of soil, water, and sunlight, and animals eat the plants, and when they die, their bodies go back to the soil. Everything is serving the cycle of creation. When we are in harmony with the whole, serving the moments presented before us, we are doing our part in life. It is called doing our dharma, and it is also referred to as being in the Tao. Participating in this harmony calls on us to use our bodies, our minds, and the inspiration and creativity from our hearts. When we live that way, we are in harmony with life, and we evolve through the experiences we have.

When we get personally blocked because we are unwilling to accept the flow of life as it passes before us, we bring disturbance into our world. To be able to handle this inner disturbance, we use our minds to try to figure out what needs to happen that will make us feel better and not worse. That is what we call our preferences. They are very personal, and they couldn't care less about serving life as it is. They only care about ourselves and the way we want life to be. That is the cause of all wars, inequality, hatred, and prejudice. We all want life to be our way, and we struggle to make it be that way.

As we grow spiritually, we learn to let go of these self-centered thoughts and emotions. As they thin out, so do our personal preferences. More and more, we see what life is asking of us, and we are willing to serve it. We are coming into harmony with the whole. Eventually, that is our only inspiration: to serve creation as it unfolds before us. As our blockages fall off because we are not feeding them, a spontaneous joy wells up inside. This joy is unconditional. It doesn't need things to be a certain way in order to feel love and passion for all of life. Surrender of the personal, and service of the whole, becomes our way of life. In the end, we have attracted to ourselves the highest possible state of being by surrendering our will to the force that is creating everything.

6-7

How can I manage my desire for wealth and the anxiety it brings?

If your mind is constantly striving for wealth and success, and it brings you anxiety and fear, the answer isn't to try to push those thoughts away or suppress them. You need to understand why they are there in the first place. Instead of resisting, ask yourself: *Why do I want wealth so badly? What do I believe it will give me?* The mind doesn't just want things randomly; it wants things because it believes they will solve something. It believes that if you achieve wealth, for instance, you will finally be okay. That's the misunderstanding—you're looking for external wealth to fix internal problems.

There is nothing wrong with wealth itself. Wealth is not the problem. The issue is why you feel you need it. If you think that being rich will give you status, respect, security, or the freedom to do what you want, then the real question is: Why do you feel like you're not okay without these things? The drive for wealth is just a symptom of a deeper insecurity. If you were already whole and at peace, wealth would simply be wealth—something neutral, neither good nor bad. But if you believe it will complete you, then you are setting yourself up for a never-ending chase, because no amount of money will ever be enough to make you feel whole.

Think about it: What happens when people actually become rich? They win the lottery, for example, and suddenly, everyone wants a piece of them. They get tangled in financial concerns, lawsuits, and people treating them like a bank instead of a person. Wealth itself doesn't bring peace—it often brings more things to worry about. What you really want is what you think wealth will give you. You want to feel safe and free from worry. Those feelings don't come from money—they come from achieving unconditional inner peace.

Instead of trying to force yourself to stop desiring wealth, go deeper. Look at the part of you that believes you need it to be okay. Be kind to that part of yourself. Don't reject it or fight it—just observe it with compassion and curiosity. Why is it there? What is it really afraid of? If you work at this level, you will no longer be controlled by the endless pursuit of external things. Instead, you will realize that what you were looking for was never out there in the first place. The peace, security, and wholeness you seek are already inside of you.

6-8

How do I handle my preferences without projecting expectations onto moments?

Preferences are natural. You don't need to deny them or suppress them—they're just there. The real question is: Why do you prefer one thing over another? If you look closely, there's always a reason. Something inside you has determined that one outcome is better than another, and that's fine. But when your preferences start turning into rigid expectations—when you tell life, "I can only be okay if things go my way"—that's when you suffer. The problem is not having preferences; the problem is believing that life must conform to them.

Look at how life actually works. Does it always give you what you want? Of course not. Reality unfolds however it unfolds, and sometimes that aligns with your preferences, and sometimes it doesn't. If you're only happy when things match what you want, you're setting yourself up for a lifetime of struggle. The world is not going to mold itself around your desires. The key is to recognize your preferences but not demand that they be fulfilled. If you do that, you will find that you are open to a much wider range of experiences, and life becomes a lot easier.

One thing you can do with your preferences is instead of getting rid of them, expand them. What if you learned to prefer everything? If you train yourself to embrace whatever happens, then suddenly, you're free. If the driver in front of you is slow, instead of resisting and getting frustrated, just prefer the opportunity to slow down for a moment. If you get criticized at work, instead of getting upset, be excited for the opportunity to improve yourself. When you approach life in this way, you are not getting rid of preferences—you are expanding them to include the miracle of life as it is.

Ultimately, reality always wins. It doesn't care about your preferences. The sooner you align yourself with what is, instead of what you think should be, the more peace you will feel inside. So, please, don't fight with your preferences, and don't fight with life. Let them both be, and just watch. You'll start to see that you don't have to control everything to be okay. You're already okay—life is just unfolding, and you're simply here to experience it.

Resistance and Acceptance

Life is going to do what life does. It will bring pleasure and pain, joy and loss, comfort and discomfort. You don't get to decide what shows up at your doorstep, but you do get to decide whether you're open or closed inside. Resistance is what closes you. It's what tightens your body, shuts your heart, and clouds your mind. Acceptance, on the other hand, is not passivity—it's the deepest strength you can live from. It means relaxing into the reality of the moment as it is, not because you like it, but because fighting with it only makes it worse. In this chapter, we'll explore your questions about how to stop pushing against life and start letting it pass through you, so you can walk through both the beautiful and the difficult with a heart that remains free.

7-1

How can I not feel resistance during tragic events?

When you are faced with a tragic event, the first thing you must understand is that resistance will only make it worse. If you fight against reality, if you resist what's happening, all you are doing is adding unnecessary suffering on top of an already difficult situation. But if you accept what is unfolding—not out of weakness, but out of a deep understanding that this is the nature of life—you will find you can move through even the hardest experiences with grace. You are here to grow, and every experience, no matter how painful, is part of that growth.

Truth is, you don't know how you'll handle extreme situations until you are in them. But don't doubt that you are capable. You are not the body, and you are not the mind's reactions to what is happening. You are the one who is aware of all of it. Just like a light shining on an object doesn't break when the object breaks, your consciousness remains untouched by the events

happening around you. The more you meditate and work on letting go, the more you will come to know this directly—not as a belief, but as a reality you have lived.

Look at the great beings who have walked this earth—people like Gandhi. He was shot while giving a peaceful speech, and as he fell to the ground, he bowed in forgiveness. It is possible to be so free inside that even in the most extreme moments, there is peace. That's not just an idea—it's a state of being that a human being can reach. Will you reach that state? Who knows? But don't assume you can't. The depth of who you are is beyond anything the mind can comprehend.

When life challenges you, meet it with openness. If it is time to act, act with clarity. If there is nothing you can do, then surrender fully, knowing that your growth is happening in real time. You will find that even in the most difficult moments, there is a space inside of you that remains untouched. That space is where true peace lies.

7-2

Why do we store bad experiences, and how can we let them go?

When an experience happens, it should naturally move through you and get stored in your long-term memory, just like a computer saves data. But sometimes, you don't store it cleanly. Instead, you resist the experience, or you cling to it, and that resistance or attachment keeps it from passing all the way through. Now, instead of just being a memory, it becomes something more—it carries emotional weight, and it stays active inside of you. That's what a *samskara* is: an impression that didn't get stored properly because you either didn't like the experience or liked it too much and didn't want to lose it.

This is why certain experiences seem to keep coming back up on their own. You don't try to remember every random moment of your life, but the ones you resisted, the ones that weren't stored cleanly, those are the ones that keep resurfacing. It's like they're sitting right in front of you, ready to jump back into your awareness at any moment. You could be walking down a street that has nothing to do with the past event, and suddenly—there it is again. That's because you stored it with disturbance instead of neutrality.

How do you let it go? You neutralize it as it arises. When one of these experiences resurfaces, don't resist. Don't push it away or judge it. Just relax

while you let it come up. Let the experience come and go without grabbing on to it, the same way you'd let a passing breeze move through an open window. Over time, if you keep relaxing and not fueling the past impression with more resistance, it will lose its charge. It will simply become a clean memory, like everything else you've experienced but don't obsess over.

Your past doesn't have to control you. What happened, happened. Life includes all kinds of experiences—some pleasant, some painful. You don't have to let them run your life. If you stop resisting, stop holding on to them, they will pass through you, and you will be free.

7-3

Can avoiding difficult situations, instead of having to resist them, be helpful for your spiritual growth?

When you remove yourself from the noise and complexity of the world, there will be fewer things triggering your inner disturbances. Don't mistake that for spiritual growth. You have to understand—peace is not the absence of disturbing situations; it's the ability to remain undisturbed regardless of the situation. If you run away from the world thinking that isolation will free you, you'll find that the mind still finds things to resist. You'll hear a dog barking in the quiet woods, and suddenly, that's the problem. If you are still reacting, then you haven't solved anything—you've just changed the scenery.

The real work is not about avoiding difficult situations; it's about letting go of what gets triggered inside you. You can't grow spiritually by running from what challenges you. You grow by using every situation—whether it's the chaos of a busy city or the solitude of the forest—as an opportunity to let go of the personal mind's reactions. When something disturbs you, that's life showing you exactly where your work is. If you remove yourself from people because they trigger you, then all you've done is delay the inevitable. Eventually, something else will take their place. The only way to truly free yourself is to stop running and start releasing.

Retreating can be helpful, but it's not the whole answer. If you take a break to center yourself, to quiet down and gain clarity, that's fine. But don't think that quieting the external world is the same as quieting the inner one. At some point, you will have to return and face life. The real test is whether you can stand in the middle of New York City, surrounded by noise and

chaos, and still feel completely at peace—not because the world changed, but because you did.

Instead of hiding from the things that stir you up, welcome them. When life triggers something inside you, say, “Thank you. Thank you for showing me something I need to let go of.” If your goal is to rise beyond the mind’s limitations, you don’t want to avoid your stuff—you want to be free of it. Freedom only comes when you are no longer controlled by what disturbs you. Let go, surrender, and watch as your consciousness naturally rises. The peace you seek is already inside you—it’s just buried beneath all the things you refuse to release.

7-4

Can the practice of acceptance help one heal physically and emotionally when faced with illness?

When it comes to healing, the first thing you have to do is accept what is happening. If you resist, you block the natural flow of energy, and that very resistance creates even more tension and suffering. Healing is not just a physical process—it is deeply tied to your inner state. If you fight against what’s happening, you end up with both a struggling body and a struggling mind. Start by accepting that this is what is happening right now, and it’s okay. That doesn’t mean you don’t take action; you still do what is necessary to seek the best care available. But you stop fighting the reality of the situation within yourself.

Once you stop resisting, you allow the natural intelligence of life to flow through you. Healing is not something you control—it is something you allow. Just like your body has an immune system that knows how to fight off illness, your inner being has a way of working through pain when you don’t interfere. Think about how some people in hospitals heal faster simply because they have the love and support of family and friends around them. That uplifted energy makes a difference. When you relax and open, you create space for that healing energy to do its work.

You also should be willing to find something positive about what you’re going through. No matter what is happening, there is always an opportunity for growth. Maybe this experience is teaching you patience, surrender, or

trust. Maybe it's showing you how much support and love are actually around you. Look for what life is giving you through this, rather than only seeing what it seems to be taking away. This shift in perspective changes everything.

So don't resist. Do what is necessary, but keep your heart open. The energy of healing is always trying to move through you—you just have to let it.

7-5

I've experienced chronic pain for many years. How do I work with illness and pain in the physical body as part of my spiritual practice?

Chronic illness and its accompanying physical pain is a different experience than the inner discomfort of mental and emotional purification. However, from a spiritual perspective, they are dealt with similarly. Obviously, if you are ill, you do what you can medically to correct the problem causing the pain. Unfortunately, that does not always work. If you are left with physical pain you simply have to live with, you deal with that by letting go. After all, you really have no choice—it's either accept or resist, and resistance makes the physical pain worse, due to the tension it creates in the body. Resistance also causes a disturbed mind and uncomfortable emotions. Now you have two problems—outside and inside. It is important to come to peace inwardly and not allow the state of the body to determine the quality of your inner life.

Acceptance means you do your best to relax through the pain. Just like when doing a yoga asana, you relax through any tension. It is not easy or pleasant, but in time, you learn to transcend the intensity of the physical discomfort. Next, you always pay attention to what part of you is experiencing the pain. You are witnessing that the body feels pain, but who are you back in there aware that the body is sending you these messages? The Self, the awareness of being, has no pain—it is experiencing the pain that the body is generating. If you can relax and center on who's aware of the pain, instead of getting lost in it, you can actually use the pain to free yourself.

Obviously, nobody said this is going to be easy. But since you asked how to deal with chronic pain spiritually, this is the answer—use it for self-realization.

7-6

Is it normal to feel constant stress even while relaxing and releasing? I want to make sure I am not suppressing instead of actually letting go.

It is important to understand that while we are growing, situations will arise that are difficult for us to accept. During these situations, we have the tendency to resist. Resistance causes physical, emotional, and mental stress. What can we do about this?

The answer is to relax. Relaxation is the opposite of stress. If you do your best to relax when you feel the tendency to resist and close, over time you will find this reduces your level of stress about the situation. When you deeply relax inside, you will be able to lean away from the inner energy that you are wanting to resist. It's not easy, but once you are committed to relaxing instead of resisting, you will feel a separation between your sense of awareness and the energy trying to pass through. You will clearly see that you are not comfortable with this energy and that is why you are almost instinctually resisting it. Once you achieve this separation between your awareness and the energy coming at you, you will have an opportunity to lean away from the energy and let it pass by.

As an analogy, let's say you are facing a strong wind blowing in your face. You don't like it, so you pick up a sheet of plywood and hold it up against the wind to protect yourself. That will create tremendous stress trying to fight the wind. You do have another choice for how to deal with the wind in your face: you can let down the plywood, relax, lean backwards, and allow the wind to blow past you. That is what is meant by not resisting the force that is trying to pass through—just let it pass.

This is a very high technique for releasing blockages. Don't feel that you should be able to succeed at this right away or under all circumstances. It takes practice with lots of low-hanging fruit in order to develop the ability to do this under strong winds. But every little effort moves you in the right direction. Just do your best to let go instead of resisting, and you will be growing spiritually.

Surrender

Surrender isn't about giving up—it's about getting out of the way. You've spent your whole life trying to control how things unfold, trying to fix the outside world so you can finally feel okay inside. But what if the freedom you seek doesn't come from changing life, but from letting go of the part of you that's always fighting with it? True surrender means letting go of the personal self that resists, reacts, and tries to run the show. It means trusting that life knows what it's doing, and that you'll be okay no matter what happens. In this chapter, we'll explore your questions about what it really means to surrender—not in theory, but in the raw, honest moments of life—so you can finally begin to live from a place of peace, clarity, and flow.

8-1

Are acceptance and surrender the same thing?

Your question is very deep. The simplest answer would be yes: acceptance and surrender are the same thing. But there really is an important difference. If an event happens and you feel resistance to it, you can simply tell yourself to accept it because it is out of your control. That is acceptance. If it is a major event, like your partner leaving you, you will go through a lot of pain in your heart, but ultimately you will have to accept that the relationship is over.

Surrender goes much deeper. Surrender means not only accepting the pain of the situation, but also releasing the root cause of your resistance—the underlying *samskara*. If you are to surrender to the experience of your partner leaving you, you are not just letting go of the relationship (as if you have a choice); you are also surrendering the part of you that wants to resist. Acceptance says, “I want to resist, but I will not express that outwardly. I will accept the reality of the situation.” Surrender says, “I want to let go of any

part of me that wants to resist. My life is about letting go of what I am watching inside myself, not just letting go of what is happening outside.”

In the end, acceptance can be a strictly mental rationalization process. But surrender is the indwelling witness willingly letting go of what is pulling it into inner turmoil. It is the Self relaxing and releasing through all that is happening inside. Acceptance makes life more tolerable; surrender makes life a spiritual experience. I hope this helps you learn to let go at the deepest levels.

8-2

How can I practice surrender when faced with personal struggles and negativity?

When you talk about surrender, understand that you’re not surrendering to some external force or giving up on life. You’re surrendering the part of you that is struggling—the part of your mind that is constantly trying to control everything to be the way it wants. That mind is always disturbed about one thing or another. It holds on to past painful experiences and reacts to life based on those impressions. If it truly knew what to do to end its suffering, it would just do it. Real surrender means letting go of that part of you and allowing something greater to guide you.

Look at the deepest spiritual beings throughout time—the ones who have merged completely into the flow of life and found the deepest peace. They didn’t get there by controlling everything; they got there by releasing themselves into something much bigger than their personal mind. They let go; they allowed life to unfold as it naturally does, and in doing so, they merged with the great oneness that is always there. You don’t have to fight with life. You don’t have to resist what’s happening. You simply need to step back, watch your mind trying to grasp for control, and say to it, “It’s okay. You don’t have to do this anymore.”

That’s what true surrender is. It’s the willingness to let go of the struggle to make everything be the way you think it should be, and instead, trust life. Not in a passive way, not in a way where you do nothing, but in a way where you stop interfering with the natural flow of life. The more you let go, the more you’ll feel a deep sense of peace arising within you. At some point, you will realize this peace has always been there—it was just buried under all the resistance.

When you're faced with personal struggles and negativity arises, don't suppress it and don't fight it. Just step back, watch it, and let it pass through. You are not your thoughts. You are not your emotions. You are the one who is aware of them. The deeper you go into that awareness, the more you will understand what it truly means to surrender.

8-3

If someone at work bullies me, does surrender mean I just let it happen? Is speaking up for myself or avoiding them outside of work a form of suppression?

The teachings of surrender are not about letting yourself become a doormat for the inappropriate behavior of others. Surrender is about letting go of your reactive response and then dealing with things from a place of clarity and logic. It's all about your intent. If you are letting go sincerely, and circumstances are such that you need to assert yourself with your coworker, first let go of your reactive energies, then interact from a place of clarity. This is not suppression.

Choosing not to interact with a coworker outside of your work assignments is not suppression either. But if you are avoiding someone because you can't handle how they make you feel inside, then work on yourself to let go so that you aren't avoiding out of reaction. If you choose to avoid them, let it be out of sincerely seeking the best overall solution to the situation. This is not setting personal boundaries, which is just protecting your ego; it is consciously working to bring the highest peace possible for both parties.

8-4

How do I know when to act in a situation and when to surrender action? In *The Surrender Experiment*, you fought having a construction dump built in your neighborhood. How did you know that you should act to stop it?

Your question is very beautiful and is one that many people struggle with, because the teaching is so subtle. When you walk the path of surrender, it will look as though you are living in the world and acting out of the same motivations as others. But the motivation is not the same, because you are not

trying to get something or avoid something; you are trying to be a servant of the situation.

When you let go of your personal preferences, that doesn't mean you won't end up having a role to play in a situation. The difference is that you first let go of your personal reactions, then simply listen to life for guidance on whether there is anything you can do to serve. You then follow life's flow and participate. In this way, your participation is not motivated by personal preference, but by the intention to intelligently serve the situation and raise it to the highest possible level.

In the case of the garbage dump, it was a matter of letting go of preferences and listening to life for guidance. Because the Temple was the largest landowner in the area, all the neighbors were asking the Temple for help to stop the dump. We served the situation to the best of our ability. And because we were willing to play the role life gave us with impersonal clarity, life was able to unfold to the amazing results you read about in the book.

When you are present and open, life unfolds, and you will naturally have a role to serve it, rather than trying to make it serve you. You become a servant of the present moment, and your only goal is to make sure that every moment that passes before you is better off because it did.

8-5

I want to live in accordance with *The Surrender Experiment*. But I can't say yes to every opportunity—there are too many. How do I choose without relying on my personal preferences?

Surrender is a very deep subject, and it is something that matures as you practice. Surrender is not about doing or not doing—it is about letting go of the lower aspects of yourself.

Behind everything we do, there are motives. Some are normal physiological drives for food, clothing, and shelter. But nowadays, most of our motives are psychologically based. "I'm lonely, I want to find someone." "I feel awkward, I want to feel more self-confident." "I need more money so that I can do the things that I like." These are not necessities; they are attempts to compensate for the psychological lack we feel inside. There is nothing inherently wrong with this, but it limits us to a life of struggling to be okay. If you

are working for the part of your being that is not well, you will never really get free. There will always be something inside that is bothering you.

In a nutshell, surrender means letting go of that personal part of your being, instead of serving it. You set a higher motive than just trying to be okay. Serving others is a higher motive, but you can't really devote yourself to serving if you are constantly bothered by a sense of lack inside. So, you decide to devote your life to letting go of your lower self in order to experience and express a higher part of your being. You look and see where you are coming from and try to come from the highest place you can see. If you do this constantly, with everything, little by little you will find the beauty and greatness of freeing yourself from yourself. Once the lower, personal, psychological motives fall off, what is left is a very great being, filled with love, joy, and constant inspiration and clarity.

What about all these opportunities that are presenting themselves to you? Instead of getting stressed about choices, try to be aware of the underlying motives that are causing all the stress. Fear of loss and desire for gain cause quite a commotion inside. Once you can stand in the midst of the ever-changing world passing before you, and remain centered, quiet, and still, you will see a path that looks higher and purer than the rest. Follow that, and don't think about the choice ever again. Make it the right choice by doing your best and never second-guessing yourself. Fully embrace and honor the results that follow—learn from them and grow into something great. This is how a great person lives, and simply living such a life leads to the highest state, outside and in. And remember: everything is fine, as long as you are fine within.

8-6

How can I tell if the urge to create is coming from an ego-driven desire or a state of surrender to something greater?

To know if the urge to create is coming from ego or something spiritual, you need to look deeply at what's actually happening inside of you. You are not just some small person trying to make things happen—you are the conscious awareness watching all of this. And that same conscious awareness is the creative force behind the entire universe. What gets in the way is the personal self—the ego. If you're creating because you want something for yourself, to

build an identity and get recognition, then that is ego. That's you trying to manipulate life to fit your personal desires.

In contrast, if you don't let your personal thoughts and emotions interfere, the creative force will still flow, but now it won't be about you. It will simply be an expression of the energy of life itself. The problem is that most people don't trust life enough to let it happen that way. Instead, they grasp at things, try to control outcomes, and get attached to what they create. That's when the ego takes something natural and turns it into something personal. You have to be very honest with yourself: Are you creating because something is naturally flowing through you, or because you are trying to make something happen for yourself?

If you truly let go, then creativity will happen—but it won't be for you. It will simply be the divine energy moving through an open channel. Ironically, when you stop trying to create for ego, what comes through is far more beautiful and powerful than anything you could have come up with by yourself. Your only job is to step aside. You're going to see that creative expression doesn't need you in order to happen. It's already happening outside and in. You just need to stop blocking it.

8-7

In your life of surrender, what role did trust play?

Let me explain trust differently than we normally think of it. To begin with, trust is not simply about trusting people you're interacting with. When you do that, what you're really doing is trusting they will behave the way you expect, and that is your ego protecting itself. Real trust is at a much deeper level.

Spiritually, there are two fundamental types of trust. First, the trust that life will unfold exactly as it's meant to, not according to your will, but according to all the forces that create reality. Second, the trust that no matter what happens, you will be able to handle it. Those are the kinds of trust that define your life. They go far beyond simply trusting individuals to act a certain way. Because, as life has shown all of us, sometimes people do not act as expected. Trusting people to act a certain way is conditional trust. Unconditional trust is at a whole other level, and it leads to the peace that passeth all understanding.

8-8

When is it appropriate to take action in difficult situations, as opposed to letting go?

Choosing whether to take action in a difficult situation requires first asking yourself whether there is anything personal involved. You can always tell the difference between personal and impersonal. If there's any sense of "I," "me," or "mine" in what you're about to do, or if you're thinking things like, *I don't like what they said to me, and I need to make sure they understand why*, then it's personal. If it's personal, it means you are acting from a place of ego, and that's exactly what you're trying to let go of.

Your mind will try to justify action in these moments by saying it's for the good of the situation or the other person. You have to be brutally honest with yourself—are you really acting for the benefit of the situation, or are you acting for yourself? Are you trying to fix something outside so you don't have to feel uncomfortable inside? If you are, then the answer is simple: let go. Use that moment to release the part of you that wants to control, defend, or prove something. You don't suppress ego, and you don't push it away—you simply relax and let it pass through you.

Letting go doesn't mean there aren't times to act. You just don't act from personal reaction. You wait until you have let go of yourself by relaxing behind your inner disturbance. When you are truly quiet inside—when your sense of "I" has relaxed—then and only then can you look at the situation with clarity. In that clarity, you ask, "Is there something I can do here that would serve the moment, not serve me?" Most of the time, when you get to this place, you'll find there is nothing you need to do. The whole situation resolves itself simply because you are no longer caught up in it.

Sometimes, however, you may find there is a right action to take—not because you need to take it, but because the moment calls for it. When action comes from that place, and is simply the natural flow of the situation, it is effortless. There is no struggle, no resistance, no personal agenda. That is the difference between true right action and reaction. One is born from surrender, the other from resistance. Your entire spiritual path is about learning to let go of resistance. Do it moment by moment, situation by situation, until there is nothing left inside of you that needs the world to be a certain way for you to be okay. You are free inside, and your simple presence serves to set others free.

8-9

You teach that when we let go and surrender, we will feel bliss all the time. How can I be in bliss if someone I love is ill?

Surrender does not mean that when something sad or painful is happening, you will feel happy. Let's take an example of having a child with a serious illness. Of course, if your child is very ill, you won't be laughing and experiencing happiness. It is natural to feel deep pain and concern. The key is to not resist your feelings regarding the situation. Surrender means that you are able to accept the situation as reality and then deal with it from a place of clarity. You cannot help your child or raise the situation if you are not able to accept what is happening.

The work is to let go of your own inner resistance and be willing to experience the natural sadness, fear, and other very human emotions that will arise. Then serve the situation as best as you can to help raise it. This leaves you clear to love your child and compassionately support them through the reality of a difficult illness. The deep growth that comes from letting go at this level will increase your capacity to love and serve in this world. Surrender is a very deep practice. By accepting reality, you discover the beauty and growth to be found in all experiences.

8-10

What is the highest form of surrender?

The highest form of surrender is realizing that the universe is already perfect, unfolding with a divine intelligence beyond anything the mind can comprehend. Yet all we do is get in its way. Our job is not to control life or manifest things according to our personal desires, but to step aside and allow the universal perfection to express itself. True surrender is not about creating outcomes; it's about dissolving the part of our being that thinks it needs to.

When you let go, the energy of life—*shakti*—moves freely, and what is meant to be can unfold. This is not about using surrender as a strategy to get what you want. That's not surrender; that's still ego. Real surrender is when you are willing to completely let go of you—in other words, *to die to be reborn*. It's when you stop using life to get what you want and instead allow life to strip you of everything false so that only truth remains.

How deep do you want to go? Surrender doesn't mean that only good things will happen to you. That's still ego, holding on to control. Real surrender is when you let go so completely that whatever happens—whether pleasant or painful—is just another step toward dissolving the personal self. Every moment is presenting you with opportunities to let go. The more you surrender, the more space there is for God, for truth, for the unfolding of the divine. That is the highest state. That is what surrender is all about.



WALKING THE PATH





Letting Go

Letting go is not something you figure out—it's something you do. Every day, life pushes your buttons. Thoughts arise, emotions stir, and your whole being tightens in resistance. But what if you relaxed, instead of reacting? What if you leaned away from the disturbance rather than into it? Letting go is the simple, powerful act of choosing not to hold on—of relaxing in the face of your inner discomfort and giving it the space to pass through. You're not fixing anything or suppressing anything—it's deeper than that. In this chapter, we'll explore your questions about how to stop clinging to the noise inside. And we'll explore how, through this practice of releasing, you can make space for something greater—peace, joy, and the beautiful energy of life itself.

9-1

A major technique in *The Untethered Soul* is learning to let go. Do any of your teachings give a simple description of how to implement this practice?

Letting go is simply the act of relaxing in the face of your inner reactive energy and then leaning back, away from the pull of the reaction. The tendency is to come forward and deal with the disturbance. Instead, just relax your shoulders, relax your heart, and relax your abdominal area. You do this instead of engaging with the thoughts and emotions.

If you do this, you will see that the distance between you and the reaction increases, and you will find yourself farther back behind it all. You will still feel the pull of the reaction's energy, but you will learn to relax and lean away from that pull. Keep in mind these are just words trying to describe the inner experience of letting go. Once you practice this and see the shift in your position in relation to the reactive energy, you can use your own words.

Perhaps this will help: don't use will to resist the energy coming up; use it to relax and allow the energy to pass.

Do your best every single day. Don't judge the process; just trust that by letting go, you are welcoming the release of the disturbances you've stored inside. If you do this constantly, one day you will notice a beautiful energy flow within you. Just keep letting go, and eventually the energy flow will feed you day and night, and you will live in a state of constant joy, love, and ecstasy.

9-2

I try to relax when uncomfortable feelings arise and remind myself to let them go. Is there some clear way to be sure that I have let go correctly instead of suppressing?

There is no "correctly" when it comes to things like letting go. There is only sincerity of intent. If your intent is to relax, let go, and not push discomfort back down, then you are not suppressing. Ego reactions have been down there for a long time; they are not going to go away immediately. The shakti will push up that which you need to deal with at any given moment. Your only job is to intend to let it go and not protect yourself by pushing the difficult feelings away. Anything you can do to keep from pushing the feelings back down is fine. Affirmation, mantra, and the practice of witness consciousness are all appropriate and very helpful in the long run.

Offering your stuff up to the vast Universe, to God, is also a wonderful practice. Offering up is the opposite of pushing back down. Make it a fun game. Enjoy the process of letting go of uncomfortable thoughts and emotions. You don't want them in there, so when they come up, relax and release to the best of your ability. Don't let your mind create a preconceived notion of what letting go is supposed to feel like. Just keep relaxing and releasing. Everything will unfold in its own time. Your job is to stay out of the way. Just relax your heart and stay behind the mind. Breathe slowly and deeply when things get really tough. When your sincere intent is to let go, everything helps, and all of life is your path Home.

9-3

I would really appreciate if you could give me a tip on how to completely release blockages from my life.

The most helpful tip to enable you to completely release things you are holding on to is to start with small things. Let go of the meaningless stuff that upsets you, like when you've misplaced something, or someone is driving too slow in front of you, or you don't like the weather. Practice relaxing and let the annoyances pass through. Notice you are the one that is noticing the disturbance—you are not the disturbance itself. Just relax and let it go. Every single day, practice letting go with the small stuff that bothers you. If you do this, you will find that the more difficult things you've been holding on to will begin to release.

How will you know it is working? You'll begin to notice that things that used to disturb you no longer do so. Because you've become accustomed to releasing inner disturbance, what used to seem so big will begin to feel more like the small stuff. Over time, because you are no longer holding on to disturbance, you will naturally begin to feel more love and openness within.

9-4

I struggle with consistently letting go. I've tried both actively letting go and simply allowing things to happen, but sometimes it doesn't seem to work. I'm not sure I'm doing it correctly.

Thank you for sharing your experience of letting go. To begin with, there is no such thing as "letting go doesn't work." You just can't see the results right away.

When you are learning a sport or how to play an instrument, you know it's not going to happen right away. It takes practice under varying conditions. Perhaps in tennis your forehand is good, but your backhand is weak. Every time you practice your backhand, even if the ball goes into the net, you are improving. Every single ball you hit makes your wrists and arms stronger and improves your hand-eye coordination. *Practice makes perfect.*

The same is true for letting go. Events in the world hit our stuff inside, and this causes discomfort and resistance. If you go with those reactions, you are protecting the very samskaras that got hit. If you endeavor to relax in the face of the inner disturbance, you are allowing room for release of the blocked energies from the past. They will not all pass through right away, and of course you don't feel an upward shift in energy every time you try to let things go. But over time, you will become a more open person, and events will more naturally pass through. Once you become good at letting go of the little everyday situations that disturb you, you will see that larger things from the past can be released when they come up.

Let your intent be to relentlessly let go of whatever hits your stored blockages. Then give the blockages the room they need to release. You do this by constantly relaxing behind the reactive disturbed energies that get created inside. If you do your best at this, and that is by definition the best you can do, you will grow every day. Don't judge the process; just trust that by letting go, you are welcoming the release of what is blocked inside. When enough has been released, you will start to feel the upward flow of the shakti lifting you into a state of unconditional well-being.

9-5

Once we have acknowledged a painful feeling and have relaxed and released, can we shift our attention to something else, or do we have to stay with it until it dissolves?

When you have deeply acknowledged a painful feeling, relaxed around it, and done your best to release any resistance you have toward it, then, yes, you go about your business with daily tasks. You don't have to stay focused on it. Just understand that while you are going about your business, if the feeling comes up strongly again, you should stop for a moment and deeply relax and release, just as you did before. Do this as many times as you need to so that the energy can be released, instead of being suppressed again.

What you don't want to do is push the painful feeling back down because you can't handle it coming up. Always welcome it coming up, and try to be comfortable behind the uncomfortable feeling. You don't have to be fixated on the painful feeling; that does not help it pass. Try to go about your business while giving it the right to release naturally. If you have some

time to be alone with it, deeply relax around it with a sense that the fire you are experiencing is the fire of purification. Learn to love that fire—it will free you over time.

9-6

I have been practicing the teachings for a few years, and they have definitely been working. But some of my blockages seem to keep coming back—what am I doing wrong?

You are doing very well to be willing to look inside and see the blockages that continue to persist. Rather than getting down on yourself, understand that some blockages have been down there a long time, and they will take time to release. Start from where you are, and work on letting go every day. If you forget, don't get discouraged. The minute you see you got lost in negativity, pick yourself back up and let go. Let the path unfold in its own time and let it be an amazing, exciting journey to inner liberation.

One should not think they can learn to do this all at once. It takes time and relentless practice to be able to let go. You start with small things, like the mind's complaints about the weather, or getting uptight about the driver in front of you. Just relax your way through the disturbances the mind and heart are creating. Little by little, it becomes natural to let go instead of causing yourself grief over meaningless things. You will then be able to handle larger disturbances, and eventually you will be able to handle any disturbance. In the end, you will be free of disturbance—even though disturbances can still happen.

Along the way, there are many stages you will go through as the deeper blockages start to release. It is not unusual to go through periods of darkness while the blockages are moving around down there, blocking the energy flow. It's not easy, but the highest technique is to relax behind the darkness, behind the discomfort. Who notices the pit in your stomach? How do you know it's there? Because you are the consciousness experiencing that knot in your stomach. You are not the knot; you are the conscious experiencer of the knot. Be that consciousness and relax. This allows the blockage the room it needs to release. The stuff down there was stored with pain, and it is going to release with pain. Be glad it is coming up; you do not want to live with it for the rest of your life. Be positive about the cleansing. Reach down, scoop up a

handful, and offer it to the vast Universe—to God. Let your mantra be, *I can handle this. I can handle this.* Then relax and relax again. If you do this, the transformation will happen naturally, over time.

9-7

Will letting go address long-held internal blocks that have become part of your self-concept?

If you sincerely want to free yourself from the burdens of your past conditioning, the answer is simple: let go. No matter how long you've carried something inside you—whether it's an old blockage, a belief, or part of your self-concept—if you stop resisting, it will pass through and leave you in a higher state. The only reason these things stay with you is because you're holding on to them. You may not realize it, but deep inside, there's a resistance, a pushing away. That very resistance is what keeps your blockages stored inside.

Look at how the body works. It has an immune system that knows how to heal. If something unhealthy enters, your body does everything in its power to expel it. Your mind works the same way. The reason these old patterns keep surfacing isn't because they're meant to stay with you forever—it's because they're trying to release. But instead of letting them go, what do you do? You push them back down. You get scared and uncomfortable, so you suppress them again, or defend yourself from what caused them to come up. Don't do that. When something arises inside of you, ask yourself a simple question: "Do I want this in there?" If the answer is no, then stop holding on to it.

The truth is, nothing is glued inside of you. There is no flypaper, no superglue—it's just your own will resisting. When something comes up, just relax. Breathe. Let it have space to pass through. This isn't about fighting with your mind or forcing things away. You're not trying to get rid of anything; you're simply letting go of what is already trying to leave. When the pain arises, don't engage with it, don't analyze it, and don't argue with it. Just relax and let it pass. You are not the pain—you are the one who is aware of it. The moment you stop resisting, you'll see how naturally it fades away.

Letting go is not complicated. It's just that you've spent your whole life doing the opposite. You've been taught to grab on to things, to build

an identity around your thoughts and emotions. You don't need to do that anymore. You are a free being—all that's left is to let go of the noisy mind that tells you otherwise.

9-8

How can I tell the difference between surrendering my inner disturbances and suppressing them?

If you are uncomfortable experiencing what your mind or emotions are doing, the tendency is to do something about it. You want to do something that makes it more tolerable. That tendency is at the root of suppression. Because you don't want to experience what is before you, you either push it away (suppression) or use the mind to create thoughts that make it feel better (rationalization). This is dangerous territory, because if you push an experience away now, you will have to keep pushing it away for the rest of your life. It will still be in there, and external events and inner thought patterns will stimulate it to come back up. And even when it's not consciously bothering you, it will be blocking your energy flow. In a similar way, while rationalization can be used to offset difficult feelings, which is better than pushing them away, it leaves you responsible for making sure your rationalizations can withstand the challenges of the real world.

The alternative to all this struggling and long-term suffering is the practice of letting go. You return to the root of the problem: the tendency to resist the mental and emotional disturbances. Thoughts cannot hurt you—they are just thoughts. Emotions cannot hurt you—they are just emotions. It is your resistance to them that causes the problem. Similarly, within reason, wind cannot hurt you. It just blows past you. But if you can't handle that experience, you'll have to buy a 4x8-foot sheet of plywood and hold it up to block the wind. Good luck! Your arms will become tired, and your whole life will be determined by your inability to handle the wind blowing across your face. It is exactly the same with thoughts and emotions. They are passing before you, and if you can let them be, they will pass in their own time. Handled this way, they do not leave scars that burden you for life. They are gone, just like every other event in life comes and goes. That is letting go, and it is totally different from suppression and rationalization. The problem is, we haven't learned how to do it.

The key to letting go is to relax in the face of discomfort. Don't try to make the mind or emotions not feel disturbed. Letting go is not about the disturbance itself—it is about you in there, the one that is experiencing the disturbance. *You* relax. Relax in the face of the disturbance, just as you relax in the face of the wind. No resistance; just deep relaxation. People don't want to do this—they want to fix the disturbance. But letting go allows the space necessary for the energy of the disturbance to pass through without getting stuck inside. Plus, it simultaneously allows the samskara that caused the disturbance to release. This is what it means to let go.

9-9

I have been practicing letting go, but how do I know if the technique is truly working? I feel better momentarily, but my blockages seem to return. I'm having trouble staying motivated.

Thank you for sending your sincere question. There are a number of ways to see that the process is working. First, imagine if you didn't let go of things as they happen—these lower energies would run your life. That is one immediate benefit: you don't allow the lower blockages to completely take over and mess up your external life. It is like breaking a habit—if you repeat the habit every time you have the urge, you are reinforcing the behavior pattern. If you bother to withstand the urge, you are working on breaking the habit.

The same is true with your inner psychological habit patterns. If you give in to them, you reinforce them, and they will become stronger. If you try to release them, over time their energy will be rerouted and transmuted. This is the second benefit: you are rerouting energy patterns instead of reinforcing them. Over time, enough energy will be released to flow upward, and you will begin to notice you are happier and less reactive.

If you keep letting go, the upward flow will become stronger and stronger until it is a major force in your daily life. If you ask how long this will take—it's none of your business! This is a natural process of purification, and the only reason it takes any time is because you are holding on to and supporting the inner blockages. You must learn over time, through daily experiences, to realize you don't have to hold on to everything that ever bothered you in the past (including five minutes ago!).

Do your work of letting go to the best of your ability—the rest will take care of itself. When you do this inner work, you are carrying out the purpose of your life, and all of life will support you. But not necessarily in the ways you expect. This is where true surrender comes in—you do the work and allow the infinite force that created the universe to do the rest.

9-10

Can loving and thanking inner demons or past struggles be part of letting go?

If something from your past comes up—old pain, struggles, things you once saw as demons—don't push it away. Don't fight with it. Instead, love it to death. Do you understand how powerful that is? If you love what comes up from your past, you're not resisting it. You're not suppressing it. You're allowing it to come up, be released, and finally pass through.

This is not about pretending the event didn't happen or trying to make it something it's not. It's about honoring it for the growth it gave you. Every single thing that has ever happened to you, no matter how difficult, has shaped you. It has helped you learn and brought you to this exact moment. Instead of holding it in as some kind of burden, thank it and let it go.

Letting go is not an act of rejection—it's an act of deep acceptance. You're not saying, "This should not have happened." You're saying, "It did happen, and I am at peace with it." This applies to your past relationships, mistakes, and your so-called failures. You should be able to look back and say, "That helped me. That taught me. That made me who I am today." If you can do that with an open heart, you'll see that you don't need to carry any of it as a weight anymore. You honor it, and in that honoring, it dissolves. That's real letting go, and that's how you become free.



Growth and Transformation

Spiritual growth isn't about becoming something new—it's about removing what's been blocking you from the truth of what you already are. Life isn't happening to you; it's happening for you—every challenge, every setback, every uncomfortable feeling is showing you exactly where you're still holding on. Growth means learning to use those moments not to protect your blockages, but to release them. You don't grow by controlling life; you grow by letting go of the part of you that needs to control. In this chapter, we'll explore your questions about what it means to embrace discomfort, meet your edges, and allow life itself to lead your transformation from within.

10-1

How can I avoid adapting my life to fit my internal problems?

You are correct; your life isn't supposed to be structured around protecting your issues and making sure they never get triggered. That's what the mind does—it builds walls, makes excuses, and rearranges the world to avoid discomfort. That's not freedom. That's a prison.

Your life has meaning because you are letting go of the lower aspects of yourself. The whole process of life—of creation itself—is designed to help you evolve into a higher state of being. You can't do that if you keep adjusting your life to accommodate your fears and insecurities. If you have blockages inside, don't protect them—release them. Life will bring you everything you need for your spiritual growth. You don't have to force it or even understand it. Just stop resisting.

10-2**Why does the process of spiritual growth often involve discomfort or pain?**

If it was stored with pain, it is going to release with pain. You have stored blockages inside of you which are restricting your natural energy flow. Life is constantly trying to bring those blockages up so they can be released. Instead of letting them go, you resist. You don't want to feel insecurity, fear, or loss, so you try to manipulate the world around you to keep those feelings buried. But life won't let you do that forever. Life is designed to help you evolve, and that means it's going to bring up everything inside of you that needs to be purified.

When you feel emotional pain, it's because energy that was supposed to flow freely is now hitting resistance. Maybe you built your sense of self around a relationship, a job, or an idea of how life should be, and then something happens to shake that foundation. It feels like your heart is on fire because the energy cannot flow around your blockages anymore and is bouncing back inside you. Instead of fighting, what if you saw that discomfort as an opportunity? What if, instead of pushing it away, you let it burn through whatever is in the way? That's real growth.

Spiritual growth isn't about protecting yourself from pain; it's about letting go of the part of you that gets disturbed. A truly free being doesn't need life to be a certain way to feel okay. They don't hold on to the past, they don't resist the present, and they don't live in fear of the future. They let go and allow the natural energy of life to flow unimpeded. That's what liberation is.

Don't be afraid of discomfort. Welcome it. When life shakes you, see it as an invitation to release what's holding you back. The more you let go, the more the beautiful energy inside you will rise, and one day, there won't be pain anymore—there will be freedom.

10-3**Why does my ego resist so strongly when I try to stay centered and let go?**

When you commit yourself to staying centered and letting go of ego, the ego will resist, and that is absolutely part of the process. You have to understand that your mind has been storing impressions, emotions, and experiences your entire life. These are not just passing thoughts; they are deeply ingrained

patterns, and when something triggers them, they will surface with full force. The mind will start talking, spinning stories, and before you know it, you're caught. That's just how it works. But here's the key: over time, if you keep letting go, this reaction will lose its power.

You don't get to choose whether something hits you or not. It's going to happen. A situation, a word, a look from someone—it will trigger something inside, and suddenly, your mind is throwing thoughts all over the place. You don't need to pretend it's not happening, and you don't need to judge yourself for it. Just don't resist. Don't get lost in thinking, *Why is this happening? Why is this still here?* It's there because it's inside of you, and that's okay. The goal is not to stop things from coming up. The goal is to get so good at letting go that they no longer control you.

When the mind starts talking and emotions start flooding in, don't fight with them—just relax behind them. If you get caught, you're caught. Fine. Just do your best. Don't use that as an excuse to indulge in negativity, like thinking you should be past all this already. If you fall down, just get back up. Each time you do, you will become stronger.

At some point, you will start to see that these moments, the very ones that used to take you down, are actually opportunities. They are the doorways to freedom. Every time something hits you and you choose to let go instead of resist, you become a little lighter. You become a little freer. One day, you'll notice that what used to knock you over barely even moves you anymore. That is the beauty of this path: you just stay with it. Let go when you can, accept when you can't, and keep on going.

10-4

How do I maintain a high state when I feel like I'm backsliding?

When you feel like you're backsliding, the first thing to do is change the way you're looking at it. Stop thinking that staying in a high state is good and coming down is bad. That's not how this works. Growth isn't about holding on to a state—it's about letting go of whatever is still in you that pulls you down. If something inside you is getting hit, that means there's something left to work through. That's a gift, not a problem. Instead of resisting it, welcome it. Let it come up, see it clearly, and use that moment to relax and let go.

You have to understand that spiritual growth isn't about clinging to highs; it's about removing the barriers that keep you from naturally staying there. If you truly want to be free, then every time life hits your stuff, use that as an opportunity to let go of what's holding you down. This is why the great masters talk about surrender. The highest beings don't go around thinking, *Am I maintaining a high state?* They're just free. They've let go of everything that would have pulled them out of that freedom.

Look at it this way: A hot air balloon naturally rises, but if it's tied down, it can't go anywhere. You're that balloon, and your old fears, reactions, and attachments are the ropes holding you down. Those ropes are very important to your growth—they are showing you exactly what's left to let go of. You should thank them for being there, because once you deal with them, you'll go even higher.

When you feel like you're falling, neither get into it nor resist it. Embrace it. Worship it. Love that life is giving you this opportunity to grow. The real question isn't "How do I stay up?" It's "What inside of me is still pulling me down?" When you stop fighting with life and start using it to release what's left inside of you, you'll no longer have to try to stay high. You'll just naturally be there because there will be nothing left to pull you out.

10-5

How can I stay committed to my spiritual growth despite setbacks?

The first thing you need to understand is that you're not here to achieve spiritual growth like it's some kind of goal you check off a list. You're here to let go of the false self that keeps you from experiencing the truth of what you are. The process of life is designed to evolve you, to break down the barriers that keep you limited. When challenges arise, they are not obstacles to your growth—they *are* your growth. If you can approach them with openness instead of resistance, you'll find that the very things you once saw as setbacks were actually life perfectly guiding you toward deeper surrender.

If you make spirituality about becoming something, proving yourself, or being good enough—you will struggle. That's the mind playing games, telling you that you need to accomplish something to be okay inside. Your life does not become meaningful because of what you do. Your life becomes meaningful when you finally realize who you truly are. This can only happen

when you let go of who you are not—the identification with the made-up self-concept.

Stop trying to force your way through obstacles, and instead, surrender to them. Let them show you what you need to release. The universe is not asking you to be perfect; it's asking you to let go. As you do, everything will unfold exactly as it needs to. The right lessons, the right people, the right opportunities will come. Your job is not to control any of it. Your job is to stay open and trust the process of life.

10-6

How do I handle difficult situations and let go when I'm overwhelmed?

When you find yourself in the midst of a difficult situation and are struggling to let go, understand that the real work should have started long before that moment. It's like asking, "What do I do now that my body is sick and breaking down?" when you haven't taken care of it for years. Of course, there will be things you can do now, but the most powerful approach would have been to build strength and resilience when things weren't so bad. If you work on staying centered with the little things in your daily life—such as traffic, the weather, or minor frustrations—then, when life throws you something big, you'll already have the tools to handle it.

If you haven't done that work and now you're in the storm, the first thing you can do is recognize that everything passes. Every single moment of your life has come and gone, hasn't it? This too shall pass. Instead of fighting the situation or getting lost in it, try looking past it. Ask yourself, "What if I could handle this? How much stronger, how much freer would I be on the other side?" Make the situation your teacher. Use it as an opportunity to grow rather than as something to resist.

The highest approach isn't about trying to control the situation—it's about working with yourself. You can use mantra, you can shift your focus, but ultimately, you need to recognize that the worst things that have ever happened to you are often the best for your growth. They push you to grow in ways you would not have otherwise. You might not see it now, but one day, you'll look back and realize that the challenges shaped you, deepened you, and took you places you never would have imagined.

Life can play hardball, and if you resist, you'll suffer. But if you embrace what's happening and allow life to teach you instead of fighting against it, you'll discover something incredible: no matter what happens, you're okay. When you truly understand this, life ceases to be something you're trying to get through—it becomes something you're willing to fully embrace with an open heart.

10-7

If I want to grow spiritually, how do I maintain awareness during overwhelming events like fear or crises?

When you go through a period of life when everything is fine, it's relatively easy to stay centered. But when something happens that is big enough to shake you, the mind goes crazy, fear escalates, and you feel completely thrown off. In those moments, it feels impossible to stay present in the seat of awareness. So what do you do?

First, understand that you are not enlightened yet—there's still plenty of evolution ahead of you. When powerful events occur, they show where you are in your spiritual growth. This is true for both positive and negative experiences. An overwhelming desire can arise out of nowhere, just as powerfully as an overwhelming sense of fear. They are both the same principle: an inner experience gets so big that it pulls you out of your center. Spiritual practices are about preparing for these events before they happen. Learn to stay conscious now, before the storm comes. The more you practice staying centered in your everyday life, the less likely the bigger challenges will throw you.

Let's say something happens, and you get pulled out of your center. What now? Don't resist, don't rationalize, don't make excuses—just come back. The moment you become aware that you've lost yourself in fear, come back as soon as you can. No judgment. No guilt. Just return. If you practice this, over time you'll find that you stay centered longer before getting lost, and you return more quickly after the fall. That's evolution.

When you do come back from a fall, don't store the experience as something negative. That's how people become afraid of growthful experiences. Instead, say thank you. Thank you for the opportunity to grow. This is how

life's experiences help you evolve. Every difficult moment is an opportunity to grow beyond yourself. Just always do your best at your current level of evolution, and the amazing process of life will take you to the next level.

10-8

I am letting go of thoughts and emotions so they can pass through, but I'm experiencing overwhelming fatigue and heaviness, rather than clarity. Should I continue to stay centered and allow the energies to pass through, or is a different approach needed?

There are many stages you go through during your inner growth. You will have times when the energy feels high and clear, and there will be times when you feel you have no energy at all. The heaviness and lack of energy are simply signs of a blockage, and that blockage will release over time if you continue to let go. You are correct that regardless of how the energy is flowing or not flowing, your work is to stay centered in the Self, relax and release, and simply be aware of the energy passing through. That is your inner work.

However, that is not your outer work. As much as possible, you want to set patterns in your daily life that support your inner growth and a sense of consistent outer stability. Your daily routines are very important. It is very hard to stay on course and not let the dips and changes in your energy flow dictate your actions in life. But if you are going through a time when your energy is low and you feel you can barely move, you should still try to go about your normal daily life to the very best of your ability.

For example, if you have a job, you go to work and do the very best that you can while you are inwardly letting go. Don't worry that the best you can do when you are feeling low is not as good as the best you can do when you are feeling clear and high. That is not what matters—what matters is that you did the very best you could. The results of the best you can do are always honorable. In addition, by looking past your inner disturbance and simply focusing on your work, you'll find that the period of low energy will pass more quickly, and you won't dip as low. If you approach your life in this way, you will find that your daily activities are actually an important part of the grace that carries you through tough times.

10-9**Is it normal to feel discomfort or low energy levels when going through spiritual growth?**

What you're experiencing is not only normal—it's beautiful. When you sincerely ask, "Who am I?" you're turning your awareness inward, and that begins to stir things up inside. You may start to feel discomforts you never felt before. That's because you're opening. As you open, the stored blockages inside you—your past experiences, your unresolved emotions, all the impressions you've accumulated—start to rise up. They were always there, but now that you're turning inward, you're becoming aware of them.

This is not something to be afraid of. It's actually a deep cleansing. Think of it like a pool where dirt and debris have settled at the bottom. On the surface, the water looks clear, but when you start stirring it, all that muck rises up. That's what's happening inside of you. When you stop distracting yourself with the outside world and turn your attention inward, all the stuff you've suppressed begins to come up so it can pass through. But instead of letting it go, most people get involved—they resist it, they fight it, and that's what causes suffering.

The key is to welcome the process—it's called spiritual cleansing. If you were in India, you might climb the Himalayas and seek out a master just to receive a touch that would initiate this exact cleansing process. Instead, life is giving it to you naturally. Don't resist it. When you feel discomfort, don't pull away—relax and let it pass through. It's just like a mother in labor—screaming in pain, yet willing to go through the process because she knows she's giving birth to something beautiful. That's what's happening to you. You're giving birth to your soul.

Don't pray for the cleansing to stop—pray for the blockages to be released. Offer them up to the Universe and say, "Take it. I don't want this inside me anymore." You don't want to carry around all this stored pain, these blockages that keep you from being open and filled with love. Let go, and what you'll find is that beneath all of it, there's nothing but joy, light, and peace. It's already there—you just have to clear out what's blocking it.

10-10

How does setting boundaries affect spiritual growth?

When you talk about boundaries in the context of spiritual growth and acceptance, you have to be very careful. Why? Because when you set a boundary, what you're really saying is, "I can't handle this." That is exactly the opposite of growth. Spiritual growth is expanding your ability to remain open in the face of life's experiences. Life is not something you get to control by drawing lines around what you will and won't accept. Life just happens—things come and go, events unfold, and your job is to remain open and allow those experiences to help you grow.

This doesn't mean you just sit there passively allowing people to mistreat you. Surrender doesn't mean you don't take action—it means you don't take action out of reactivity. You don't set boundaries because you're afraid or because you can't handle something. Instead, you step back, let go of your initial reactions, and ask yourself, *Am I seeing this clearly?* So much of what people call boundaries is just projection—reacting to past pain and imposing that reaction onto present situations. If you had a bad experience at a job before, you might walk into the next one already convinced the same thing is going to happen. That's not clarity—that's carrying your past into the present.

Acceptance means staying quiet for a moment and watching your inner reaction to the situation. Once you've settled yourself, ask, *Is this actually happening the way I think it is? If so, what is the appropriate response?* That's very different from saying, "I have a boundary, and I refuse to deal with this." When you accept reality and seek to respond appropriately, you're not running away, and you're not avoiding. You're handling life with clarity. If someone is mistreating you, you don't just sit there and let it happen—but you also don't run away out of fear. You handle it but from a place of strength, not weakness.

For example, if someone steals your car, you don't just sit there and say, "Oh well, I accept it." No, you surrender the part of you that's freaking out because you can't handle it, and then you take action. You call the police. You

call your insurance company. You do what needs to be done, but you don't react from a place of panic or resistance. Because life doesn't have boundaries, it does all kinds of things. Your growth is about expanding your capacity to stay open while life moves through you. Then you take appropriate action when needed—without making the mistake of believing that you have to protect yourself from life. If you act from clarity instead of fear, you're not setting boundaries—you're just dealing with life in an impersonal, appropriate manner. That's real spiritual growth.

Dealing with Fear

Fear is not your enemy—it's either an instinctual warning of imminent danger or just a part of you that doesn't feel safe. The latter case is psychological fear that rises up like a wave, pulling your attention, demanding control, and convincing you that something has to change outside. But that fear isn't outside—it lives inside, buried deep within your psyche from past experiences you never fully let go of. The moment you feel that tightening in your chest, that racing mind trying to escape what might happen, you're being given a sacred opportunity: to relax, to let go, and to allow the fearful energy to pass through without owning you. In this chapter, we're going to address your questions about learning how to sit with fear, how to soften around it, and how to use it as a doorway back to the part of you that was never afraid in the first place.

11-1

I have had a problem with fear since I was a child. How do I work with it in a compassionate way?

An important part of your spiritual growth is learning how to work through past experiences that have left you feeling fear. The path of letting go is never about heartlessly abandoning that scared part of your psyche. True spiritual growth is about being willing to experience fear when it comes up but remaining centered enough to work with it so that it is not controlling your life.

Your ability to work with fear comes in very distinct steps. To begin with, you must learn to immediately relax the moment you start to feel the vibration of fear. Relax your shoulders, chest, belly, and buttocks instead of tightening up in resistance to the experience. Start with the very small expressions of fear within you. Perhaps someone is passing you while you're driving, and you see yourself starting to tense up. Or maybe your mind is bothering

you about something minor you said during a passing conversation with a friend. There are lots of these moments during the day that are not actually threatening, but you still feel some fear come up. Dare to relax instead of resist. Let the initial impulse of fear pass through. You don't need to protect yourself from these reactions of fear; they are not really threatening you.

Over time, if you can stay centered in the face of these minor fears, the scared part of your being will begin to see that the current reality is not as threatening as it thought. That habitually scared part of your being will begin to feel comfortable that you, your higher consciousness, are there to help it through these moments. You are not alone—the higher part of your being is there to raise the lower part.

When you reach this stage, you are not denying the fear or even trying to get rid of it. You are simply remaining in witness consciousness and allowing the fearful energy from the past to pass through. As you practice relaxing through minor fears, you are actually learning how to deal with fear itself. You will find that remaining in witness consciousness becomes your natural state. Once you can relax through the initial impulse of fear, you can interact with the world from a much deeper place. You can now actually deal with the outer situation, instead of having to deal with your inner fears about it. Without realizing it, you have used the impulse of fear to help you grow spiritually. There is now less fear and more centered consciousness. Letting go is a very beautiful practice that can transmute lower self into higher self.

11-2

I've always had a very deep fear of injury and death. I've tried relaxing and releasing it, but it keeps coming back. How do I deal with this fear?

Fear can be very strong and sometimes even overwhelming. But never forget you are not the fear; you are the consciousness that is aware of the fear. The nature of consciousness is joy, love, and absolute well-being. But since consciousness is now focusing on fear, it is experiencing the fear it is focusing on. Don't fight the fear, and don't be afraid of the fear. Just know it as part of human nature. Relax around it, honor its right to be, but don't get lost in it. Let it pass by, the way a matador steps aside and lets the charging bull pass right by. Don't touch the fear; work to shift your awareness off the fear. That is why people do mantra—to focus on something other than the disturbances

created by the mind and heart. Don't push the fear away; don't suppress it. Simply shift your consciousness onto something else. If the fear keeps pulling you back into it, don't fight it—just relax and actively welcome it to release and pass through you. It's just energy trying to release. Your only job is to help it.

If remaining centered in the face of fear seems impossible, I will give you a technique I used in the early years of my growth. Instead of trying to stay above the fear as it passes through you, there is a very sacred place inside of you where you can lay down very quietly and allow the fear to pass over you. This requires no will or strength; it is an act of complete surrender to the experience. Try lying down on your back with your arms out to your sides. Relax so much that you feel like you are melting into the floor. Focus on the feeling of melting backward into that space, instead of focusing on the fear that is blowing like wind over you. You are safe there and can weather the storm. This will allow the energy of fear to release without you reacting in resistance.

People don't know how to release like this because they were never taught how. Instead, they try to change things outside so they don't have to handle the inner fear. The fear never really goes away that way. It will always come back. If you learn to relax in the face of the fear, you can learn to let the root cause of the fear surface and pass through.

Always remember: that which is aware of the fear is a billion times more powerful than the fear itself.

11-3

What is the relationship between our fears and our preferences?

There is a powerful relationship between fear and preferences. When you prefer something to be a certain way, you naturally experience fear at the possibility it won't turn out that way. The deeper the preference, the stronger the fear. This isn't about instinctual fear—the biological kind that protects the body from danger. That's natural, and it's there for survival. If a tiger is chasing you, you should be afraid. That fear is not the problem.

The fear we're talking about is psychological fear. The "what-ifs." *What if they don't like me? What if I fail? What if my feelings get hurt?* Fears such as these come from your mind spinning stories about how things need to be

for you to be okay. You're afraid because you have an expectation, a preference for things being a certain way. If you didn't have that preference, there wouldn't be fear. Imagine you didn't care what people think of you—then you wouldn't be afraid of being judged. Imagine you didn't need to be in control—then you wouldn't be afraid of uncertainty. Fear is the tension you feel when your preferences might not be met.

From a spiritual growth point of view, you don't allow the fear to pull you into it; you allow it to come up and pass through you. You never fight or suppress fear, either. Instead, you recognize it for what it is: blocked energy inside of you. That fear is showing you where you're holding on to unresolved blockages from the past. If you allow yourself to relax and not resist, something amazing happens. You start to let go. The preference loses its grip on you. The fear dissolves on its own, because it only existed in relation to your attachment.

This doesn't mean you force yourself to have no preferences. That's not how it works. Preferences naturally fall away as your inner blockages dissolve. You don't have to push them away; they just stop controlling you. Maybe once you failed in a math class and were embarrassed because you had tied your self-worth to being good at math. As you grow and release those old wounds, you stop caring. You realize your worth was never tied to that. Suddenly, the fear is gone. This is how fear fades—not by force, but by letting go of what created it in the first place. You must work at the root cause.

Eventually, you will realize that it is not the situation itself that is causing fear—it's your need for things to be a certain way that generates mental and emotional disturbance. When you stop committing your life to your preferences, you will become free of these fears. They will no longer have a hold on you, and you will be free to openly experience every moment of your life.

11-4

I was diagnosed with a serious illness, aggressive cancer, and the probability of recurrence is very high. How can I stay in witness consciousness and use this for my spiritual growth?

I am so sorry to hear of your serious illness. There are so many levels at which your question can be answered. They all include compassion, but one response can actually make a huge difference in how you live the remaining years of

your life. The problem is that most people are not receptive to the deepest and surest way to work with life's issues. If you fear a recurrence of the cancer and the possibility of an early death, it'll be pretty much impossible to enjoy the remaining years of your life. The best you'll be able to do is suppress your underlying fears, and that does not lead to a life of openness and appreciation.

What you must do, if you are willing to try, is to change your entire attitude about your remaining years. Start with the affirmation that everyone dies; in fact, everything that was ever born is going to die. How long a person lives is not the important part—it's the joy, love, and pure appreciation for each day that makes the next day worth living. Don't worry about how many years you have left—learn to appreciate each day, one at a time. This is all done by working with your thoughts.

Of course, by default, we don't tend to think this way. It may be challenging to do so, but you can work at making that change in your thinking. Use an affirmation, like: *I am grateful for the day I have been given, and I will use every moment of it to love everyone and everything that unfolds before me. If I get one more day—that is a treasure chest of experiences I get to have.* Work on thinking like this. Don't be mad at God or the Universe for your illness; be grateful that you have one more day to live fully and love openly. Reread the chapter "Contemplating Death" in *The Untethered Soul*. Work on this, and everything will look different. You will be a light of inspiration to all those around you.

11-5

Recently I started experiencing a lot of fear and anxiety when I try to let go of the ego. I am concerned I will become nothing. Is this the ego trying to hold on to its false self-concept?

Sometimes when you are going through deep growth, the lower self becomes frightened and challenged. It is really important to let go and not listen to it. At the same time, it is important to be kind and not push the fear down or push the lower self into a corner inside yourself. Be kind to yourself. You can use loving affirmations, if it helps. This could be as simple as saying *I am always okay* or *I am always loved*. Allow yourself to feel that loving presence. This is how you deal with fear in the short term.

Over time, as you continue to let go and fall back into your true Self (the conscious awareness), you'll find the fear you have of losing yourself will go away. The more you experience your deeper presence by simply watching your mind and heart, the more you'll see that your true being is ever-present and unchanging. Your awareness does not leave; it is just the noise of the personal mind and heart that leaves. It's a very natural process. As the lower self thins out, all the energy that was creating it comes back to your center. You'll find that the lower energy is naturally replaced with a happy, loving sense of presence and fulfillment.

So, in truth, you are not losing yourself—you are actually finding yourself. You will begin to experience a fullness, like everything and everyone is a part of you. They say that in the end, you do not become nothing—you actually become everything!

11-6

How do you overcome fear, such as fear of pain before a necessary medical procedure?

When you're dealing with the fear of pain from an upcoming event, such as a necessary medical procedure, you have to start by being completely honest with yourself. Ask yourself, *Do I have to go through this procedure? Yes or no?* If the answer is no, then don't do it. If the answer is yes—if you've done the cost-benefit analysis, consulted the experts, and made the decision that this is the right thing for your well-being—then that part is settled. You're not going to keep going back and forth in your mind, questioning it over and over. That only feeds the fear. Instead, you see reality, make a decision, and say to yourself, *This is happening, and I am doing this.* That clarity is powerful. It stops you from letting your mind play games with you.

Once you've accepted the reality of the situation, you shift your focus. Instead of obsessing over your fear, you start to reframe the experience. You tell yourself, *I really want to do this. I'm looking forward to getting through it so I can be on the other side.* You use affirmations. You remind yourself, *I can't wait for this to be done. Imagine how much better I'll feel knowing it's behind me. I'm taking care of myself. I'm doing the right thing.* At first, you may not fully believe what you're saying, but that doesn't matter. You keep saying it

anyway. You give your mind something positive to focus on, an alternative to sitting in fear.

One of the best ways to handle fear is to mentally skip past the part you're dreading. Don't fixate on the procedure itself—jump beyond it. Imagine yourself afterward, relieved, free of worry, stronger for having faced it. Your mind is going to make up stories anyway, so why not choose a story that serves you? Instead of picturing fear and pain, picture yourself on the other side, looking back and saying, "That wasn't so bad. I did it. It's done." That shift in perspective changes everything.

Understand this: You have to be willing to make this mental shift—it won't just happen on its own. Fear will keep pulling you down unless you actively lift yourself up. Take responsibility for where you place your attention. Instead of letting fear drag you into suffering, guide yourself toward a place of strength. This is something you can do, and once you start, you'll realize you're more capable than you ever thought.

11-7

I fear major life tragedies like losing a child, getting a terminal illness, or experiencing a disaster. How does surrender work when someone is experiencing extreme tragedy and pain?

Undoubtedly, there are horrific events that take place on this planet. The question is, can you handle that? This is an especially poignant question if you have fear of events that are not actually happening to you. If you live your life driven by fears that something bad might happen, you will live a life of constant suffering. It might as well be happening because it's causing you constant pain. The good news is that in this situation, you have complete control. You are the one who is allowing your mind to fixate on something that is not real. Empower yourself to change—work on letting go of the part of you that distrusts life and thinks it is unsafe. Stop and question yourself: How many moments of your life were actually as traumatic and difficult as the scenarios you are imagining? It's probably a very small number of moments compared to the rest of your life. Yet you still fear them.

One practice is to ask yourself regularly, *Is everything okay right now? Can I handle this moment?* If you keep asking this regularly, you will see that you really are okay the vast majority of the time. Take refuge in that

realization. Keep relaxing and releasing each time you feel the fear, and over time, the fears will diminish.

When it comes to horrific experiences that are actually happening, people will naturally experience fear, along with the physical and emotional pain the event creates. That is part of the reality of living through such an ordeal. Surrender is not about denying the reality of these events. It is about allowing them to ultimately pass through without leaving permanent scars and fears in the psyche. Part of the process of inner healing is to fully accept that the event took place and see what you can do to view it in a positive light. Maybe the event taught you to be strong, to have a deeper understanding of humanity, or to have compassion for others who have suffered trauma. Find a way to raise yourself through the situation—you learned, you grew, you became a greater person for having lived through the experience. Yes, it brought pain, but it also expanded you and helped you evolve.

11-8

Is fear part of the process when deeply buried emotions begin to surface? How do I stay motivated when deep emotional cleansing feels overwhelming and regressive?

When those deeply buried emotions begin to surface, yes, fear is absolutely part of the process. This fear isn't something wrong or something to avoid—it's a natural protective mechanism that's been guarding these emotions for years, perhaps decades. Your psyche buried these feelings for a reason, and now they're coming up. Fear arises to say, "Wait—are you sure you want to go there?"

What you're experiencing during deep emotional cleansing isn't regression—it's progression. You're finally allowing yourself to face what you've spent an enormous amount of energy avoiding. The feeling of being overwhelmed comes because you're experiencing both the emotion itself and all the resistance you've built around it. When you feel like you're drowning, remember that you are not the emotions or the fear—you're the awareness that notices them arising within your consciousness.

Motivation does not come from fighting these emotions, but from a profound understanding that facing them is the only path to freedom. Every time you allow a buried emotion to surface without resistance, you are freeing

energy that has been locked in your heart. This is spiritual work of the highest order. The temporary discomfort you feel is the price of permanent liberation. When you're in the thick of it and feeling overwhelmed, remind yourself that millions of people live their entire lives avoiding this work, carrying these burdens to their graves. You've already chosen the path of freedom—now honor your courage by continuing.

The key is to relax in the face of your resistance. When fear arises, don't push against it or analyze it. Simply notice it, relax your shoulders, open your heart, and breathe. Let it pass through you like a storm cloud passing through the sky. The sky itself remains untouched. This is the practice: to witness without clinging; to feel without identifying. Your awareness is vast enough to hold any emotion that arises.

Remember, this cleansing isn't something you're doing—it's something you're allowing. The natural state of your being is joy, peace, and love. Suppressed emotions are coming up precisely because they're ready to be released. Trust this process. Trust that the intelligence that created the universe is perfectly capable of healing your heart—if only you'll step aside and allow it to work through you.

In the end, staying motivated is about remembering what's on the other side: a life of openness, freedom, and unconditional joy. Each emotion you face and release is a step toward living untethered from the patterns of your past. This work isn't easy, but nothing of true value ever is. Keep going. The light you seek is not somewhere in the distance—it's what remains when you've allowed the darkness to pass through.



Karma, Free Will, and the Law of Attraction

People love to talk about karma, free will, and the law of attraction—but they often miss the deeper truth behind it all. These aren't mystical forces floating out in space; they're reflections of what's going on inside of you. Karma is just the energy you haven't let go of yet. Free will is the choice to release or to cling. And what you "attract" isn't some magical reward system—it's your own consciousness shaping your experience of life. In this chapter, we'll look deeper than just the surface level of these ideas. And we'll explore your questions about how true freedom comes not from controlling life, but from surrendering the part of you that thinks it needs to. When you stop trying to manipulate the world and instead align yourself with the flow of life, something amazing happens: you rise above it all and become free.

12-1

What is the role of free will in dealing with the world, emotions, and thoughts?

The role of free will in dealing with the outer world and your inner state is simple, yet profound. You have a choice every moment: to accept or resist. That is the only real control you have. Life will bring you experiences—some beautiful, some difficult. Your freedom lies in how you handle those experiences. If you choose acceptance, you are allowing life to flow through you. You don't get caught struggling with life; you remain centered in the seat of Self. If you resist, if you push against what is happening, you create tension, turmoil, and suffering within yourself.

This is where free will meets the spiritual path—it's at the point of acceptance versus resistance. Every time something happens outside, every time a thought arises or an emotion stirs inside you, you have the opportunity

to choose: Do you open, or do you close? Do you allow the energy to move through, or do you fight with it? If you resist, you don't just resist the situation; you resist the natural flow of life itself. You hold on to pain, you create blockages, and then you have to deal with all of that. If you surrender, if you accept what is given, you stay open and free to interact from a place of clarity. Ultimately, that openness pulls you back into alignment with something much greater than yourself.

Look at the highest teachings—this is what they've always shown us. Even in the most difficult moments, there is a choice: resistance or surrender. Even Christ himself, when faced with the ultimate challenge, said, *May this cup pass from me*—but then, *Not my will, but Thy will be done*. That is the choice. It's not about making life go your way. It's not about controlling every thought and every feeling. It's about letting go, trusting, and allowing life to unfold as it is meant to. That is the highest use of your will: to surrender to what is and stay open no matter what.

If people truly understood this and lived it, the world would be a very different place. Resistance is what causes division, pain, and suffering. When you surrender, you find peace—not because life is perfect, but because you are no longer fighting it. You have free will—learn to use it wisely. Don't use it to control the world or fight with your mind; use it to stay open, to accept, and to allow life to take you exactly where you are meant to go.

12-2

How do your teachings view karma, and how can one let go of it?

If you're carrying the idea that karma is some external force dictating your life, let that go. Karma is not some cosmic punishment system—it's just the energy you hold inside yourself from the past, attracting present events. If you have unresolved emotions, attachments, or regrets, those stay inside of you. Because they're inside of you, they continue to shape your experiences in life. The external world isn't keeping that karma alive—you are. If you want to be free of karma, you don't need to perform rituals, seek forgiveness from some higher authority, or try to pay it off. You simply need to let go of what you're holding on to inside.

If you did something in the past that you now regret, it can still weigh on you. That weight is your karma. It's not about what happened—it's about

the fact that you are still carrying it. The key isn't to suppress it, deny it, or justify it. You just have to let it move through you. True remorse is not guilt or shame. It's a deep recognition that, given who you are now, you would not act the same way again. That's enough. The moment you fully allow that realization to pass through you—without holding on to it, without resisting it—you burn away the karma. It's gone because you are no longer holding on to it. In a real sense, you have worked it through on the inside.

Karma is simply unfinished business. It's the energy of your past that you haven't let go of yet. The reason it comes back to you is because you're still energetically tied to it. The moment you truly release it, it no longer has power over you. That's why the great masters say that in a moment of true enlightenment, all karmic seeds are burned away. This is because in that moment, you have finally let go of your lower self, the one who created the karma in the first place.

Please don't sit around worrying about your karma. Instead, let go of the tendencies inside you that caused it. Keep surrendering and releasing what comes up, and you will naturally rise above the part of you that has any need for lessons from the past. When that happens, you won't have to ask how to let go of karma—you will already be free.

12-3

What is the connection between free will and karma?

You absolutely have free will, and you are using it all the time. The question is, what are you using it for? Right now, your will is being used to stay identified with the patterns and conditioning inside of you. When a habitual reaction arises—whether it's fear, desire, guilt, or anything else—you have the free will to engage with it or let it go. If you choose to engage with these stored patterns, that's where the concept of karma comes in.

People say that if you use your will improperly, you take on bad karma. But karma isn't some external force punishing you. It's simply the consequence of expressing the energy you've stored inside. If you've built up guilt, fear, or negativity, those seeds will keep sprouting in your life. You don't escape karma by avoiding life—you free yourself by working through what arises. If a past mistake keeps coming up in your mind, ask yourself, *Would I do that again?* If the answer is no, then you've learned your lesson. There is no

need to carry it anymore. That's how you burn karma—not by paying a price, but by evolving beyond it.

You are not here to be run by your past. You are here to use life to let go of yourself so that something greater can unfold. The moment you decide to stop clinging to old patterns, you begin to rise. As you rise, everything changes. You don't have to fight your karma or force yourself to be free. Just step back, relax, and let go—and watch as life takes care of the rest.

12-4

Do you think will is an unlimited resource, or does it have a threshold?

To answer this question, you first have to ask yourself—where does will come from? Will is the force created by the focusing of consciousness. When you need to do math in your head, you have to concentrate. Concentration is the willful act of focusing your awareness.

The great masters tell you that divine will is what created everything. It is the force that brought every atom into existence and holds it all together. You have access to that same consciousness, but you're blocked by layers of personal identity formed by your past experiences. The more you stop focusing on that false identity, the more your consciousness is free to expand, and with it, your will becomes stronger and freer.

When you think your will is limited, what's really happening is that you've reached the edge of what your personal self can handle. If you let go of the part of you that thinks, *I can only do so much*, you will see that your capacity for will is infinitely greater than you believed. The more you align with the deeper truth of who you are, the more your will is able to flow without obstruction.

Don't think of will as something you have a little bit of and need to conserve. Recognize that will is as boundless as the consciousness from which it arises. Your job is not to strengthen it—it is to remove the blocks that keep you from experiencing it fully. Let go of yourself, and you will see there is no limit to the will within you.

12-5

What about the Law of Attraction? Is it a good thing to focus on?

There is a truth to the Law of Attraction, but probably not in the way you think. The way you see the world is filtered through what's going on inside of you. If you're hungry, you notice restaurants. If you're lonely, you notice people. If you're afraid, you see threats everywhere. That's not some mystical force bringing things to you—it's just that your mind is distorting reality according to its own conditioning. In such moments, you don't actually see the world as it is; you see it through the veil of your mind. When your mind is filled with desires, fears, and preferences, your experience of life becomes warped by all of that.

This is where you need to be careful. People love the idea that they can just decide what they want, think about it a lot, and the universe will give it to them. But how did you decide what you want? Notice that something you perceived as positive yesterday may appear as negative today. Which is it? It's going to be based on your mind's current and past impressions—*samskaras*. Do you really want to reinforce those impressions and make them the meaning of your life?

If you really want a higher way to live, forget about trying to control what comes to you. That's just your ego playing God. Instead, let go of yourself. Let go of the need to make life into what you think it should be. The universe has been unfolding perfectly for billions of years. You just got here a few decades ago, and now you think you know how it's supposed to go? The Tao, the natural flow of life, is already handling everything. Your job is not to tell it what to do—it's to let go of yourself enough to come into harmony with it. Life will give you tasks to do. Just put your whole being into doing each task to the best of your ability. In other words, serve life instead of your ego. When you do that, life doesn't just give you what you want; it gives you something far greater—what you need in order to reach unconditional well-being.

12-6

How can I attract the right partner to build a family once I have a vision of a perfect future?

The first thing you need to understand is that if you're thinking that life is supposed to match your vision, you're already setting yourself up for trouble. You are creating a fixed idea of how things need to be—the perfect partner, the perfect child, the perfect future. Life doesn't work that way. The more you insist on things being a certain way, the more suffering you will create for yourself and everyone involved. If you cling to your idea of perfection, what happens if life doesn't unfold according to that plan? What if your partner isn't always who you thought they would be? What if you find out you can't have children? Are you going to be devastated? Are you going to reject life because it didn't match your expectations? That's not a foundation for love; that's a foundation for suffering.

Instead of using your will to try to control how things turn out, learn to let go. Let life bring you what is meant for you. Because, in truth, you don't know how to pick the perfect partner or force perfect outcomes years in advance. Things change, and you need to be okay, completely okay, with whatever unfolds. If challenges arise, they are there for your growth. Your job is not to dictate how life should be. Your job is to show up each day, ready and willing to serve whatever unfolds in front of you.

If you live this way, you will find yourself attracting exactly what is right for you. Not because you controlled it, but because you aligned yourself with life instead of resisting it. If life hands you something unexpected, you will meet it with grace, not disappointment. True love is not about trying to orchestrate the right conditions—it's about being fully present, open-hearted, and ready to embrace life however it comes. The highest way to live is not to force life to match your desires, but to surrender to the flow of life and let it show you what is meant to be.

Stop trying to control everything in a relationship. Stop trying to make sure everything turns out the way you thought it would. Instead, wake up every morning, take a deep breath, and say, "I'm back. Let's see what gifts life has in store for today." That's how you find true love. That's how you live a life filled with joy and freedom.

12-7

Does the external world change as I grow internally?

If you are growing inside, does the external world change? That's a beautiful way to look at it, and many people teach it that way. But look deeper. What's actually happening is not that the world outside is changing, but that you are seeing it differently. If you put on dark glasses, the world looks dark. If you put on rose-colored glasses, the world looks rosy. But if you take off the glasses altogether, you see things as they truly are. As you clean up inside, as you stop projecting your fears, desires, and disturbances onto the world, the world starts to look clearer, more harmonious. In truth, it was always like that—you were just distorting it with your own mind.

The universe is already perfect. Every star is exactly where it belongs. The sun is precisely the right distance from the earth so that life can flourish. Babies form in the womb by themselves. You didn't do any of that. It just happens because the entire universe is unfolding exactly as it should. But when you are caught up in your personal preferences, you don't see this perfection. You divide life into good and bad based on what suits you. If something happens that you like, you say life is working for you. If something happens that you don't like, you think something is wrong. But what if you stopped interfering? What if you let go of yourself and simply observe reality as it is?

That's why the great teachings don't tell you to try to control the world so it gives you what you want. They tell you to seek something higher. *Seek ye first the kingdom of God and his righteousness, and all things shall be added unto you.* That means stop seeking for yourself first—your wants, your fears, your personal preferences—and see how life unfolds. You will find that life is always taking care of things. The forests get watered, the animals know how to feed themselves, the planets move in perfect order. None of that is because of you. It's because life knows what it's doing.

As you grow internally, what really happens is you stop distorting life with your personal struggles. You stop dumping your inner turmoil onto the world. When you stop interfering, life flows in ways you never imagined. But it's not because the world is changing—it's because you are finally seeing it clearly. The perfection was always there. Now, you're just getting out of the way.



Spiritual Practices

You don't need to escape to a mountaintop or a monastery to live a spiritual life. True spiritual practice is not about outer rituals or dogma—it's about what you're doing with your inner world, right here and now. Every moment of your life gives you the opportunity to let go, to relax, and to rise above the noise inside. Whether you're sitting in meditation or in traffic, the real practice is learning to release your resistance and surrender to the flow of life. In this chapter, we'll explore your questions about what it means to bring spiritual practice into everyday moments—how to use your thoughts, emotions, and even discomfort as stepping stones to freedom. This is not about becoming someone else. It's about returning to the quiet, open presence that's always been within you.

13-1

What is the best way to start letting go as a beginner in spiritual practice?

The best way to start letting go is to start small. You can't just jump into the deep end and let go of all your deepest fears and attachments overnight. That's not how it works. You've spent a lifetime identifying with your thoughts, emotions, and preferences, and they feel real to you. If you try to tackle the biggest things first, you're going to get overwhelmed. Instead, start with something simple—something that doesn't really matter but still gets to you.

Start with the weather. Yes, the weather. It's the perfect first teacher. Why? Because your mind does all kinds of neurotic things about it. *I don't like this rain. It's too hot. It's so humid.* But let's be honest—none of that changes the weather, does it? The rain isn't falling just to annoy you. The sun isn't shining too brightly because it's out to get you. It's just doing what it does. Yet you're sitting there bothering yourself about it. That's the key

realization: the moment in front of you is not bothering you—you're bothering yourself about the moment in front of you.

Your first practice in letting go is to stop bothering yourself about meaningless things. Make a commitment to yourself: "I will no longer bother myself about the weather." Every time you catch yourself complaining and wishing it were different, just stop. Relax into what is. Accept it fully. Why? Because resisting it does absolutely nothing except make you suffer. That's 100 percent cost with zero benefit. That would be a terrible business decision.

If you can train yourself to let go of something as simple as the weather, you'll begin to understand how to do it with the bigger things in your life. First, it's the weather. Then it's the traffic. Then it's what someone said to you. Eventually, it's the deeper things—the disappointments, worries, and fears of the past, present, and future. The more you practice letting go, the more you will see that these deeper things start to fall off naturally.

13-2

How do I maintain my intent to relax and release when it starts to erode over time?

To begin with, understand that what you're experiencing is completely natural. Intent is not something you set once and then expect it to stay perfectly clear forever. Just like anything in life, your intent to relax and release will have its ebbs and flows. It's not that something dramatic has to happen to make it fade—it just slowly gets clouded over by the noise of the mind and the pull of old habits. That's why it's essential to have regular practices that help realign you with your highest intent.

One of the simplest and most powerful things you can do is set aside dedicated time each day—morning and evening—to recommit yourself to letting go. It doesn't have to be long. Even ten or fifteen minutes where you sit quietly, take a breath, and consciously reaffirm your commitment to letting go can make a profound difference. This practice reminds you of what you're doing with your life and why, so you don't drift as easily. At the end of the day, take a moment to reflect. Look at what you held on to, what you didn't release, and see if you can let it go now. That way you don't have to carry it forward into tomorrow.

If you make this a regular part of your life, something incredible starts to happen. Because you're reinforcing your intent every day, you'll find that it doesn't erode as easily. You just naturally stay aware instead of letting unconscious tendencies take over. Over time, you'll look back and realize that these small moments of recommitment were among the most important things you've done with your life. They anchored you in your practice, kept you aligned with your highest path, and ultimately transformed your entire inner experience.

So don't worry if your intent seems to fade sometimes. That's just life. If you honor your intent enough to renew it each day, you'll find that it stays with you more and more. The commitment to letting go becomes second nature, and instead of losing yourself in resistance, you'll naturally relax, release, and flow with life.

13-3

How can I bridge the gap between understanding spiritual teachings and living them consistently?

The fact that you recognize such a gap is, in and of itself, great awareness. That's witness consciousness: you're already in there noticing what's going on inside. You see the potential to live the teachings, but living them is not always easy. That's okay, because the deeper question is, what is your intent? Do you intend to do this to the best of your ability? That's what matters.

Your intent is everything. You don't have to be perfect. You don't have to get it right all the time. That's not the point. It's like learning to play the piano or tennis—you don't start out playing like a master. You miss shots; you hit wrong notes. But if your intent is there, you keep going. You practice, and every time you make a mistake or fall, you get back up. You don't quit. The real trouble isn't in the mistakes or the falling; it's in abandoning your intent. It's when you say, "I can't do this," or "I don't want to do this anymore," and you turn away. That's when you lose your way. Your intent has shifted from freedom to distraction, from growth to avoidance. You can be sure that will never work.

On the other hand, if you hold your intent and stay with it—you're going to make it. That's how it works. And here's the most beautiful part: you are not doing this alone. In fact, you can't do it alone. It's too big. You will

find that something very great is carrying you. There is a force, something invisible yet deeply real, that is helping you. And when you stay with your intent, you'll start to notice this force. The right thing will show up at just the right time. You'll receive exactly what you need to take the next step, to handle the next challenge. It will strengthen you, and before you know it, you'll find yourself capable of handling what once seemed impossible.

It is true that the mind is very powerful, and the beliefs you hold shape your experience. If you believe that your heart's natural state is disturbance, you will have to live in that disturbance. If you understand that your heart's natural state is openness and joy, that state will always be there. We forget this because we've been disconnected for so long. But the moment you entertain the possibility that openness and peace are your true nature, things will start to change.

So just keep your intent. That's all you need. Stay with it, and you will see—your sincere intent will carry you.

13-4

How do I handle intense emotions or energies that arise during spiritual growth?

You are where you are at any given moment, and you don't really have a choice about that. The lower self is there, and if you keep focusing on it, it will dictate your actions and your whole experience of life. It doesn't have to stay that way. The question is, where is your polestar? Where are you aiming? No matter what is happening—whether you're caught in your emotions, struggling with your thoughts, or dealing with life's difficulties—something in you can always be looking higher. You don't have to fight with what's unfolding; you just need to keep even a small part of your attention on that higher place.

The mistake people make is thinking they have to deny what they are going through or force themselves to be something different. That's not it. You live the life you have and go through what you need to go through, but you do it with an awareness of something greater. Keep your heart turned toward the highest, and that will change everything. When life pulls you into drama, you don't have to get lost in it. You don't need to judge yourself

or others. You simply remind yourself—*this isn't all there is. There is something higher, and that's where I'm going.*

This path isn't about struggle; it's about surrender. If you let go, if you stop resisting, life itself will pull you forward. Everything you experience, every challenge, every difficulty, is there to help you grow. When you hold on to that truth, even pain and loss become part of the process of liberation. You don't need to push away what's happening—you just need to stop resisting. Keep your eyes on that higher place, and trust that what you're going through will take you exactly where you need to be. That's how you walk this path of surrender.

13-5

How can one maintain a spiritual focus without intense strain during purification periods?

The first thing to understand about purification is that it's a perfectly natural process. It happens when it's meant to happen. Your job is not to control it, but to cease to resist it. Learn how to let go—not just during an intensive retreat or when doing a dedicated spiritual practice, but in the midst of your daily life. Every moment presents an opportunity to release something inside you that is holding you back.

A common mistake people make is thinking they have to go through a period of extreme spiritual focus—like three months of deep practice—and then return to their normal way of living. That's not how real growth works. That's like going on an extreme diet, losing weight, and then eating junk food again. Instead of separating spiritual work from daily life, integrate it into every single moment. Use your relationships, your work, your interactions—everything—as a means to let go of yourself and turn toward something higher.

You don't need special time set aside to do this. There's time within the time. While you're working, while you're in a conversation, while you're feeling frustrated—there's always a space within that moment to let go. You don't have to wait for some designated spiritual practice to do the inner work. The world will bring up exactly what you need to let go of, and when it does, you simply release. That's what purification really is—it's life showing you what's inside of you, and your job is to let it pass through without resisting.

It is true that sometimes things will come up intensely. You might feel fine one day and then suddenly be overwhelmed by emotion or resistance. That's okay. That's part of the process. If you make purification a natural part of your daily life, it won't feel like some huge, overwhelming ordeal—it will simply be how you live. The middle way, the way of balance, is to use every experience as an opportunity to let go. When you do that, you'll find that spiritual focus isn't something you need to maintain with effort—it becomes the natural state of your being.

13-6

I'm doing a mantra more intensively, but it feels like the mental chatter fights back even harder. Should I keep pushing through it, or is there a better approach?

When you do a mantra, it's not about fighting with your thoughts. If you use it like a sledgehammer—trying to beat your thoughts down, trying to make them stop—you're just creating more inner resistance. That's the mind fighting with itself. When the mind fights with itself, there's no real winner. You don't want to use the mantra as a tool of suppression or control. That will only make the mental chatter push back even harder, just as you're experiencing.

Instead, let mantra be a means to make a shift in your consciousness. When you use mantra, you're not trying to get rid of thoughts; you're simply choosing to place your awareness somewhere else. Your mind has layers—you know that. You can be doing one thing while thinking about another. Doing mantra is a way to shift into a higher layer of mind, where you're not entangled with every little thought that arises. Just quietly say the mantra and lean back into it. Don't worry if the thoughts are still there; they can come and go. Your job is not to fight them—your job is to rest your awareness in something higher, something lighter.

Over time, your consciousness will start to prefer that higher space. Just like when a song gets stuck in your head, it keeps pulling you back to it. The mantra should be like that—soft, gentle, something your awareness can naturally settle into. You're not forcing anything. You're not suppressing anything. You're just letting go. Letting go is always about relaxing, not struggling. Yoga, true spiritual practice, is never about force. It's like judo—you flow with the energy; you don't resist it.

Your personal mind is simply the result of all the stored impressions and blockages from your past. That's why it chatters, why it complains, why it stirs up so much noise. It's just trying to release all that stored energy. Instead of fighting it, try something different—just love it. Like a child who's upset, give it a little compassion. Say, "Hey mind, I hear you. I see you. You're just expressing all the stuff I stored inside. That's okay." Give it a kiss on the forehead, so to speak, and let it be. Then return to your mantra. Not as a weapon, but as a gentle place to rest. You'll see—if you relax into it, the mantra will take care of everything.

13-7

What are your teachings on noticing and embracing thoughts with loving kindness instead of resisting them?

Noticing your thoughts without resisting them is a beautiful practice. Your mind is going to do what it does—thoughts will arise, patterns will play out, and emotions will surface. The question is, what is your relationship with all of that? Most people try to fight with their mind, pushing thoughts away and resisting what arises. But the mind isn't something you need to control—it's something you need to let go of. Instead of fighting with your thoughts, just let them be. Watch them with the same loving kindness you would give to a small child who doesn't know any better.

When you see a thought arise, don't judge it, don't resist it, and don't feed it. Just watch it. Let it be there, and instead of getting caught up in it, place your awareness above it. You don't have to push it away—just recognize that you are the one who sees it. If you can, take it even further. Look at your mind with a little smile and say, "Oh, there you go again." If you can do this with loving kindness toward your mind, you'll notice that the thought starts to lose its hold on you. This is a very powerful method of letting go.

You can also offer those thoughts up. Instead of holding on to them, hand them over—to God, to the Universe, to something higher than yourself. Let them be taken from you. Every time a thought arises that pulls on you, you have a choice: Do you hold on to it, or do you let it go? The moment you choose to let go, you set yourself free.

The most important thing is that you're using your will to rise above the mind, not to reinforce it. The problem isn't the thoughts—it's that you're

getting involved with them. Don't fight or resist them. Just relax, watch, and let go. If you love your thoughts instead of fearing them, they will lose their grip on you. One day, you'll find that you're no longer stuck inside of them—you're resting in the freedom of your own awareness.

13-8

I am struggling with some overwhelming emotions after a breakup. I am not sure if I am relaxing and releasing correctly because my emotions are so intense. How do I maintain clarity while allowing these energies to move through me?

Thank you for sharing. You can be sure you are not alone in experiencing strong emotions after a breakup. Everyone on the path goes through such overwhelming energies at one time or another. There are two different approaches to dealing with overwhelming energy when it comes up. The first is to try to rise above the energy, using techniques that leave you centered in the face of the release. Meditation, mantra, positive thinking, yoga asanas, and other such practices are all techniques for maintaining your center when being pulled into the disturbed energies.

When this is not even close to working, there is another technique you can try. It is not about staying above the disturbance; it is solely about letting it pass through you. For example, when the emotional pain is overwhelming and you can't stay above it, lie down on the floor on your back with your arms out to your sides. Relax your whole body, then raise your chest up toward the ceiling, and offer the energies you're feeling to God, the Divine Mother. Let her take it all from you. You don't have to deal with it; give it to her. She knows how—you don't. Raising your chest up is inviting her to reach her hand in and take it all out. Keep relaxing the area around your heart. Let the disturbed energy release. Love the release, love the pain—it's the pain that ends all pain. It has come to liberate you from yourself. Welcome the process of purification. Childbirth has pain; so does soulbirth. You are not doing anything—you are letting it happen. This is very deep spiritual growth.

13-9

How can I handle profound spiritual experiences without becoming ungrounded?

If you have profound spiritual experiences, don't hold on to them as part of your identity. No matter what you experience—no matter how high, how deep, how expansive—don't let your mind get involved in defining yourself by it. The moment you start thinking, *I had this experience, I must be special, I must be enlightened*, you've lost the very thing the experience was offering you: freedom from your ego. The ego will always try to co-opt positive experiences and make them about you, but that's not the spiritual path. The path is about becoming nobody, not somebody.

The experience itself is not the problem. Spiritual experiences can be beautiful, profound, even life-changing. What matters is what you do with them. If you let the experience shape your self-concept, it will create a separation between yourself and life. You will start living in your mind's idea of spirituality rather than in the reality of the present moment. That's how people get lost. They become disconnected from life, from others, from the very flow of the universe they were trying to merge with.

Instead, take the experience as grace. It's not yours—it was given to you. You didn't create it, you didn't earn it, and you certainly didn't make the universe reveal it to you. Just bow your head and say, "Thank you." That's it. Then go sweep the floor. That's what keeps you grounded. You don't chase the experience, you don't define yourself by it, and you certainly don't let it create distance between you and the simple, ordinary beauty of everyday life.

The real measure of spirituality is not how high you go in a momentary experience, but how balanced and present you are in daily life. If you can't stay open and at peace on this plane, what makes you think you can handle higher planes? If an experience leaves you ungrounded, it wasn't the experience itself but how you related to it. You let the "I" touch it. That's the danger.

So let go. Stay humble. Recognize that the personal self is nothing. When you truly let go of it, something far greater than you can flow through you. That is where real spirituality begins—not in defining yourself as someone who had an experience, but in becoming nobody so that Truth itself can move through you, untouched.

13-10

What is the power of gratitude, and how does it affect perception?

If you want to understand the power of gratitude, you have to stop looking for something specific to be grateful for. Gratitude isn't about picking and choosing—it's about seeing reality as it is and realizing it's all a gift. Just look at what's in front of you right now. Look at the sky, the trees, the people, the fact that you can hear, see, and breathe. Every single moment of existence is an absolute miracle. If you could step back and actually see what's happening—the way trillions of cells work together to form a human body; the way a seed knows how to grow into a plant; the way the entire universe has managed to exist for billions of years—you wouldn't need to manufacture gratitude. You would live in it.

The problem is, you let your mind get in the way. It decides what it likes and doesn't like, what it wants and doesn't want. If you dropped all that, you wouldn't need to change anything to feel gratitude. You'd just prefer whatever is happening. The sun is shining—beautiful. It's raining—amazing. Life is giving you something pleasant—*thank you*. Life is challenging you—*I love it*. Because all of it is miraculously unfolding by itself, all of it is an opportunity to grow.

This isn't some philosophical game—it's the highest form of living. When you are truly grateful, you are in harmony with life itself. Gratitude isn't intellectual; it's not about comparing what you have to what others have or trying to convince yourself to appreciate something. It's about waking up to the fact that right here, right now, you are witnessing the unfolding of something far greater than yourself. Instead of fighting with life, you surrender in awe.

You might think you need a reason to be grateful, but the truth is gratitude is the natural state of a clear mind. The only reason you don't feel it all the time is because your mind gets caught up in preferences, judgments, and personal narratives. The deeper you let go, the more you'll see that every single moment is a gift. When you live that way, life becomes effortless. Gratitude isn't something you practice—it's something you become.

The Real Spiritual Teacher

You don't have to go looking for your spiritual teacher—your teacher has already found you. It's called life. Every moment, every challenge, every inner reaction is here to show you exactly what you need to let go of in order to be free. Books and gurus can point the way, but the real teacher is the unfolding of your own life and your willingness to stay open to it. The question isn't whether a teacher will appear; it's whether you'll drop the walls of ego and receive what life is already giving to you. In this chapter, we'll explore your questions about true guidance and how it doesn't come from outside—it comes from your own sincerity, your openness, and your commitment to letting go in the face of life as it is.

14-1

Can we learn everything we need from books, or do we need a spiritual teacher?

The answer is that life itself is your teacher. You don't have to go looking for a guru, because every single moment of your life is teaching you exactly what you need to learn. The real question is: Are you paying attention? Are you willing to let go and surrender to what life is showing you? Because that's where the real growth happens.

Books can help. Teachers can help. They can point you in the right direction, offer clarity, and help you see things you might not have seen on your own. But in the end, the work is yours. You have to deal with your life. You have to be able to handle your relationships, your job, and your responsibilities. You have to learn to be okay regardless of whether you have money or not and whether things go your way or not. If you don't, then all the books and teachers in the world won't do you any good—because you can still be disturbed by what life throws at you. If you're still clinging to your personal

self and trying to make life be the way you think it should be, then you're missing the whole point of spiritual growth.

Spiritually, the most important thing is your motive. What do you really want? If your motive is pure—if you genuinely want to let go of yourself, to be free, to grow—then everything will align for you. Life will bring you exactly what you need, whether it's a book, a teacher, a difficult situation, or a moment of insight. It will all serve your journey. And yes, looking back, you may see that you didn't always get it right, that you made mistakes—but that's part of it. You have the right to grow, to change, to evolve.

But if your motive is to build up your ego, to use spirituality to make yourself feel more special, then that's exactly where you'll end up—trapped in yourself. You end up where your motive is. It's not about what happens outside; it's about what's happening inside. The heart of the path is in your willingness to surrender, to let go and trust life.

So, don't worry about whether you need a teacher or a book. Worry about your motive. If you're sincere, life will take care of the rest. Everything you need will come to you at exactly the right time. Just stay open, stay honest, and let go.

14-2

How do I find a guru or spiritual teacher?

When you ask about finding a spiritual teacher, what you're really asking is: *How do I find guidance on this path? How do I make sure I'm moving in the right direction?* The truth is, when you're truly ready, the teacher appears. That's how it works. Not because you went out and found them, but because your sincerity opened the door for them to come into your life—whether as a person, a book, an experience, or even an inner knowing.

You don't need to go searching. Every master that has ever walked the face of the earth—living or passed—will help you if you are truly open. The grace and guidance you are looking for is always there. A great master once said that grace is everywhere, pouring down like rain. But we hold up the umbrella of ego, making sure we don't get wet. We protect ourselves from the very thing we're asking for. The question isn't, *Where do I find grace?* The question is, *Am I willing to put down the umbrella?*

Your real work is not going out to find a guru—it's letting go of yourself. Let go of the mental noise that says the answers are always outside you and that you need to find them. The moment you stop clinging to that, you'll see that life itself is grace. Everything you need is already coming to you. But if you insist on holding on to your fears and doubts, and your constant need for more than what life is already giving you, you'll miss it. Let go, trust, be open, and you will know everything you need to know.

14-3

Do the teachings of Christ relate to yoga, and if so, how?

Yes, Christ's teachings absolutely relate to yoga—because yoga, in its highest sense, is about union. It's about letting go of the personal self and merging with something much greater. That's what Christ was pointing to. When he said to turn the other cheek, he wasn't just talking about an external action. He was talking about what happens inside of you. Life is going to come at you—it always does. People will say things; situations will challenge you; difficulties will arise. What did Christ say to do? Let go; don't resist; stay open. That's what it means to turn the other cheek. You turn away from resistance and allow life to pass through you without disturbance. That's inner freedom.

Look at what else he said. He told you that as he sits in the presence of the Father, you are meant to sit there too. He didn't say, "I'm up here and you're down there." No, he basically said, "You will do even greater things than I have done." That's an extraordinary statement. What does it mean? It means that the state he reached is available to you, to everyone. That's the highest yoga. It's not about bending your body into poses; it's about transcending the personal self—rising above that little mind that gets caught up in fear, judgment, and resistance. It's about merging with something much greater, stepping into a state of pure openness, pure presence, just like he did. Christ called it *dying to be reborn*.

When you honor Christ, or Buddha, or any great being, you're not worshipping a person. You're honoring the state they reached, the state they encouraged you to reach. That's a very beautiful thing. It's an inspiration, a reminder of what's possible. That's why as you grow and you deepen your understanding of yourself, you will deepen your respect for Christ and the

great masters. They weren't just teaching rules or morality; they were teaching the highest truth—the path to absolute liberation.

14-4

How can I spread the truth about higher consciousness to people who are resistant or rooted in traditional beliefs?

If you want to help people wake up, don't focus on changing them—focus on bringing the highest version of yourself into every moment. That's how you truly spread truth. You don't have to argue with people's beliefs. Just be the presence of truth, be the embodiment of openness, peace, and clarity, and that alone will have an effect far beyond what you can imagine.

People are at different levels of receptivity, and you can't control when or how someone will be ready to hear something deeper. You may say something, and it seems like it goes nowhere, but years later, when their life shifts, they remember. That's how truth works—it plants a seed. Sometimes that seed sits dormant for years, and then one day, when the right conditions arise, it blossoms. It's not your job to force that timing; it's your job to share truth as purely and openly as you can, then let go.

If you try to push against people's beliefs, you'll meet resistance. If you simply live in truth, embodying a higher way of being, people will feel it. They may not even realize what's happening, but something inside them will shift. When the time is right, they will remember that feeling. That's how transformation happens—not through force, but through the quiet power of presence.

Don't worry about changing anyone. Don't worry about who agrees with you or who doesn't seem interested. Just keep growing, keep expanding, keep deepening your own connection to truth. When you do that, people around you will shift naturally, because truth is contagious. You don't have to convince anyone of anything—just be the light, and the rest will take care of itself.

14-5

How can I support my partner without becoming frustrated when they don't adopt the same teachings I follow?

If you truly want to support your partner without frustration, stop trying to be their teacher. It is not your job to fix them, change them, or get them to follow the same teachings you do. The moment you take on that role, you've made it about you—about your need for them to be your way, about your discomfort with how they are. That's not love, and it's certainly not surrender. Instead of focusing on whether they are growing the way you think they should, turn inward. Use the relationship as a way to let go of yourself, to release whatever is causing your frustration.

Your responsibility in a relationship is not to impose your spiritual path onto someone else. It's to bring the highest version of yourself into the relationship. Be a source of love, of kindness, of unwavering presence. If you can show up with deep acceptance and embody peace instead of preaching it, that alone will do more to inspire change than any teaching can. People don't change because you tell them to; they change because they feel something in you that touches them at a deeper level.

What if they never change? Then that's reality, and your work is to accept it. A true spiritual path isn't about controlling the outside world—it's about learning to be okay with exactly what is. If your partner comes to you and asks for guidance, by all means, share it. If they don't, your role is to love them as they are, without judgment, resistance, or frustration. The moment you stop needing them to be different, you'll find that your disturbance disappears on its own.

Spiritual growth isn't about others. It's about you. If you feel frustrated because someone else isn't growing the way you want, that's your work. That's what you need to let go of. Use the relationship for your own growth—release your expectations, surrender your resistance, and bring the highest version of yourself into every moment. Allow life to take care of the rest. That is the greatest gift you can offer, both to your partner and to yourself.

14-6

How can I respond to people who think spiritual growth requires worldly success first?

If someone believes that worldly success must come before spiritual growth, you don't need to argue with them. You can simply say, "That's beautiful." It's beautiful that they have aspirations, that they believe certain things will help them on their path. That's where you leave it. Let them find out for themselves. There is nothing you can say to talk them out of the stage they're in. Everyone moves through life in their own way, at their own pace. If you want to help, begin by honoring that truth.

Ultimately, the most powerful thing you can do is to live the teachings. If you carry yourself with peace, with clarity, with inner joy, it will have an effect on others. Over time, they will see that you have changed, that you are centered in a way that has nothing to do with external success. That's the real teaching—not words, but the way you live.

Great masters understand this. When someone comes to them and says, "I feel like I need success, I need pleasure, I need to explore life in this way," the response isn't to correct that person or to try to stop them. Instead, it's to say, "That's beautiful. If that's what you need, then go through it. Just take God with you." Whatever you do, bring awareness, bring presence, bring consciousness into it.

Spiritual growth isn't about rejecting life—it's about bringing the divine into every aspect of life. No one can force another person to grow before they're ready. If someone thinks success is necessary first, let them follow that path. In time, they will see for themselves what is truly fulfilling. Your role isn't to convince them otherwise. Your role is simply to stay open, be an example, and hold a space for love and understanding. That is the deepest way to support someone on their journey.

RIGHT ACTION





Decision Making

Most people think decision-making is about figuring out what will lead to the best personal outcome. But the truth is, it's not about the outcome—it's about where you're coming from when you make the choice. If you're acting from fear, need, or personal preference, your decision is coming from the noisy part of you that's trying to rearrange the world in order to feel okay inside. But what if you already felt okay inside? What if you could let go of that inner pressure and make decisions from a place of clarity for the benefit of the overall situation? In this chapter, we'll explore your questions about how true decision-making begins with surrender—releasing your attachment to results and learning to let life unfold while you stay centered in the Self.

15-1

The Surrender Experiment makes it seem like you never say no to what is presented to you. How do you distinguish between saying no because of personal resistance versus rejecting a genuinely bad choice?

The teachings are not that you should always say yes to everything or avoid asserting will when it's needed. Surrender is about letting go of your reactive responses and dealing with things from a place of clarity and logic. It is not about doing or not doing—it is about your deepest inner intent.

If you are saying yes because your lower tendencies and habits are driving you to do so, you should try saying no, in order to challenge the power those lower forces have over you. Likewise, if you are saying no because of a stubborn streak that you simply don't want to rise above, then you should try saying yes, if for no other reason than to free yourself from those shackles. In the end, it isn't about yes or no; it's about your willingness to free yourself so that you can act from the highest place within you.

We are here to learn and grow from our experiences in life. The actual outside events and their outcomes are far less important than the transformation they put us through. Once you truly feel that you are willing to go beyond the petty likes and dislikes that the mind makes up, you will begin to make decisions that come from a deeper place. As you willingly let go of the habitual thoughts and emotional patterns that bind you to the limits of your personal self, you will naturally begin to be guided by an overwhelming sense of love and service to life.

15-2

When is the voice in my head just a thought, and when is it actually me? If I have to think through a major life decision, isn't that "me" doing it? If I ignore that voice, how do I make decisions?

The voice of the mind is never you—you are the one who is aware of the voice. You are the one who is watching the mind try to decide whether to change your career or move abroad or do anything else. Those are thoughts; they are just something you are aware of. Even the uncomfortable feeling that you need to make a decision is not you. You are the one who is aware of all the commotion and anxiety being generated around this decision. Before you can interact properly with life, you must first establish yourself in the seat of Self by letting go of the mind's noise.

Once established in your seat of consciousness, you will see that nothing your mind ever says is you. Just as your reflection in a mirror is never you—it is simply something you are seeing—so the mind's thoughts are never you; they are simply something you are seeing. But just because you are not the mind doesn't mean you cannot use the mind. The mind is meant to be used. The question is, are you using it properly? Most of the thoughts you hear in your mind are personal thoughts—they are about what you want or don't want. Those thoughts are unnecessary, and your spiritual work is to learn not to listen to those thoughts. Such personal thoughts are just noise interfering with your ability to harmonize with the flow of life.

That doesn't mean that the analytical mind is not helpful. The mind is brilliant—it is an amazing tool for analyzing and creating. The mind created the computer, the rocket ship, and air conditioning—it is awesome! By all means, use it constructively to create and build and learn.

15-3

If we are meant to surrender to life's unfolding, how do we make decisions? My mind keeps going over and over the possible choices in the situation I'm in. How do I navigate this?

I cannot help you make a decision one way or another, but I can help you explore the basis of decision-making. Decisions are difficult because we are trying to use them to get what we want and avoid what we don't want. We are trying to use them to take care of our attachments, desires, and fears. When you are truly letting go of yourself, and have done so for a long time, decisions seem to fade away by themselves—there is just interaction with what is in front of you. That doesn't mean that you won't participate in change outside. Everything still happens—it just happens in accordance with God's laws, instead of your desires. You still have things to do, but you are no longer acting out of the personal motives of need and fear.

A great being interacts in this world out of the sheer joy and love of interacting. If something in front of you can be improved and raised, then you put your whole being into it. You do the best you can at whatever you interact with, just for the joy of the interaction. You are not seeking the fruits of your actions—your actions are simply the expression of the love you feel for everything and everyone around you. You are fine no matter what happens, and you honor and respect whatever is put in front of you. This is the Dharma. The key is: Once you are in a self-sustained state of contentment within, you won't be trying to use life to make you okay—you are already okay. At this stage, decisions carry no pressure. They carry excitement about what will come next, regardless of what path unfolds.

In the meantime, relax and enjoy making a choice if you need to. Take the pressure off and enjoy your life. Whatever choice you make, put your whole heart and soul into that path. Never look back; never second-guess yourself. Just use the path you have chosen to let go of your personal doubts and fears and be happy to live each day. If you always do this, you will always have made the right decision.

15-4

Can you clarify the difference between judgment and discernment? For example, how do I avoid judgment while still using discernment in work or practical situations?

In order to make rational decisions, of course you use discernment. But discernment is not judgment. Judgment is when you impose your personal preferences, fears, or conditioning onto a situation. It's when you decide that someone is good or bad, right or wrong, based on your own likes and dislikes. That's very different from simply seeing what is in front of you and making a rational decision.

There is nothing wrong with rational thinking—it's a wonderful thing. The problem is when the mind is being used to serve your personal self instead of serving truth. If you fall in love with someone and then find out they are already married, you probably should use discernment. That's not judgment; that's clarity. If you are hiring someone for a position and one candidate is more qualified than the other, choosing the right person isn't judgment—it's simply making a clear decision based on the reality of the situation.

Judgment happens when you bring your personal self into it. "I don't like them because they are different from me. I don't approve of what they do." That's personal, and it only happens when you are not okay inside yourself. If you were okay, you wouldn't need to judge—you would just see. You would respond appropriately to the moment without adding your personal noise to it. That's the difference.

Learn to observe yourself. Are you making choices based on your personal likes and dislikes, or are you using objective discernment? If there's resistance, frustration, or a sense of superiority, then you're in judgment. If there's clarity, ease, and no inner struggle, then you're using discernment. Let your decisions flow from reality, not from your personal mind. You will make much better decisions, and you will move through life with more joy and freedom.

15-5

I often struggle with making personal decisions and feel paralyzed by the fear of making the wrong choice. How can I overcome this?

Of course you're struggling with decisions—how could you not? Look at what you're asking your mind to do. You want it to tell you which choice will make you happy and which one will make you suffer. Your mind doesn't know this. It only knows what it has experienced before, and it hasn't yet experienced the current choice. So the mind starts trying on different scenarios like outfits in a dressing room—spinning them around, analyzing them from every angle—but nothing quite fits. That's why you feel stuck—you're asking your mind to do something it simply can't do.

At its core, most decision-making is simply an attempt to be psychic. You're trying to predict the future and make sure you won't regret your choices. With difficult decisions, your mind doesn't really know which path will lead to happiness. Yet you keep going back to it, expecting it to figure it out. It's like using a broken calculator and getting frustrated when it won't give you the right answer. Stop all the struggling and admit the truth: your mind doesn't know, and that's okay. Instead of obsessing over which choice is right, recognize that you're going to be fine either way. Your well-being isn't determined by these external circumstances—it's determined by you.

If you want to break free from this paralysis, you need to transform your entire approach. Instead of trying to force a decision, just relax. Let go of the idea that one choice is going to make everything perfect and the other will ruin your life. That's not how it works. You will be fine either way because you're going to choose to be fine. Once you stop making it all so heavy, you'll notice something incredible: a natural flow will emerge. If you stay open, life will start giving you information, little clues about which way to move. You're not deciding—you're gathering information. At some point, the decision will simply unfold, without all the mental commotion.

Simply take a step back. Tell your mind it doesn't have to figure it out. Its job is to relax, be open, and pay attention to what is unfolding. Once you know you will be okay either way, life becomes an exciting adventure instead of a struggle. In the end, life has much more to give you than you could ever take from it.

15-6

How does intent influence major life decisions, such as career or relationships?

Your intent is everything. It's not about whether you choose one career over another, or whether you enter a relationship or stay single. The real question is: Where are you coming from when you make these decisions? Are you acting from a place of clarity and openness, or are you trying to fix something inside yourself by rearranging the world outside? If your intent is to find happiness through external circumstances—the perfect job, the perfect partner, the perfect path—you're setting yourself up for suffering. None of those things will ever be exactly what you think they should be.

Instead of looking outward for fulfillment, turn your attention inward. See if your intent is being driven by personal need, by the idea that something outside is going to make you okay inside. If that's your intent, then you're using career, relationships, or even spirituality as a means of escape rather than as a way to grow. The key is to stop using life to try to fix yourself. Instead, use life to let go of what's blocking you from already being okay. That's a very different approach.

You don't avoid making choices. You still choose a career, you still enter relationships, but you do it with a different intent. You do it because it's what's unfolding in front of you, not because you think it will complete you. When challenges arise, and they will, use them to let go of the parts of you that resist and cling. Imagine if two people entered a relationship not to get something from each other, but as a way to let go of themselves—to support each other in releasing whatever gets in the way of unconditional love. That's a whole different level of being.

Stop defining yourself by what you do, who you're with, or what path you take. None of those things are you. You are the one experiencing them. Keep your intent pure—let life unfold, use each moment to grow, and stop thinking anything outside of you is going to solve your inner struggles. When you live that way, your decisions stop being a source of stress. They simply become part of the beautiful unfolding of life.

15-7

What made you decide to dedicate your life to helping others?

In a life of total surrender, you don't decide to help people. That's not how it works. You don't sit there and say, "I want to be a spiritual teacher who helps others." That's just the mind trying to create an identity, trying to take ownership of something that isn't personal. You let go of yourself, and life unfolds in a way that serves the greater whole. If you let go—if you truly surrender—all of this happens by itself.

You don't have to figure out what you're supposed to do. You just have to stop interfering. You let go of the noise in your mind: what you want, what you don't want, who you like, who you don't like—all of it. You leave space, and something much greater than you moves through that space and serves unconditionally. That's how you serve. Not by deciding, but by getting out of the way. When you truly surrender, life flows in a way that lifts everything around you.

15-8

I am struggling with making a decision to undergo surgery, given its potential risks. How does surrender apply when a person is faced with difficult decisions where there is no clear choice?

Spiritual surrender is never about not making a decision—it's about using the situation, as difficult as it may be, to let go of your personal self. The truth is, your personal mind and emotions don't know what to do, and that's why you are struggling so much. Surrender starts with accepting that reality: *I have an illness, and I don't know the best way to proceed with treatment.* That better be okay with you, because it's the truth.

Once you are at peace with the fact that there is no clear answer as to the best path forward, you accept that you are not in control of the outcome. No matter what you choose, you might have been better off the other way. You will never know the answer to that, and that is where acceptance becomes essential.

Now comes the really deep part. Once you are at peace with all of this, choose a path forward that is not based on fear. Fear does not make good decisions—cull out any options that are based merely on fear. What may be left are two or more options that seem equally reasonable, given the information you have at the time. Fine—since there is no way of knowing which will yield the best outcome, choose one, and be at peace that you did your absolute best. Let that choice be your solid ground. Never look back or second-guess based on hindsight. Honor the situation, honor your decision, and honor the results.

This is surrender, and it leads to the highest inner states. This is how you use difficult situations to free yourself from yourself. If you are a spiritually oriented person, offer it to God: “I did my best to serve the situation put before me, now I place it all in the hands of reality. I am at peace with the whole thing.” I know this is very deep, and it may seem impossible, but you are in there, and you are higher than all the noise your mind is making.

Now you understand that surrender is something you do inside yourself. It always involves letting go of personal fears and desires in order to live life from a place of absolute clarity and peace.

Career and Work Life

Your job isn't separate from your spiritual path—it is your spiritual path. Emails, meetings, deadlines, even the frustrations with coworkers—these are the very moments life gives you to let go, to grow, and to serve. The question isn't whether work is spiritual; the question is whether you are bringing spirituality into work. Are you reacting from ego and stress, or are you showing up with clarity, presence, and a surrendered heart? In this chapter, we'll explore your questions about how your career can become a living practice—not by quitting or escaping, but by doing your best and letting go of the rest. This is how you turn ordinary work into a path to extraordinary freedom.

16-1

How can we use the practice of surrender to grow and act with higher leverage in business or professional life?

The key to using surrender as a tool for growth in business or professional life is to stay conscious and open in the face of what is unfolding in front of you. Life is always presenting you with moments—phone calls, emails, meetings, unexpected demands. The question is, can you meet those moments with clarity and presence instead of resistance, worry, or stress? That is the practice. Instead of getting caught up in anxious thoughts about how much there is to do, stay centered and handle what is right in front of you with a calm, open heart. This is how you turn your professional life into a spiritual path.

Business, especially at higher levels, always involves more work than you can possibly complete. That's just the nature of it. You will never get it all done, so the real question is, how do you handle that reality? Most people spend their energy stressing about what they aren't getting done, which drains them and makes them less effective. You can take a different approach. You

can stay centered, do the best you can with what's in front of you, and then let go. The work will always be there, but your inner state doesn't have to be dictated by it.

A practical way to apply this is to prioritize. When you do what is truly necessary first, you will find that some things simply fall away. If something is important, it will come back to you. If it doesn't, then it was never that urgent to begin with. Instead of chasing every task with anxiety, you learn to flow with what actually needs your attention. You're not controlling everything—you're aligning yourself with what naturally unfolds. That's a whole different way of engaging with work, and it makes you far more effective than those around you who are lost in stress and overthinking.

Use business as a practice of surrender. Be fully present with each task, but don't attach yourself to the outcome. Accept what comes, do what you can, and let go of what you can't. In doing this, you will not only excel in your work, but you will also grow spiritually. That growth will set you apart—not because you're forcing success, but because you're operating from a place of clarity, balance, and trust. That's the highest leverage you can have.

16-2

I run a successful business. How do I approach business decisions while remaining aligned with the practice of surrender?

Amazingly, the answer you seek is the essence of the teaching in the Bhagavad Gita. Though it is considered a holy book—some say even the Hindu Bible—its teachings are very practical in regard to the highest way to interact with life. In a nutshell, it says do the absolute best at whatever you are doing, but don't do it for personal gain—do it as an act of service to the Universe. You don't surrender doing your best; you surrender the personal motives for doing or not doing what is put before you.

You are a businessperson running a business the Universe has given to you. You do business just as any other excellent businessperson would do it. But you renounce the fruits of your actions. You are not doing it for you—you

are doing it as an expression of perfection. Make good business decisions—not out of fear or greed, but out of rational, clear judgement based on what's best for the business. Make believe God came down and gave you this business to run for Him. It's not yours—you are running it for Him. Now, do your best to run it to the best of your ability—fearlessly and selflessly.

16-3

I have spent years exploring goal and intention setting, but it seems more natural to surrender to life's flow. Does goal setting have a place in spiritual practice?

There is nothing wrong with intention or goal setting. The question is, on what basis are you setting those intentions and goals? If you're setting your intentions based on needs, fears, or desires, then the best that will happen is that needs, fears, and desires will be guiding your life. From a spiritual point of view, no meaningful success can come from that.

A spiritual person works at a much deeper level than fears and desires. If you set your life's aspirations on the highest aspects of yourself, you'll quickly notice that fears and desires are what keep you from your God-realized state. It will become obvious that you must relax through the powerful draw of these very human, psychological aspects of your being. This cannot be done in one fell swoop. You have to learn how to let go of the pull of the personal on a moment-to-moment, day-by-day basis. Start from where you are by honestly recognizing the root cause of your fears and desires. You're still in your daily life, but instead of putting your will into getting or avoiding, you put your will into constantly relaxing and releasing.

Amazingly, as you let go of yourself, you will know what you are supposed to be doing. Your life becomes a moment-to-moment service to the unfolding of life. The personal falls off, and what is left is what we call the Dharma—that which you would be doing if you had no personal motive but were simply here to serve God. This is called "The Pathless Path," and it stretches from where you are now to the perfection of your merger with God.

16-4

What is the difference between striving for excellence and being trapped in perfectionism? I am struggling with the balance between accepting life as it unfolds and doing my best to serve it.

Surrender is not about being passive or lazy. The flow of life will always give you work and service to do, and by all means, do the best you can with all your tasks in life. The difference between doing your best and being a perfectionist all comes down to your root intent. If you are striving to do your best out of love for expressing yourself and giving your best to life as an act of service and beauty, this is a great spiritual practice. If you are striving to do the best you can because you are neurotic about making everything perfect and are driven by perfectionism out of fear of failure or disapproval, then your intent is coming from a place of disturbance. Striving for excellence comes from enthusiasm, love, and inspiration and has nothing to do with others, except the Creator of the Universe, who gave you the ability to serve with all your heart.

If you feel the act of doing your best is coming from a place of disturbance, then work on letting go of those fears while you still strive to do your very best. The key is to let go of the personal, do your very best, then be happy with whatever comes back. The outcome of the best that you can do is a very beautiful and honorable thing, regardless of how the outside world judges it.

16-5

I am passionate about building my business and also very committed to my spiritual growth. How do the concepts of surrender and non-doership work together with building a successful outer life?

The short answer is that the cleaner you are inside, the more natural your outer life will be. It all comes down to motive—why are you making plans and striving outside? If you are not okay inside and are striving externally to try to be okay, that is a very difficult life: trying to fix the inside with the outside. If, on the other hand, you are wonderful inside—filled with energy, love, and inspiration—and you are expressing that outside, that is a totally different story. Expressing your inner beauty outside can certainly involve planning and putting your whole being into your work. First, fix the inside so

that you are whole and complete within yourself, then do your absolute best to express your inner greatness in the world—if for no other reason than love wants to give and inspiration wants to create.

This is what it means “to be in the world but not of it.” The fact is, you live inside, and once you cleanse the inside of all the blockages you have accumulated, your energy will be free to flow abundantly. Life will then naturally give you service to do—that is what is meant by the Tao and your Dharma. There are no desires or personal motives. You are a whole being in harmony with the flow of life. Once you do the inner work to transcend the personal, there is no conflict between completely surrendering inside and doing your absolute best to serve outside.

16-6

How do I balance a hectic, demanding life with the need for inner peace and devotion? Do I need to find the time to slow down, turn inward, and overcome stress and energy blockages with spiritual practices?

Stress is not due to how busy you are. Stress is due to how much resistance you are asserting while you are doing what you are doing. Work is not stress; it is service to the universe. God has given you a task to do while you spin around dark, empty space. It has no real meaning except as an act of service. We are all going to die soon, and we are not going to take anything of this world with us. Stress is caused by ego thinking there is something to get and something to lose. We constantly feel that whatever we are doing is not enough. There are always other things we must be doing to succeed and not fail.

The secret to life is to do your best at whatever you are doing in the moment, and then serve what comes next. Renounce the fruits of your actions and let the joy of service be your sole intent—every moment. Working, taking care of family, taking care of others—all of it is a gift you are giving to God. That is how to feel close to God in the midst of daily life. Offer everything you do as an act of devotion to God.

If you are taking on too many tasks and getting overwhelmed, ask yourself why you are doing that. Is it fear of failure? Is it to gain acceptance and not feel rejected or criticized? Those are all ego issues. Don't serve your ego; serve God. There is a natural balance, but you will never find it until you devote yourself to the Universal Flow instead of your ego. Read *Living Untethered*

and start with the small stuff you are bothering yourself about. An important quote from that book is, “The moment in front of you is not bothering you. You are bothering yourself about the moment in front of you.” Stop doing that, and the stress will melt away. Meditation and time in quietude are also very helpful. Do what you can, but don’t make it just another source of stress. Let it be another act of service.

16-7

How do I approach my sales job and caregiving for my father without becoming overwhelmed or feeling unsuccessful?

Your job and your caregiving are not separate from your spiritual path—they are your spiritual path. The idea that spiritual practice only happens when you meditate or listen to talks, and then you have to go back to your “real life,” is an illusion. Life itself is your practice. Your sales calls, your father’s illness, your frustrations, your disappointments—these are all opportunities for growth. The real work is not about changing those external situations; it’s about letting go of the part of you that resists them. That’s where the suffering comes from—not from what’s happening, but from your reaction to it.

Start to watch yourself. You’ll see how certain things make you uncomfortable—maybe a rejection on the phone; maybe something difficult with your father. Notice how the mind starts creating resistance: *I don’t like this. I wish this wasn’t happening. This is hard. This isn’t fair.* That’s what is causing the disturbance, not the situation itself. Your job isn’t to fix the outside world so that it matches what you want—it’s to let go of the part of you that insists on things being a certain way. Whenever you notice tension and resistance, just relax, breathe, and let it go. You won’t be perfect at it, and that’s okay. Just keep practicing.

As you do this, something remarkable starts to happen. The very things that used to bother you don’t disturb you anymore. The caregiving, the sales calls, the challenges—they don’t change; you do. Because you’re not wasting your energy resisting, you’re actually performing better. If you’re relaxed and open, you’re naturally more effective. If you fight everything, you’re tight, you’re reactive, and you suffer.

This is your spiritual work. You’re not escaping your responsibilities but using them as a means to let go of yourself. That’s freedom. That’s peace.

The very same life that once overwhelmed you can become your doorway to liberation.

16-8

I struggle with colleagues who are driven by ego, fear, and greed. How do I interact with negative people in my work environment while staying true to spiritual principles?

The key is to always let go of your personal reactions first. If you find that you feel resistance to someone whose behavior is coming from a place of ego, let go of the part of you that is not able to handle that. You will find in many cases that the highest thing you can do with someone's negative behavior is to let go of your resistance. The very fact that you aren't pushing their negative energy back at them can transform the relationship.

Of course, there are times when a situation calls for action. In those cases, first let go of your personal reactions and preferences, then act from the highest clarity available to bring about the best possible outcome. I know it is hard to believe at first, but if you drop your resistance, you can actually take the attitude of serving the people around you—even if they are not so spiritual. That is good for you and good for them.

16-9

I'm a business owner and challenged with managing negativity among employees. What is the balance between stepping in and taking control of the situation versus allowing life the time to naturally work it out?

Surrender is about letting go of your reactive response and then dealing with things from a place of clarity and logic. It is all about your intent. If you are letting go sincerely, and circumstances are such that you need to take action for the good of the employees and your company, first let go of your reactive energies, then act from a place of clarity.

Let your actions come from sincerely seeking the best overall solution to the situation. Be sure to listen to the issues your employees are having, and then work consciously to bring about the highest outcome possible for all parties.

That said, there will be times that you simply have to let an employee go because of the disruptive energy they insist on creating. You are the boss, and it is your responsibility to create a productive work environment for your employees. But don't do it because you can't handle the situation. Do it because you can handle the situation, and this is the best way to move forward.

16-10

Is it helpful for my growth to have other goals besides spiritual realization?

The answer is yes—because the highest realization naturally includes engaging with life. It's not about isolating yourself on some mountaintop or cutting yourself off from the world. It's about bringing higher energy into everything you do. You don't have to become a priest, a monk, or some spiritual recluse. You can live in the world. You can have relationships. You can run a business. The real question isn't whether you should have goals—it's whether your goals are rooted in truth. A spiritual life doesn't mean rejecting external goals; it means living in a way that raises everything around you.

That's the highest life you can live. Every moment that unfolds before you is an opportunity to uplift the energy of that moment. When someone yells at you, you don't yell back. You quietly see if there is something you can say or do to uplift the energy being expressed. You walk through life leaving everything better than you found it—not by forcing or controlling, but simply by being in harmony with what is.

The drive for success often stems from a desire to fill an inner void or seek meaning for your life. Spiritual growth encourages addressing these inner needs directly, rather than relying on external achievements for fulfillment. By letting go of attachments to outcomes, you can engage in pursuits with clarity and purpose, making success a byproduct of authentic action rather than an ego-driven goal. This balance allows you to enjoy the process of life while staying aligned with your spiritual values.

So yes, you set goals, but not in the way the world teaches you. Not as a way to get something from life, but as a way to give yourself fully to it. Whether you're leading a company, raising a family, or just walking down the street, you bring that deeper awareness into every action. That's the goal—because in the end, there's no separation between spiritual realization and life itself. They are one and the same.

Relationships

Relationships serve as one of the most powerful arenas for spiritual growth—not because they’re easy, but because they challenge your willingness to let go. Whether it’s your partner, your child, or a coworker, the people in your life have a way of exposing where you are still clinging, resisting, and trying to control. That’s actually a gift. If you’re willing to stay open, to let go of the part of you that wants others to make you okay, then every interaction becomes a chance to rise above yourself. In this chapter, we’ll explore your questions about how to bring your highest self into your relationships—not to make them what you want, but to use each moment as a doorway to unconditional love, deep surrender, and profound transformation.

17-1

Are relationships meant to teach us about overcoming ourselves?

Relationships are about growth. You think you’re looking for someone who aligns with you perfectly, but what you’re really doing is looking for someone who won’t challenge your preferences, your past experiences, or your expectations. That’s not love. That’s you trying to hold on to yourself. The truth is, relationships are one of the greatest opportunities for spiritual growth. This is because they expose the places inside of you where you are still holding on and needing things to be a certain way in order to feel okay.

When you enter a relationship, you open. Your heart opens, your expectations open, and suddenly, things are flowing. But the moment something happens that doesn’t match what you want, you start to close. You think, *Maybe this isn’t the right person. Maybe I made a mistake.* What if the whole point of the relationship isn’t getting what you want? What if it’s about

learning how to stay open, how to let go of yourself, and how to love beyond your personal conditions?

If you were given a relationship where nothing ever challenged you, you would never grow. You would never be pushed beyond your own limitations. That's why there is no such thing as a perfect match—because the world isn't supposed to give you a person who fits all your preferences like a checklist. It's supposed to give you a person who helps you see the parts of yourself that you are still clinging to and having trouble letting go of. If you're willing to use your relationships for your spiritual growth, then any relationship you are committed to can become meaningful.

So don't keep trying to find the one person who won't challenge you. Instead, find the part of you that wants to be challenged, that wants to grow, that wants to love beyond your own limitations. That's what relationships are really for—not to reinforce who you think you are, but to help you transcend into who you really are.

17-2

I have successfully applied the teachings to my family relationships, but I still feel blocked in my relationship with my spouse. Is it really possible to let go of my blockages in this area?

You obviously have been trying to apply the teachings to your life, and relationships are where many people stumble. In truth, relationships are very simple—we make them complicated. If you are not okay inside and you are expecting a relationship to make you okay, you are already off to a bad start. Another human being cannot make you okay—all they can do is distract you from yourself or attempt to compensate for your inner issues. That type of relationship does not work and can never last at a healthy level—especially for someone who is trying to grow spiritually.

In contrast, a healthy relationship starts with the relationship with yourself. If you are giving yourself a hard time in there, how can you expect that someone outside of you is going to make it all okay? First, you have to learn to get along with yourself. You have to learn to let go of the blockages that are holding you back from the highest expression of yourself. This is your work, not someone else's. Once you are committed to working on yourself

and not expecting someone else to make things okay, you can have a healthy, lasting relationship with someone else.

The key to a deep spiritual relationship is there are no expectations that the other person is supposed to be making you okay. That is your job 24/7. The other person is someone you are honored to get to know. There are eight billion people on the planet Earth—you can't get to know all of them. But you can get to know one special person really well. Great! Enjoy getting to know someone who is nothing like you. Their genetics differ from yours; their formative years were very different from yours; their blockages are different from yours—everything is different from you. Good—enjoy the differences. Do not expect the other person to satisfy your needs and protect you from your fears. You should be letting go of your psychological needs and releasing the causes of your psychological fears. Work to bring your highest self into the relationship. Don't think that because this is your significant other, they have to handle your blocked energies. Those blocked energies are your work, not theirs.

If you approach your relationships like this, they will be totally supportive of your highest spiritual growth. Do your inner work, and strive to bring into your relationships the most beautiful, open person you can be. If it's hard to do that, good—that is the spiritual work of letting go of yourself. Bring beauty into this world, and don't expect anything in return—especially from those who are closest to you. Once you have let go of the blockages holding you back, you will start to feel a flow of joy, love, and inspiration rising up within you. This is your natural, unblocked state. By all means, share that unconditional love with all, especially the people closest to you. This love will never subside, as long as you keep letting go of yourself.

17-3

How do I manage relationships while growing spiritually, especially when others don't understand my changes?

If you are growing spiritually and the people around you don't understand, that's okay. You don't have to make them understand. Your job is not to explain yourself or to convince anyone to see things your way. Your job is to stay true to your highest intent. If your growth is real, the relationships in

your life will shift naturally—some will fall away, and others will deepen. That's just how life unfolds. You don't have to force anything, and you don't have to resist anything. Let things move as they need to move.

Relationships are one of the greatest tools for spiritual growth. If you're in one, it's because there's something there for you to work through. It will bring up your attachments, your fears, your expectations—it will show you all the places where you're still holding on. That's a gift. Use it. Let the relationship help you see yourself more clearly. But don't expect the other person to be on the same journey at the same pace. They are where they are, just as you are where you are. When you truly wake up, you don't become more demanding in your relationships—you become more willing to serve. You stop needing the other person to be a certain way, and instead, you live to give.

Commitment is powerful. If you're in a relationship and you've committed to it, then use it as part of your path. Commitment means you don't just walk away because something is difficult, and you don't let your changing spiritual experiences become a reason to push people away. You stay present, and you learn from what arises. Love isn't about taking—it's about giving. If your spiritual growth is real, it will open your heart, not close it. You won't withdraw from people because they don't understand you—you'll just love them anyway. You won't need anything from them, so you'll be free to give them everything.

The key is to let go of yourself. Let go of your need to be understood and your need for others to validate your path. Let life unfold naturally. Some relationships will shift, and that's okay. The ones that are meant to stay will stay. The ones that are meant to change will change. If you stay centered in your highest intent, everything will take care of itself. Keep letting go. Keep surrendering. That's all you ever have to do.

17-4

Is it possible to heal together in a relationship?

If you are in a relationship and looking to heal together, of course you can. A relationship should not be about making the other person conform to what you think you need. It's not about controlling each other to avoid getting hurt. Instead, it's an opportunity to grow together, to use each other as mirrors, and

to support each other in letting go of what keeps you from being fully open. You both have your own inner stuff—the key is to recognize that and choose to love each other while the cleansing process takes place.

The way to do this is to give each other the respect and space needed to go through your changes. Commit to letting go of your own inner disturbances to the best of your ability. In doing so, you create an environment where the other person can do the same. It's not about being perfect. If you fall short, give yourself grace, and give that same grace to your partner as well. That's how you support each other. If both of you are willing to do this, the relationship becomes a sacred place for growth, rather than a battlefield of personal blockages clashing against each other.

There is an even deeper aspect to this—if you truly learn how to perfect your relationship with one person, it won't stop there. It will expand into every aspect of your life. The way you interact with your partner will begin to affect the way you interact with the world. When you practice this kind of love and openness in your relationship, it will naturally extend to coworkers, friends, and even strangers. If someone at work has a bad day and takes it out on you, you will have developed the inner strength to not take it personally. You won't need to react—you'll simply remain open.

That is what it means to truly heal in a relationship. You don't just heal each other; you use the relationship to grow into the kind of person who brings love and openness into every part of life. Eventually, your presence itself becomes a gift, not just to your partner, but to the whole world. That's the real purpose of a relationship—to become more of who you truly are, beyond all the fears and insecurities, until all that's left is love.

17-5

I struggle with knowing when to leave a relationship. If my suffering comes from my ego's preferences, should I stay to grow? How do I know when a relationship is truly unhealthy and not worth continuing?

Of course, we cannot give relationship advice—people need to find their own way through these things. But recognize that the real issue is not the decision of whether to leave; it is the motive behind the decision. Life will unfold, and you have a responsibility to use it for your spiritual growth. Get clear, let go

of your personal motives, and serve the unfolding of life to the best of your ability.

Relationships last when they have deep growth left; they sometimes end when they are holding one or more of the people back. There is nothing wrong with staying, and there is nothing wrong with leaving. The question is: What is the underlying motive? If your motive is to grow spiritually, and the relationship is not creating growth opportunities, that's one thing. If you are simply not open inside and want to look for someone who can better satisfy your personal needs, that's another thing. Be brutally honest with yourself—then make a decision. Make it be the right decision by willfully letting go of the inner turmoil that either decision is going to create.

17-6

I'm in a difficult relationship that I'd like to try to salvage. We tend to close when we're around each other. What can I do to change that dynamic?

We can certainly choose to use our relationships for our inner growth. Based on the honesty you showed in questioning your role in the relationship, you are very capable of doing that. You can make it a game, like a video game. Can you stay centered during the time you are interacting with your partner? If not, try to see why. Is it that the well has been poisoned by past difficult interactions, and now you close the moment you have to interact? If so, practice staying open deep inside while you let go of whatever comes up in your mind and your emotions. Don't make the interaction be about your partner—let it be about you and what you see coming up inside. Be polite and pay attention to what is happening outside, but keep an honest eye on what you are experiencing inside.

This is really a great situation for spiritual growth. As you manage to remain clear and nonreactive during the time you spend together, you will get to see if any of this is just you carrying forward hurt and disappointment from the past. Each time you're together, make believe you have just met—they are a new person every time you interact with them. It can be so much fun and exciting to challenge yourself in this way, and it can completely change the dynamic of the relationship. Just let your intent be to always use the situation to get closer to God, and you can't go wrong.

17-7

How does someone know whether they should leave an abusive relationship?

There are many types of abuse: physical, emotional, and mental. There is no excuse for physical abuse. If a person stays in a physically abusive relationship, they need to examine why they are staying. A clear person understands that their body is a gift from creation, and they have a responsibility to take care of it and treat it with great respect. There may be fears and needs that keep a person compelled to stay in a physically abusive relationship; they need to work on doing their best to rise above these fears and needs so they can move into a healthier environment.

If the abuse is mental or emotional, it's a little subtler. If a person has a closed mind, and that mind considers it abusive if they don't get what they want, that person should use the relationship to be more open and receptive to other people's views. Not getting what you want is not abusive, per se; we need to be able to handle letting go of our mental preferences. However, if a person's partner is purposely going out their way to be mentally or emotionally abusive, that is not a healthy environment and has to be dealt with. In this situation, one should stay calm as much as possible so that clear decisions can be made.

17-8

How can I teach spiritual resilience to a young child who has experienced hardship?

The first thing you need to understand about teaching a child resilience is that you don't teach it through words or structured lessons. You don't sit them down and explain resilience to them. You live it. You embody it. Children watch you, whether you realize it or not. Over time, they absorb what they see in you. If hardship comes into your life—if you face loss, betrayal, or pain—how do you handle it? Do you break down and fall into judgment and anger, or do you move through it with grace, without closing your heart? That's what your children will learn from you.

This isn't about putting on a performance for them. That's not real enough, and children see through that. You're not doing it to set an example—you're doing it because it's the highest way to live. If you love, even when you

are not loved in return, they will see that. If you don't judge, even when others judge you, they will see that, too. One day, when life presents them with their own challenges, they will find something inside themselves that they didn't even know was there. It will be a way of being that they absorbed just by growing up around you.

You don't always know what someone else is getting from you in the moment. Sometimes they don't even know. But years later, they look back, and something clicks. They remember how you handled things, and in a moment of struggle, they instinctively do the same. Maybe they're in a difficult relationship, and they recall how you treated them with patience and kindness when they were being difficult. Maybe they face loss, and something in them remembers the way you walked through your own pain with dignity and openness, without shutting down. That's how they learn. That's how you give them a very special gift. Give them the gift of having experienced how beautiful a human being can be.

17-9

I have a two-year-old daughter. How can I guide her to live with the clarity and freedom I'm now learning to cultivate?

Your daughter's first and most powerful teacher is you—not through words or lessons, but through how you are. From the moment she was born, she has been absorbing everything from you—your energy, your emotions, your state of being. She doesn't just listen to what you say; she feels who you are. So, the greatest gift you can give her is not intellectual teachings, but your own clarity, openness, and presence. If you live in a state of love, peace, and acceptance, she will naturally learn to do the same. If you live with frustration, impatience, or anger, she will learn that too. Your responsibility isn't to shape her into something—it's to purify yourself so that she is naturally surrounded by the highest vibration of being.

At two years old, she is not ready for teachings about the mind, about the Self, or about spiritual practice. But she is ready for presence. She is ready to live in an environment where love flows naturally, where she is safe in the presence of someone who is not caught up in their own struggles. The best thing you can do as a parent is to step aside—to get out of the way. Let go of your personal reactions and mental noise. When you do that, something

much greater than you can come through. What comes through is pure love and compassionate understanding. That is what raises a child. Not your words, discipline or even your conscious efforts, but the energy that flows in your presence.

Take responsibility for yourself. If you are clear, open, and filled with love, that is what your daughter will know. The world will bring her challenges, no doubt. When she has been raised in clarity, she will meet those challenges with clarity. When she has been raised in love, she will move through life with love. She will not have to learn how to handle difficulties—she will simply handle them because she will not be burdened by the same inner noise that keeps most people trapped.

Let your daughter be your inspiration to do this work. If you want to bring something beautiful to her, commit fully to your own surrender. Let go of yourself before you walk through the door of your home. Before you see her, clear yourself. Do not bring your stress, frustrations, or worries into her world. Make it your practice to be a vessel of love in her presence. That is how you become a great parent—by showing her, through the purity of your being, what it is like to live in the presence of a great human being.

This is not just about parenting. It is about all of life. If you want to bring beauty into your daughter's life, bring beauty into everything you do. Bring it into your work, your relationships, and the way you walk through the world. Let go of your own baggage so that you can be a force of clarity and love wherever you are. When you do this, you will not only raise your daughter in light—you will walk through life as a beacon of light itself.

17-10

How do I handle challenges in relationships with my children?

The first thing you must understand is that they are not your children in the sense that your mind thinks. They came through you, but they are their own beings, with their own bodies, their own consciousnesses, their own journeys. If you start with the belief that they belong to you, and that their lives must unfold according to your desires, you will struggle. Instead, step back and recognize that they are souls, just like you, navigating this human experience in their own way.

The real challenge is not your children—it is your inability to handle what they bring up in you. When you say, “I can’t handle my kids,” what you’re really saying is, “I can’t handle the experiences that come with being a parent.” Life is full of experiences, and if you can’t handle them, you don’t just suffer—you become part of the problem. Think about it: if you showed up at a car accident and couldn’t handle the sight of blood, you would be of no use to anyone. The same is true in parenting. If you can’t handle the terrible twos, the teenage years, the heartbreaks, the uncertainties, then not only are you not helping your children, but you are adding unnecessary tension to the entire situation.

Where do you start if you’re having trouble with your children? You start with you. Your job isn’t to control your children’s lives or to make everything go the way you want. Your job is to work on yourself so you can handle whatever comes. If you can handle things, you can be supportive and be a source of strength for your family. But if you’re always caught up in your own fears and anxieties about your children, you are not helping them; you are just adding noise to the situation. Instead, commit to handling life. Say to yourself, *I can handle this. Whatever stage my children are in, whatever they go through, I can handle it.*

Ultimately, the highest truth is that you are not in control. If you can step aside, if you can let go of the neurotic part of you that tries to control everything, then something much higher will flow through you. The real parent is not your small self—it is something divine. And when you get out of the way, that higher force can take care of things in a way your mind cannot. This is how you truly serve as a parent—not by worrying, not by controlling, but by making space for something greater to flow through you.

The next time you feel overwhelmed—stop, breathe, and remind yourself, *I can handle this.* Let go of the mental noise and allow yourself to be a conduit for something higher. That is how you truly help your children—not by gripping tighter, but by bringing clarity into situations as they unfold.

Engaging with the World

The world doesn't need you to be disturbed by what's happening—it needs you to be free enough inside to serve it. There will always be chaos, injustice, and darkness. But the question is: Can you stay centered in peace while standing in the middle of it all? True engagement begins when you stop reacting from personal disturbance and start acting from inner clarity. You're not here to fix the world so you can feel okay; you're here to let go inside so you can bring something beautiful into the world. In this chapter, we'll explore your questions about how to engage with life not from resistance or frustration, but from a deep place of love, strength, and surrender. This is how you become a force for real change—not by fighting life, but by rising above yourself and serving what's in front of you with an open heart.

18-1

In *The Surrender Experiment*, you wrote about letting go of personal preferences and allowing life to unfold. If you do this, how will you know when you really do need to act?

If you want to grow spiritually, the first thing to do is let go of your personal reaction to what life is presenting you. But that's not the end of it. Life is not passive; it's interactive. Once you have let go of your personal self by relaxing through the noise of likes and dislikes, you are left to deal directly with reality, instead of your habit-formed reactions to it. You will know what to do. It is not so complicated, once like and dislike are out of the picture.

For example, if someone is suing you for something you didn't do, you have an obligation to defend yourself. Clearly, there are situations that require action. The key is to remain centered, not reactive, while doing so. If you can

do this, you will find a quiet guidance from within that is easily missed when your mind and your heart are screaming about how you want things to be.

That is an act of inner surrender. First let go of the personal, then see what life is doing and interact appropriately and intelligently. In time, all your interactions with life will seem like acts of service, and they will all be done with a sense of great love. You become a servant of the present moment, and your only goal is to make sure that every moment that passes before you is better off because it did.

18-2

You often talk about letting go of the small stuff, the low-hanging fruit. But what about the more disturbing events in life, like violence, racism, pollution, or severe illness? How can we let go when terrible things are happening in this world?

We understand your desire to address how to let go when it comes to the bigger things in life. The key is that if you aren't practicing regularly with the small things, it will be much more difficult to release the bigger ones, because you haven't learned how to handle your inner resistance. Don't worry about the big stuff right now. Instead, practice every day with every situation that causes inner resistance. The earlier you catch your tendency to resist, and then relax and let go, the easier the process will be.

With that said, you need to understand that when it comes to disharmony in life, there is a spiritual aspect to these things also. You begin by deeply accepting that even these difficult things are part of reality. If you cannot accept this truth, you will become disturbed and incapable of dealing with situations in a productive way. A disturbed person is so absorbed in their inner disturbance that their entire motivation becomes finding a way to end it. They are not really dealing with the outside situation that triggered the disturbance; they are dealing with the inner disturbance itself.

A deep being begins by accepting reality. If something has happened, then it has happened. You cannot undo what has already happened. Acceptance doesn't mean you enjoy what happened; it simply means you can handle the fact that it took place. Find the place of peace within you that does not judge reality but strives to serve it. Ultimately, you learn to honor, respect, and love reality so much that you live and breathe to serve every

moment that unfolds before you. If harmony unfolds before you, rejoice in it. If disharmony unfolds before you, consciously work to raise it as it passes by. All of this is done with a sense of love and honor.

In the end, if you act from a place of disturbance, you are bringing disturbance into this world. If you act from a place of peace, love, and respect, then you are bringing peace, love, and respect into this world. An evolved being is not here to be disturbed by this world—they are here to serve it.

18-3

How can I embody nonviolence (ahimsa) in daily life?

Ahimsa—nonviolence—is not just about how you act in the external world; it is also about how you treat everything that comes up inside of you. It is an absolute commitment to not create violence, and that includes how you interact with your own mind and emotions. If difficult thoughts or feelings come up, you don't push them away. That would be a form of inner violence. Instead, you love them. You allow them to come up, you honor them for the role they played in your growth, and you release them with gratitude.

Loving what comes up inside you is a form of letting go. You are not struggling against your own thoughts, resisting your past, or condemning yourself for what you've been through. When you can love your past fully, it loses its power over you—it dissolves. When you embrace everything inside you, the struggle ends. The Bhagavad Gita says: raise the self with Self; do not trample down the self. That means your work is not to suppress or reject what arises within you, but to uplift it and transform it through love.

This extends beyond just your current situation. Everything that has ever happened to you, even the most difficult experiences, has played a role in shaping who you are. If you look back and see only resentment or regret, that is violence toward yourself. Instead, see that every experience, good or bad, has helped you evolve. The people who hurt you, the relationships that didn't work out, the hardships that tested you—they all gave you something. They made you stronger, wiser, more capable of handling life. Instead of carrying your past as a weight, honor it, love it, and be sure to thank it.

When you live this way, you embody nonviolence at the deepest level. It's not only about not harming others—it's about not harming yourself. It's about meeting life, inside and out, with total openness. No resistance, no

suppression, no struggle. Just a deep, abiding love for whatever comes up, knowing that it is all part of your journey home.

18-4

How can I contribute positively to a chaotic world without being overwhelmed by frustration?

If you find yourself overwhelmed by frustration with the state of the world, you must first recognize reality as it is. There will always be people cutting down trees for profit, leaders waging wars for power, and individuals making choices that seem destructive or ignorant. That is the nature of the world. The real question is not whether these things happen—it's whether you are going to let them disturb your inner state so that you become ineffective, lost in anger, or consumed by despair. If you cannot handle what is happening around you, you cannot help.

Begin by handling it. That means stepping back and realizing that reality is unfolding as it always has, with both beauty and destruction. Your role is not to fight reality with resistance, but to bring something higher into it. You don't have to agree with what's happening, and you don't have to disengage either. What you must do is find a place inside yourself where you can witness the chaos of the world without being thrown off-center. If you allow frustration, hatred, or despair to take hold and overwhelm you, then you are no longer contributing—you are just another person lost in reactivity.

Once you have established that inner steadiness, then you act. You do what you can to help, not because you're upset but because you have something to offer. If that means standing in front of a tree to protect it, do it. If that means working toward solutions in a peaceful, constructive way, do it. But don't do it because you can't handle what is happening; do it because you are strong enough to bring clarity and love into a situation that desperately needs it.

This world does not need more people who are lost in disturbance. It needs people who can stand in the middle of it all and bring light. Let that be your practice. Start with handling the inner disturbance, then bring your best self forward. This is how you contribute to a chaotic world without being overwhelmed by it.

18-5

How do we deal with evil in the world, such as people who harm innocent people?

People have asked many times about the injustices and evils in this world. Interestingly, we don't generally call animals evil when they hurt each other; we understand they are just following their lower instincts. But humans are capable of rising above their lower instincts—if they choose to do so. More importantly, humans have a much more complex psychological aspect of their being—their advanced thoughts and emotions.

When that psychological aspect becomes blocked by suppressed past experiences, many people try to release the blocked energy by acting out externally. This release can be very damaging to those around them. When a person becomes disturbed enough inside, they can become so dark and warped that the only way for them to find release is to harm others. Sometimes they are motivated by some perceived personal gain—but sometimes there is no perceived gain except the release of the darkness that has manifested inside. We view a person who brings such extreme darkness into this world as evil.

Evil is a terrible thing, but it is part of reality. If a river becomes blocked, it floods innocent people who live upstream. If a person becomes blocked, they can hurt innocent people who live around them. The only solution is for people to be taught how to process the difficulties of life instead of suppressing them. That is part of the evolution of humanity. In the meantime, we cannot let other people's disturbances cause us to become blocked. We have to be able to process reality, and then do what we can to raise the world as it passes before us.

18-6

I was in an abusive relationship, and I struggle daily with deep emotional pain and shame. What advice do you have for truly healing?

The experience you struggle with is undoubtedly painful. To begin truly healing, it is important to understand that the process of letting go is the same whether you are letting go of the small stuff or the big stuff, like this. The problem is that if you're not practicing regularly with the small stuff, it will be much more difficult to let go with the big stuff. This is because you

haven't learned how to handle your inner resistance. Start the healing process by practicing every day with all the small situations that cause inner resistance. The earlier you catch your resistance and let go, the easier the process will be. In addition, the energy of fear that is so closely tied to deep emotional pain, such as trauma, tends to show up throughout the day in simple, smaller fears and resistances. If you focus on letting go when these daily fears come up, you will find that, over time, even deep emotional pain can gradually diminish.

Obviously, events can be traumatic and very difficult to deal with when they take place. The key to a beautiful, healthy life is to let go of these painful impressions as soon as possible. The problem is we try to adjust our lives so we don't have to deal with the continuing sense of discomfort. Instead, we need to learn to let go of the root blockages, the *samskaras*, that are causing the continuing sense of discomfort.

It is important to change your attitude and be positive about the possibility of living your life free from stored pain. You don't have to fight the *samskaras*; you simply have to relax and release to the best of your ability when they begin to surface. Eventually, you will have worked through your past blockages, and you will get to deal with the joy of having freed yourself.

18-7

I was sexually assaulted many years ago and have been through therapy, but I still struggle with trauma. I have read your books and practiced letting go, but this pain seems impossible to release. How can I finally free myself from it?

It hurts my heart just reading what you went through. I am so sorry that you had to endure that terrible experience. But you weren't seeking my sympathy; you were asking how to let the stored pain go. That is a very deep request. Many people, for reasons that are entirely understandable, don't really want to hear the deep answer. But you asked, and from a spiritual point of view, here is the answer:

1. You must really want to let it go, no matter what it takes. This means you are willing to go through the pain of letting it go. That must be your honest intent throughout the process.

2. Accept that the event happened. This has nothing to do with right or wrong—it has to do with reality. And the reality is that no matter what you do, you will never be able to make the event not have happened. As terrible as it was, it did happen. And you must be ready to accept that it was part of your life experiences while visiting the planet Earth.
3. This is the hardest part—you must try to stop feeling sorry that it happened. Feeling sorry for yourself does not help. You are a great being who had a terrible experience. It does not define you, though right now it may feel as though it does. The experience came and it went like all of life's experiences. If you really want it to stop haunting you, you must be willing to forgive and to release the samskara it left, so you can move on.
4. If you really want your mind and your heart to be cleansed of this, use affirmation. Acknowledge that what you went through was a life experience that can help you grow and make you stronger. As long as you harbor fear and pain about the experience, you will continue suppressing it and keeping it buried inside. Better to be bold—embrace the challenge of letting go. Whatever you do, don't keep it in there ruining your life.
5. When the event comes back up in your mind or heart—welcome it. Tell it that it is free to come up, and now it is free to release. To truly release it, your heart and mind must be open so that the energy can finally finish its journey through you without your resistance. This will take time, but you can do this if you're really ready to let the past event go. Each time it shows its head, give it a kiss, like you would a child that went through a bad experience. Hug it, tell it everything is okay now, and it is free to come up and continue its journey through the universe of time and space. You must be positive about this process of letting go. Love the process—be excited to let go.
6. It takes a great being to do this, but you don't have to do it alone. You can offer the disturbed energy up to God (if that is your path) or release it into the vast universe of outer space. Just don't

own it anymore—give it away. It's a bad memory that got stuck inside. It cannot harm you—that part was over long ago. Love the process of letting go.

7. When you are able to smile again, from the depth of your being, you will be done with the entire event. And those around you will be able to feel the difference. This is the greatest gift you can give to your family and friends, and to yourself, for the rest of your life. In truth, it is a gift to all of humanity. Christ turned water into wine—you turned darkness into light.

THE ASCENT





Love and Compassion

Love isn't something you find—it's something that's already inside of you, waiting to be uncovered. Your heart was born open, radiant, and flowing, but over time, you started closing it to protect yourself from hurt, rejection, or loss. Now you think you have to earn love, or guard it, or hold on to it. But the truth is, love doesn't need to be managed—it just needs to be allowed. And compassion isn't about taking on others' pain or fixing their lives. It's about being so open inside that your presence becomes a place of peace for others. In this chapter, we'll explore your questions about how to stop closing your heart, how to let love flow without needing anything in return, and how to bring true compassion into your life—by softening and surrendering, no matter what life brings.

19-1

How do I open my heart and keep it open?

If you want to open your heart, don't focus on trying to force it open—focus on why it's closed in the first place. Your heart is naturally open. It is your default state. But over time you've built walls around it, trying to protect yourself from pain, disappointment, or fear. The real work is not in opening your heart, but in letting go of the things that make you close it.

You close your heart because you are trying to protect yourself. Maybe you've been hurt; maybe you're afraid of rejection; maybe you have expectations that aren't being met. Whatever the reason, notice that the closing is something you are doing. It's not happening to you; you are actively pulling back, resisting, tightening. The key is to stop doing that. Let go of the fears and unmet preferences that make you contract. If you do that, your heart will open on its own.

As you work through this, you'll notice something profound. When you stop closing, you'll start experiencing life more fully. You'll feel other people's emotions more deeply, and sometimes you'll feel pain more intensely. That's not a problem—that's what it means to be open. When someone shares their struggles with you and your heart aches, don't resist. That's your heart awakening, coming alive. The reason you haven't felt that before is because you were too busy protecting yourself.

If you truly want to live with an open heart, make it your practice to let go of yourself. Stop filtering life through "What do I need? What do I want?" Instead, shift your attention outward. Be more interested in others than yourself. Be present for them, without needing anything in return. It's really not that hard to have an open heart—just stop closing it.

19-2

How should one handle fluctuations in the experience of love and joy?

The first thing you need to understand is that it's not your job to control the experiences of love and joy. Your heart knows exactly what it's doing. Just like your body has an immune system that takes care of itself, your heart has its own process of opening, expanding, and cleansing. When love pours through you, it's because something inside has opened. When it seems to fade or contract, it's because something deeper is being worked through. It's not a problem—it's part of the process.

There will be times when love expands so much that you don't know how to handle it. It can feel overwhelming, even scary, because it's pushing you beyond the limits of what you are comfortable feeling. Then there will be times when it feels like love is gone. But just like waves in the ocean, love isn't disappearing—it's just cycling through its natural rhythm. When it pulls back, trust that it's doing what it needs to do. Maybe it's bringing up something that needs to be released. Maybe it's preparing to open even further. Either way, it's none of your business. Your only job is to let go and allow it to do its work.

You have to stop trying to manage love. The mind wants to ask, *How do I keep it? How do I make it stay?* But the heart isn't something you hold on to—it's something you surrender into. The more you try to control it, the

further away it gets. So when love comes, let it come fully. When it seems to fade, give it the space it needs. It's still there, just working at a deeper level.

The truth is, love wants to take you further than you can imagine. For that to happen, you have to be willing to let it have you completely. That means letting go of yourself—your resistance and fears, even your ideas of what love is supposed to feel like. Just let go completely and thank love for the journey.

19-3

It is often taught that the heart center is divided into two halves, lower and higher. Does that still apply when the heart is open?

If your heart is open, the idea of it being divided into halves is not something that applies in the way you might think. The division isn't a structural one—it's about how much of your heart you're actually willing to open. There's a lower half to the heart center, where you experience love in a personal way, and then there's the higher half, where love is no longer personal—it just is. If you stay in the lower part, your love is conditional. It depends on people behaving a certain way, looking a certain way, doing what you want them to do. That's personal love, and it comes with all kinds of struggles and expectations. It's not the highest love.

If you let go of yourself enough, you don't place conditions on love anymore. Instead of holding on to personal attachments, you move into a space where love is always there, flowing freely. This isn't something you manufacture—it's something that exists beyond the personal self. The love that comes from above is always available, and when you open fully, you are no longer withholding it or filtering it through your personal wants and fears. It becomes unconditional.

As long as you continue to open, the division dissolves. You aren't stuck in a lower or higher half—you're simply open. The more you let go, the more open your heart becomes, and the more naturally love flows. If you close, even just a little, you create resistance. That's when conditions creep back in.

Ultimately, the heart isn't meant to be divided. The only question is whether you are allowing it to be fully open. And the answer to that isn't found in trying to make love fit into your personal framework; it's found in letting go of yourself completely, so that love can exist as it truly is.

19-4

If I already feel unconditional love within myself, what would a love relationship with someone else look like?

If you are already feeling unconditional love within yourself, then loving another person is simply an expression of that love. You are not looking to get love from them, nor are you relying on them to behave a certain way in order for you to feel whole. You are already whole. The love you feel is not dependent on another person; it is something you honor within yourself and then share. That is the essence of real love. It is not about fulfilling needs, expectations, or conditions. It is about allowing the love that already exists within you to flow freely, without resistance, no matter what happens.

When you bring another person into the equation, old patterns, expectations, fears, and desires will naturally arise within you. Your partner's behavior will not always align perfectly with what you might want, and this will stir up inner reactions. Your work is to recognize these reactions as blockages that prevent love from flowing unconditionally. Your challenge is to not let them close you. No one outside of you can close your heart—only you can do that. If you are truly committed to unconditional love, you must make the decision that no matter what happens, you will not close.

Not closing is what love is really about. It is not about whether the other person reciprocates in the way you think they should. Love is simply the act of keeping your heart open, regardless of circumstances. If someone brings up things in you that feel difficult, that's okay. In fact, that's the gift of relationships—they show you the places inside where you're still holding on, where you're not free. Rather than seeing a relationship as something you need to control, see it as an opportunity to go deeper into yourself by letting go of anything that would cause you to close.

If you stay open in this way, something very powerful will happen. Either the other person will be affected by the depth of your love, and they will open as well, or they won't. If they don't, they will naturally fall away. You don't have to force anything. Let life decide who stays and who goes. Your only job is to keep honoring the love that is within you, to let it flow, and to never let anything or anyone take it away from you.

19-5

I'm in a happy, committed relationship, but a past relationship keeps popping up in my heart and mind. I don't understand what is going on, and I don't like it. Can you suggest guidance to free me from this?

Thank you for your beautiful, deep question about the ways of the heart. All I can share is what a committed spiritual seeker would try to do in that situation.

1. Do not ever feel guilty about love in the heart. It is beautiful that the heart feels love—that is what it is supposed to do.
2. The key is to honor the flow of love through the heart, but gently work on redirecting it. You can channel the love toward your partner, your children, your work, God, or any other positive force that aligns with your commitments in life.
3. Someone once asked a great yoga master if there is any technique that guarantees enlightenment in this lifetime. He said yes—put your attention at the point between your eyebrows and never take it off. That is a technique for rechanneling all your personal energies towards a higher center of consciousness (the sixth chakra). You have been struggling to redirect the energy flow passing through the fourth chakra—the heart chakra. Bring it up higher; breathe it up to the point between your eyebrows. Never push it back down—always raise it up. You have decided not to express yourself in ways that would interfere with your life's commitments, and that's beautiful. You are very powerful in there, and you have the ability to redirect the energy upward. It takes time, but it is always worth it to align your energy flow with your life's aspirations.
4. That is the answer in a nutshell. Do not feel ashamed or guilty for the energy flow through the heart. Rejoice that love exists in your heart. Now gently offer the love up to God. Raise the energy to the highest place you can imagine. The way the energy is flowing now is just a habitual flow the heart got used to. It's not bad; it's just misguided for this time and place. It will not

take you where you have chosen to go. But you can, over time, rechannel that energy flow. Work with it. Turn the flow into something that supports the meaning of your life. Just keep raising it up, and you will become greater at everything you do.

19-6

Why do I feel like I close myself off because I care too much? If I practice spiritual detachment, isn't that really a lack of caring?

When you feel the need to protect yourself from caring too much, take a deeper look to see what is really happening. When something happens to someone you love, it creates discomfort inside of you. Maybe they are suffering, and that suffering bothers you. Maybe they are struggling, and that struggle makes you uncomfortable. Rather than learning to sit with that discomfort, you close. But closing isn't a result of caring—closing is a reaction to your own inability to handle what's happening inside of you.

Real caring isn't about being disturbed when someone else is struggling. That doesn't help them, and it doesn't help you. If you are suffering because someone you love is suffering, now there are two people suffering instead of one. What if you could be the one who stays open? What if you could be the one who brings love, strength, and peace into the situation? That's what true caring is. It's not about taking on someone else's pain—it's about being fully present with them, while still remaining centered in love.

Detachment is not a lack of caring. It's the highest form of caring. It means you can be there, fully open, fully available, without being pulled into the turbulence of the situation. You don't resist what's happening; you simply let it move through you, honoring it, accepting it, and bringing love into the moment. That is compassion, and that is what allows you to serve others without losing yourself in their struggles.

Don't confuse closing with caring. You don't need to close and protect yourself. You need to remain open so you can be a presence of love and support no matter what is happening. If you do that, you'll see—there's no need to shut down. You'll be able to stay open to life as it unfolds and bring your deepest presence to every moment.

19-7

How do I stop judging others and embrace compassion in daily life?

To stop judging others, the first thing you need to understand is why you judge in the first place. Judgment comes from the ego—plain and simple. The ego creates a self-concept, an idea of who you are, and then it spends its entire life reinforcing that idea. *I do this, I don't do that. I'm this kind of person, not that kind of person.* Because the ego needs to be right, it judges everything that doesn't fit into its little framework. *How could they act like that? Why don't they take care of themselves? Why don't they see things the way I do?* That's all ego. It's your mind trying to convince you that you're right and the way you live is the correct way. That's why judgment feels so automatic—it's just the ego protecting itself.

The real shift happens when you start to see what's actually going on inside you. If you can notice yourself judging, that means you—the real you—are already separate from the act. You are the one watching the judgment happen. That's growth. That's awareness. Most people don't even recognize that they're judging because they're completely identified with their thoughts. Once you can objectively see judging happening, don't try to force it to stop; just watch it. Let it be there. The more you observe it without getting caught in it, the more it will fall away naturally.

As the act of judging starts to drop, something else will take its place—compassion. When you stop filtering the world through the lens of your ego, you begin to see people for who they really are. That person who doesn't take care of themselves, who struggles in ways you don't understand—what must it be like inside them? What must it feel like to wake up in their reality, inside their mind, with their past? You think it's hard dealing with your own thoughts? Imagine living inside theirs. When you start seeing others that way, judgment disappears on its own. It's no longer, *How could they be like that?* but *My God, how must it feel to be in there?* That's where true compassion comes from.

Remember, you cannot force yourself to feel compassion. All you can do is keep letting go of yourself—the part of you that needs the world to fit into your made-up framework. Judgment is not the core problem; it's just a symptom. The real work is stepping back and releasing the grip your ego has on you. When you do that, judgment falls away naturally, and compassion

takes its place—not because you forced it to, but because it was always there, waiting for you to move out of the way.

19-8

What is the significance of forgiving myself, and how does it impact my relationships with others?

If you truly forgive yourself for the mistakes you made in the past, it changes everything. You don't just stop judging yourself—you free yourself. When that happens, something profound takes place: you naturally begin to forgive others. Once you see that you don't have to carry the weight of your own past mistakes, you realize no one else has to either. You stop judging them and holding on to past resentments. Forgiveness isn't something you do—it's something you become.

The moment you start practicing self-forgiveness, you see how easy it really is. The only thing that ever made it seem difficult was your resistance to letting go. You realize you don't need to hold on to all these old judgments about yourself. You made mistakes—of course you did. You were five years old, or you were a teenager, but you were doing the best you could with what you knew at the time. Why would you keep punishing yourself for that? When you let it go, the relief is immediate.

So, the effect that forgiving yourself has on your relationships is simple: it heals them. The more you let go of yourself, the more space you create for others. You stop trying to control everything; you just experience people as they are. That's real forgiveness. That's real freedom. When you do this, you'll find something incredible—you'll look around, and suddenly, everyone in the world feels like your friend.

19-9

How can I have compassion for those who commit terrible acts?

To have compassion for those who commit terrible acts, you have to start with reality. The reality is that these things happen. People harm each other; there are wars; there is suffering; and there are actions you may find unthinkable. Closing your eyes to reality or resisting it internally doesn't change anything; it only disturbs you further. If you are hating what is, you are just fighting

reality, and reality always wins. Accepting reality does not mean condoning these acts, but it does mean starting from a place of clarity instead of resistance.

Once you have accepted that these things happen, you can begin to ask a deeper question: Why do people do these things? You may not understand it because you haven't lived their lives. You didn't grow up in their circumstances; you didn't go through the same suffering, conditioning, or trauma that shaped them. That doesn't mean you justify their actions, but it does mean you recognize that every person is the result of countless influences you will never fully comprehend. If you had lived exactly their life, who's to say you wouldn't have ended up doing the same things? As the proverb says: "There, but for the grace of God, go I."

This understanding brings forth compassion. Compassion is not about excusing behavior—it's about not letting your heart close. If you let yourself be consumed with judgment, hate, and anger toward those who do terrible things, you have brought that darkness into yourself. What good does that do? What good does your internal suffering do for the world? If anything, you are just adding to the very energy that caused these things in the first place. Instead, step back, take a breath, and create space for a deeper truth—one that both recognizes the pain caused by the terrible act and understands that every being is shaped by their journey.

Dare to be the person who does not shut down, who does not add more division, but instead holds space for understanding. You are here to rise above the darkness that created the suffering, not to fall into it yourself. The more you let go of your resistance, the higher you will rise. From that higher place, real change can take place.



Freeing Your Inner Energy

There is a powerful energy already flowing inside you. It's the same energy that makes you feel inspired, uplifted, alive—and it's also the same energy that gets blocked when you resist life. Every fear, every stored emotion, every moment you closed your heart created a dam in the natural flow of your inner energy. You don't have to go searching for energy—you just have to stop holding it down. Freeing your inner energy isn't about doing more; it's about letting go of the very part of you that's always trying to control life. In this chapter, we'll explore your questions about how to allow that energy to rise, how to let the inner blockages pass through without resistance, and how to return to the natural state of joy and inspiration that lives at the core of your being.

20-1

What does it mean to transmute energy, and how can I achieve this?

If you want to understand how to transmute energy, you have to start by seeing how energy moves inside of you. When something happens that stirs up an inner reaction, you feel a pull—an intense, almost magnetic force that tries to drag your awareness down into the disturbance. The first step is to recognize that pull. Just notice it. You don't have to fight it or push it away. And you don't have to let it take you under. Simply witness it. That alone is a profound shift, because now you are separate from it. You are not the energy itself—you are the one experiencing it.

Now, instead of collapsing into the experience, you do something radical: you stay centered and allow the energy to rise. This is transmutation. You are not suppressing anything, nor are you indulging in it. You are creating the space for the energy to pass through you, without clinging to it or resisting it. Instead of going down into the old habitual patterns of reaction, you

let the energy come up to you. You welcome it, like a wave rolling through, and you watch it release into a higher state.

If you want to see this clearly, think of a rope being pulled taut. At one end of the rope is your *samskara*—your stored past impressions—trying to pull you down into it. The other end is you, holding on to the rope, struggling not to get pulled in. Letting go isn't about being strong enough to win the battle; it's simply about opening your hands. The moment you release the rope, the tension disappears, and you are free to continue your journey upward. That's how transmutation happens—not through effort, but through surrender.

20-2

Does yoga transcend physiology as well as psychology? For example, can stored emotions in the body be released through yoga?

When energy gets blocked, it doesn't just stay in your mind or heart—it manifests in your body. That's why you might feel tension in your shoulders, tightness in your chest, or knots in your stomach. It's why emotions seem to settle into different parts of your body, like trauma in your hips or stress in your neck. This is real, and it's why practices like acupuncture, massage, and various body-based therapies can bring relief. They help move the energy, clear the pathways, and allow blockages to release.

But here's what you need to understand: If you only work on the body, you're not getting to the root of the problem. The reason the energy is stuck in the first place is because the mind and heart are holding on to things. The more you hold on to the fears generated by deep-seated patterns from the past, the more the energy has no choice but to lodge itself somewhere. That's why, even after a massage or a therapy session, the tension often comes right back. You've only treated the symptom, not the cause.

The real work happens inside. The more you let go of resistance within your mind and heart, the more these blockages naturally dissolve. That's why practices like yoga, meditation, and deep inner surrender are so powerful. When you stop inwardly resisting life, the body doesn't need to store those blocked patterns anymore. The energy that was stuck can begin to flow again.

So yes, work with yoga or body-based therapies if they help you release, but don't rely on them alone. The deeper healing comes when you learn to let

life pass through you without resistance. That's where true freedom is—when nothing inside of you is stuck anymore.

20-3

Why is my body holding tension despite mentally surrendering, and how do I let that go?

The physical body gets the energy—the shakti—after it passes through the mental and emotional bodies. Even the slightest disturbance in the energy flow coming into the physical body can cause imbalance. That is why people get ulcers from worrying, and so on. Here are some suggestions that may help as you continue to cleanse your mental and emotional systems:

1. First, it is important to understand that while you are letting go of mental and emotional disturbance, some of the disturbed energy can still make it into the physical body. Be sure to relax the physical body while you are working with the energy. Relax your shoulders, relax your chest around your heart area, relax your tummy, and relax your buttocks. Breathe while you are relaxing. On the exhale, blow out any tension that has been released.
2. Treat the body as though it were a little child getting scared by the disturbed energy coming into it. When you get a chance, give it a hug and speak nicely to it. Your physical body is an animal, and animals get very scared at the slightest thing. They can either tighten up and attack to protect themselves, or run away. Your body has inherited these tendencies of fight or flight. However, you are more evolved than your body, so reach down periodically and encourage it to relax. Tell it things are fine, and it doesn't have to protect itself from the disturbed energy that leaked through. Just relax, relax, relax, and let go of any reactive tightening.
3. Keep working with yourself in this way, and over time your body will stop reacting to uncomfortable energy. It can learn to be okay with disturbances.

20-4

Why do samskaras keep returning even after I try to release them?

When deep samskaras come up again and again, it's not because you're doing something wrong; it's because you're only releasing some of their energy, not the root samskara itself. Every time a past experience or trauma resurfaces, what's actually happening is a piece of its stored energy is coming up into your awareness. When you consciously relax and release that energy instead of resisting it, you're doing exactly what you need to be doing. But that doesn't mean the whole samskara is gone—it just means another layer has been lifted.

The mistake would be to think that because the thought or emotion came back, you're not truly letting go. That's not the case. You're doing the work. You're simply meeting these blocks at the level they're ready to be released at the time. Releasing samskaras is not an overnight process—it's a process of patience, openness, and trust. The best thing you can do is to stop resisting what's coming up. When something arises, instead of thinking, *Oh no, not this again*, try saying, "Great—another chance to let go." The more you welcome it, the easier the process becomes.

It's also important to recognize that your mind will want to judge the process. It will want to say, "Why is this taking so long?" or "Am I doing something wrong?" None of that helps. The only thing that helps is learning to embrace each moment of release as it comes. Let whatever is surfacing be there. Don't push it back down. Just relax and allow the energy to pass through you. That's all you can do, and that's all you need to do.

At the deepest level, this is about opening. The more you let go, the more you open. As you open, more will rise up to be released. That's a gift. That's life working to free you. The process is already happening—your only job is to stop interfering with it. Always welcome it, embrace it, and let it take you into a world of more and more love and freedom.

20-5

I've been letting go of my blockages on a daily basis, and it's working. But I feel more neutral than joyful. When will I begin experiencing constant joy?

It is very good that you are not being bothered as much by your daily life. That is a very good start to your spiritual growth. It is what we call "non-negative,"

but it is not yet positive. You are using your will to avoid the negative energies when they come up, and that is certainly better than getting caught in them. But the shakti that has been blocked down there for years is still not totally free to flow upward. We have all developed personalities that keep our blockages at bay. We are in there holding it all together on a moment-to-moment basis. If we don't change this at the root, the best we can get is neutrality.

Witness consciousness is the state in which you are noticing that you are holding it all together. Notice your mind's thoughts; notice how your heart processes emotions. If you do this, you will see an underlying protectiveness going on at a very deep level. That is what you surrender and relax through—not just the moments when life hits your blockages. See if you can witness this deeper part of your being. And when you can see what is going on underneath, just relax and let go.

Remember, spirituality is not about letting go of life—it is about letting go of the parts of you that are protecting you from life. Once you see this, you're doing great. Now, start working at an even deeper level. It will not be easy, but it is very much worth it.

The key is to remember that letting go is not a one-time event. It's a practice. You may feel the pull again and again, but every time you make the choice to relax and let the energy pass through, you are working to rewire your entire way of being. Over time, the same energy that used to disturb you will become the very energy that lifts you. Once that upward flow begins, the joy for life becomes a reality. That is the beauty of this path—you are not trying to control the shakti; you are learning to set her free.

20-6

How can one feel passion in everyday tasks?

When you talk about passion, you're describing something very real. It exists in those moments when you become completely absorbed in what you're doing, when there's no separation between you and the task in front of you. It's a merger, a oneness between consciousness and the object of consciousness. That's a beautiful thing. True passion happens naturally when you are fully present, when you are so open that you become one with the moment itself.

Here's the problem: most people can only experience that state when things are exactly the way the ego wants them to be. When you're painting, playing music, or doing something you're passionate about, you disappear into it. But the moment something happens you don't like, you're no longer in that flow. The ego blocks it.

The real question isn't how to find things you are passionate about—it's why you're not passionate about everything. Taking out the garbage, washing dishes, or driving your kids to soccer is just as beautiful a task as anything else. The truth is, all of life is beautiful. It's just that the mind has made distinctions, labeling some things as meaningful and others as mundane. If you learn to stay open, you'll see that every single moment has the potential to be full of inspiration.

So don't try to manufacture passion for certain things. Just be willing to let go of the blockages you have stored inside that interfere with your natural energy flow. Passion, love, inspiration—these aren't things to be sought after. They are the natural state of a being who has stopped closing. Let go of the barriers, and you'll see that life itself is ecstasy.

20-7

How do I respect each moment as unique and special?

The moment that is unfolding in front of you is yours. No one else has ever experienced it before, and no one ever will again. That makes it unique, doesn't it? But the mind doesn't see it that way. The mind compares, judges, and decides which moments are special and which are ordinary. That's the problem. There is no such thing as an ordinary moment. Life is extraordinary, but you miss it because you're too busy deciding how you want it to be.

How do you learn to respect each moment as unique and special? You stop making it about you—about what you want and what you don't want. The moment is already whole, already perfect in its own way. Your job isn't to manipulate it; it's to serve it. And you serve the moment by being fully present for it, without resistance, without preferences.

When you do this, you'll notice something amazing. Instead of chasing after special moments, you'll realize that every moment is special. Whether you're sitting in traffic or standing on top of a mountain, there's no difference. The moment itself is enough. You don't need to add anything to it.

If you learn to live like this, you'll find that life takes care of itself. You won't have to struggle to make things meaningful because everything will already feel full. The key is to stop making it about you and start showing up for life exactly as it is. Serve what is in front of you. That's how you honor each moment.

20-8

How can you practice letting go without feeling indifferent? How do I reconcile putting all my energy into life with the concept of spiritual detachment?

Be assured that letting go of your personal self does not lead to a state of indifference to life. It is really quite the opposite. While we are lost in thoughts and feelings of our own personal past, we are not connected to the present moment, and we are missing the true experience of life. You will find that when you let go of your personal self, you will actually feel more connected to life.

When you let go and are truly open to an experience, you let it all the way in. It actually moves you to the depth of your being. It becomes one with you, and you become one with it. This merger of the experiencer and the experience is a very spiritual state, and it transcends the noisy mind. You don't have to recall that experience for it to affect you from then on. It has become part of your being, not just part of your mental collection of thoughts. It is beyond the psyche, not limited to it. These deep experiences make you more whole. When a river is free to flow unimpeded into the ocean, the waters merge and are no longer separate—they become one ocean, which is more complete than it was before.

When you go deep enough inside, beyond your personal mental and emotional panorama, you will find the source of love, compassion, and beauty. Your emotions are simply the ripples created by these energies manifesting in the lake of your psyche. When you let go of what you are watching, you will realize that you are the source of everything below you. You are not your thoughts; you are aware of your thoughts. You are not your emotions; you are aware of your emotions. The seat of Self is not a cold, indifferent place. The nature of Self is love, ecstasy, and divinity. When you stop clinging to the personal psyche, you'll find you are much more than merely the human

you're watching—you are pure consciousness, experiencing the expression of itself in the form of reality.

20-9

What happens after one realizes and learns to stay in the seat of Self? How should one deal with distractions and samskaras?

Once you are established in the seat of Self, you don't need to do anything—you're already complete. What happens naturally, however, is that you are so filled with love and inspiration that these beautiful energies want to express themselves. It's like when you fall in love with someone—you don't have to wonder what to do next; you just naturally spend time together expressing that love. The same is true with the inner flow of divine love. It flows out into the world expressing itself with everything you do, every moment of your life.

Right now, your actions are driven by fears and desires, by trying to make things be the way you want. You assume that if you remove all these psychological needs, there will be no motivation left. That's not true. What's left is something much greater. When you are fully centered in the Self, you don't stop interacting—you just stop interacting out of personal needs. You do what you do because it naturally flows from within you. You serve, you create, you engage with life, but not because you're trying to get something. You do it because you are constantly inspired to express the beauty within.

You don't have to seek this inner energy flow. Just stay centered and learn to allow life to flow through you. The inner shakti flow is already there—you just have to stop blocking it. When samskaras come up, don't resist them; just relax and let them pass. The more you do this, the more you will feel the shakti flow. Eventually, you will see that you don't have to decide to do anything. Life will become the beautiful dance of expression between the inner and outer energy flows.

Consciousness and Awareness

You are not your thoughts. You are not your emotions. You are the one who is aware of them. That awareness—the silent witness behind it all—is your true Self. But most of us have become so lost in what we’re looking at that we’ve forgotten who’s looking. That’s the great fall: consciousness, the pure light of awareness, gets so caught up in the objects it’s observing—thoughts, sensations, experiences—that it begins to believe it is them. In this chapter, we’ll explore your questions about what it really means to step back into the seat of awareness, unhook from the mind’s pull, and begin the journey home—to the still, vast presence you’ve always been.

21-1

If the voice of my mind is telling me to relax and release, isn’t that just another layer of thoughts I’m aware of?

Thank you for your very deep question. Think of it as a stairway to heaven—not a single leap. Consciousness identifies with what it is conscious of. In its most lost state, it actually uses the term “I” to express the thoughts it is caught up in. *I like this, I don’t like that. I hope I get what I want; I pray I don’t have to experience what I don’t want.* On and on it goes—never stopping, always thinking about how to control the world to match its preferences.

A giant step back is witness consciousness. You are aware that all of this is going on in your mind, but you are no longer totally lost in it or committed to it. In essence, you are conscious of being conscious of what you are conscious of. This is not enlightenment, but it is consciousness unbound from its addiction to the mind’s thoughts.

As an analogy, let’s say you are completely lost in watching a TV show. You are not aware of anything else in the room except what is on the TV. That

is equivalent to how we typically interact with our minds. We are completely absorbed and identified with the mental show. Now imagine a commercial comes on the TV that you have no interest in. Suddenly you are back on the couch, aware of your body and the rest of the room. You have extricated yourself from your addiction to the show, but you are still on the couch, aware that the TV is on. That is the equivalent of witness consciousness. You are no longer totally absorbed in the mind's thoughts, but you are still looking at the mind from a detached state.

When you are completely done with the TV, you can get off the couch and experience the rest of your life. When you are done with the mind, you—the consciousness—are no longer distracted by the mind's thoughts, and you are free to stop looking in that direction. Just as when you get off the couch there is a whole world for you to experience, so when you stop looking in the direction of your mind's thoughts, you realize you are not finite—you are universal.

You must pass through the state of witness consciousness in order to become detached from your addiction to your thoughts. Once you can see a thought as just a thought, you are ready to let it go. Once you can see all thoughts as just thoughts, you will no longer be distracted by them. Consciousness, not distracted by objects of consciousness, has returned to its Source—this is enlightenment.

21-2

How can I separate my mind from consciousness?

You don't have to separate the mind from consciousness—they are already separate. The only reason it feels like they're not is that you're so used to focusing on your mind that you've lost sight of yourself as pure consciousness. Think of a light shining on an object. The light has nothing to do with the object—it's just illuminating it. Your consciousness is the light, and your mind is the object. But because you've been staring at the mind for so long, you think they're the same.

The key isn't figuring out how to separate them; that's just the mind thinking about itself. Instead, start by noticing that you are the one who is aware of the mind. Your thoughts come and go, but something in you remains constant—the awareness itself. If you were truly your thoughts, you

wouldn't be able to observe them. But you can. You can watch your mind talk, analyze, worry, and dream. If you can watch something, then you are not that thing—you are the one who is watching.

The real question isn't how to separate yourself from the mind, but why you are so attracted to it in the first place. Why does every little thought, every little emotional disturbance, pull your awareness into it? That's what you need to let go of. When the mind says, *I feel lost* or *I need to figure this out*, don't grab on to that thought. Just relax. Let it go. The more you release, the clearer it becomes. You are not the thoughts, nor the emotions, nor the personal story playing in your head. You are the one who is aware of all of that.

If you keep letting go of what you are not, you will naturally settle into what you are. That's the only way to truly know the Self. Don't fight with the mind, don't try to control it—just stop getting caught in it. Keep relaxing and letting go, and what you've been looking for will reveal itself. You're already there—you just need to stop getting distracted.

21-3

What does it mean for consciousness to be distracted, and how can it return to its source?

When you say that consciousness is distracted, you have to understand what that really means. Consciousness itself is always present, always aware, always whole. But it gets drawn down into thoughts, emotions, and external events. Consciousness is pure and untouched at its source. But as it projects outward, it appears to take on the characteristics of what it focuses on. If your awareness is completely fixated on a thought, a problem, or an emotion, it feels like you are those things. You are not. You are the one who is aware of them.

In truth, you don't have to go anywhere to return to your seat of consciousness—you never really left. You've just been looking outward instead of resting in your true nature. Returning to your source actually means learning to not be pulled out of your source. It means recognizing that when something arises in the mind, you don't have to follow it. You don't have to leave your seat of consciousness to chase the thought. If you want to be free, you have to stop getting lost in the objects passing through.

The key is to let go. Let thoughts arise and let them pass. Let emotions come and let them go. Instead of being dragged down into them, simply

observe them. That's how you return home. That's how you stay centered in the seat of consciousness. You don't find your way back by struggling with the mind—you let go of the struggle entirely. You will then come to see that you were always there, but you were looking out instead of in.

21-4

Does shakti grow stronger as samskaras are released? What does it feel like to have no blockages?

In the deep yogic teachings, one of the most beautiful names for God is *Chit Shakti*: Conscious Energy. When Einstein discovered that $E=MC^2$, he scientifically unveiled a great mystery of the universe: there is no matter, just frozen energy. Just like steam, water, and ice are all just temporary states of the same substance, so the whole universe is just manifestations of the same underlying energy: shakti.

Your body, thoughts, and emotions are all shakti energy vibrating at different rates. The higher the vibration rate, the more beautiful the experience of the energy flow. Low, dark thoughts and emotions are heavy, while more elevated thoughts and emotions are light and uplifting. If you willfully resist an energy flow because you can't handle it, it becomes a stored blockage, a samskara. The higher energy flows can't make it past the lower blockages, just like water can't flow freely through ice, even though they are the same substance. But when you work to release these blockages, it frees the shakti to vibrate at higher and higher levels, which is eventually experienced as bliss and ecstasy.

Note that this is just the shakti flow within the body, mind, and emotions. Since shakti energy is omnipresent, you are capable of experiencing your oneness with all. You just have to learn how to free your consciousness from its addiction to focusing on your tiny body, mind, and heart. That is what the teachings are gradually teaching you: how to let go of your false image of self. The more you let go, the more you will experience the shakti in her purer form. Eventually you will cease to experience yourself as separate from her—that is the state of the Great Merger. Christ said it this way: "I and my Father are one."

21-5

Some teachers speak of super-consciousness. Is that really just another word for God?

Consciousness identifies with what it is conscious of, especially when the object of consciousness is very distracting, like pain, the feeling of love, or a powerful experience that leaves a strong impression. We call that “the fall from the garden”—consciousness has totally lost itself in what it is aware of. Such is the human state.

When consciousness releases the tendency to identify with what it’s conscious of and remains in the seat of objective observation, we call that witness consciousness. In this state, consciousness is aware that it is experiencing the objects of consciousness, but it has not fallen down into or identified with those objects. It is simply aware, nothing more.

When consciousness is no longer distracted by what it is aware of, it naturally returns to the source of consciousness. This can be called the Great Merger, the return to oneness, the nondual state. When that merger into oneness is complete, that is the super-conscious state. All things are in you, and you are in all things. You have merged into the primal, unmanifest state before all was created. Your drop of consciousness has fallen into the ocean of consciousness—that drop exists no more—it has become the ocean.

21-6

What does it mean to live with awareness of your higher self while continuing to engage with your personality and everyday life? How does this affect the evolution of the soul?

That’s a great question. First, understand that the terms “consciousness” and “soul” are just words pointing to something much deeper. If you try to grasp them with the mind, you’re going to get tangled up in concepts, instead of experiencing what they really mean. The truth is, you don’t have to define them—you have to experience them. But let’s at least use words to point in the right direction.

Consciousness is awareness itself. It's that which notices everything—your thoughts, your emotions, the world around you. If I ask you to watch your thoughts right now, who is watching? That's consciousness. It's not personal; it's not bound by your name, your history, or even your body. It is simply the presence of awareness, the part of you that has always been there, completely untouched by what it observes. Consciousness is not something you develop—it's what you are.

The soul, on the other hand, is more of a personal expression of consciousness. You could think of it as an individual drop of the ocean of consciousness that moves through life, learning, growing, and evolving. It carries impressions, and even tendencies, from lifetime to lifetime. Your personality is that drop of consciousness identifying with what it is aware of—your body, thoughts, and emotions. Meanwhile, the ocean of pure consciousness remains untouched, transcendent, identifying itself as the ocean, not the drop.

The key is to not get caught up in definitions, but to shift your attention toward what is real. If you sit quietly and notice that you are aware of experiencing this moment, without getting lost in thoughts about it, you are touching pure consciousness. If you open your heart, if you align yourself with the highest within you, that's the unfolding of the soul's journey. The beauty is that as you go deeper, you'll see that the two are not separate at all. The soul longs to merge back into the ocean of pure consciousness, to let go of its individual limitations and return to its true nature.

Don't worry about defining it too much. Just watch. Just be. The more you let go, the more you'll come to know—not with your mind, but with direct experience—what consciousness, soul, and personality really are.

21-7

You say that Earth is a place souls are sent to evolve. I thought the soul was perfect, complete—how does it evolve?

The Self, or soul, is the perfection of God's consciousness staring at your mind, your body, your emotions, and what comes in through your senses. Just as you can get lost in watching a TV show and completely forget you are a human sitting on the couch, so a ray of God's consciousness gets so distracted by what it is staring at that it forgets who it really is. This is how God takes on the self-concept of a human being.

The evolution of the soul is not about perfecting God's consciousness—it is already perfect. It is about freeing that ray of consciousness from its addiction to staring at what it is not. Spiritual enlightenment is like finally freeing yourself from being completely absorbed in the TV show and standing up to remember who you really are. That is why Yogananda called spiritual awakening self-realization.

21-8

Do you believe our consciousness transcends death? If so, do we retain our personality?

Science says, "Energy is neither created nor destroyed." Likewise, the great masters say, "Consciousness is neither created nor destroyed." Consciousness is and always was aware—it's just a question of what it's aware of. Thus, at the death of the body, consciousness does not change; it just becomes aware of things other than what the body's five senses pick up.

As far as your personality is concerned—your habitual thought and emotional patterns—it is not made of physical substance and does not fall apart at the body's death. So, unfortunately, you take your mess with you! That is why it is so important to clean out your stored disturbances while you're alive.

Ultimately, when a truly great being dies, they are free to fall all the way back into the source of consciousness because there are no past mental or emotional patterns binding them. That is what is meant by merging with God. We call this the ultimate liberation. At this point, you have truly died of the personal and are reborn in the spiritual. Life's entire journey is the evolution of individual consciousness back to the state of Oneness.



The Meaning of Life and Death

You're going to die—sooner than you think. And when that moment comes, none of the things you clung to—your money, your possessions, even your relationships—will go with you. So the real question is: What will go with you? What in life matters so much that it transcends the temporal? That's where the purpose of life reveals itself. You are here to let go of what holds you down, to open your heart, and to evolve back into the infinite consciousness from which you came. Life isn't about arranging the outside so you feel okay inside—it's about using every moment to free yourself inside so you can merge with the divine flow of life. In this chapter, we'll explore your questions about how contemplating death can bring clarity to life and how the evolution of your soul is the real reason you are here.

22-1

What is the ultimate purpose of life?

If you want to know the ultimate purpose of life, first look around. Everything you chase, everything you hold on to, everything you think matters so much—it all passes with time. It's transient. You can build relationships, make money, raise a family, and there's nothing wrong with any of that. But don't mistake it for the meaning of your life. You are here for something much deeper.

You're going to die soon—sooner than you realize. When that moment comes, none of what you've collected will go with you. The pharaohs tried to take it all with them, and they didn't succeed very well, did they? But if everything external is temporal, then what is permanent? What is the real purpose of all this?

The purpose of your life is the evolution of your soul—your return to the divine. You are here to use every experience to lift yourself higher, to let go

of what holds you back, and to merge into the greater flow of life. If you put your energy on your inner work, instead of clinging to life as it slips through your fingers, you will be investing in what is permanent, rather than what's temporary.

So don't get lost in the small stuff. Don't think life is about arranging things the way you want. It's about learning to let go, about realizing that each moment is an opportunity to free yourself. When you finally surrender, when you stop fighting and start flowing with life, you will see—you were never separate; you were never small. You were always part of something infinite. That realization is the purpose of your life.

22-2

You teach that I am just a tiny speck in the universe. I understand, but it's overwhelming. How can I regain passion for life?

When we take a universal perspective, it helps us avoid getting lost in the meaningless minutiae of our personal fears, desires, and reactions. Once you have that perspective, you can simply enjoy the natural unfolding of your life on this tiny planet. When your personal noise becomes meaningless, the miracle of life itself becomes meaningful. It becomes awe-inspiring that in the middle of vast, empty space, you are on a beautiful planet, experiencing a body, breathing air, feeling emotions, and thinking thoughts. You are conscious and honored to receive each breath and to engage with every experience that unfolds before you. This integrated experience of your life will create the connection you are seeking.

We all go through stages in our inner growth. If right now you are feeling disconnected and overwhelmed, experiment with just quietly receiving and appreciating the simple experiences in your environment. Notice the sensation of the earth beneath your feet, the air moving in and out of your lungs, the sensations you feel when you touch objects. Take a walk, wash some dishes, receive your life in a simple way, and let go of any fears of complexity. It is the mind that creates complexity and alienation.

Gently work on letting go of any anxieties that come up about being out of place. The very fact that you are alive and conscious means that you have a

very important place in life. Do you realize that nobody has ever experienced the exact moments you've experienced? If something exists and nothing is conscious of it, it has no meaning. But you are the consciousness that gave those moments meaning. Your place is to receive, experience, and love all the amazing parts of creation that pass before you. Consciousness is the most important thing in all of creation—and you are that consciousness.

22-3

I feel unfulfilled in my profession. I want to find something that I am truly passionate about. How do I discover my real purpose?

Thank you for sharing the problem you're having finding passion and purpose in your life. Passion and purpose are not something you find outside—they are something you have inside. When you start your car in the morning, you should be passionately excited that it started and that you get to drive to work. When you get to work, you can be passionately excited that you have a job, get to be of service, and actually get paid for doing it!

In essence, you are asking the wrong question about finding passion. The real question is what is blocking your natural passion for being alive and spinning on this tiny planet in the middle of vast, empty space. The great Persian poet, Rumi, once said, "Yesterday I was clever, so I tried to change the world. Today I am wise, so I am changing myself."

Change how you're looking at things, and your whole life will change. Work on being passionate about your current job, and if a new opportunity presents itself, wonderful—be passionate about that. You don't have to look for a certain job or relationship in order to be passionate. You should be able to clear out the blockages that keep you from being excited about everything on this amazing planet. Or would you rather be on Mars, where nothing is ever happening?

If you want purpose, let this be your life's purpose: Let go of the inner blockages that are stealing your shakti and keeping you from God. Be passionate about that purpose, and all of life will become a fantastic, passionate experience.

22-4**Are my life events part of a divine plan, or are they basically random?**

The purpose of your life is your soul's evolution. But this does not unfold as we think it does. God is much more brilliant than we can comprehend. If two or more people are experiencing the same outer event, and each of them has separate evolutionary needs, how can the same nonrandom event be equally beneficial for the growth of each person?

To answer that perplexing question, you have to first understand that the event itself is not personal. It is simply the natural unfolding of the universe manifesting at that point of time and space—just like the quadrillions of other events happening at the same time. All of them are intricately tied together in a great perfection throughout time and space.

The reason the same event can be beneficial spiritually for each observer is because each observer is looking at the same event through “the eyes of the beholder.” They will experience the same event differently because of their own personal blockages from their past. In other words, the experience will stimulate different stored patterns in each observer, with their indwelling consciousness experiencing the event only after it has been tainted by these *samskaras*.

Thus, every event will be exactly what each individual needs to experience in order to stimulate the challenge of their inner growth. In essence, the universe is created with such perfection that it works perfectly for each individual. The event doesn't have to be personal; you just have to take it as personal. That has exactly the effect needed in order to force you to deal with your blocked energies. When you are done with your personal blockages—that is, enlightened—you will see life as it really is: the manifestation of God.

22-5**Is the goal to always handle situations and then serve from that place?**

If you can't handle a situation, you will be trying to manipulate it so you can handle it. When you do that, you're serving yourself. You're making life be about you—about what you need in order to feel okay. But if you can handle what's happening, if you are fully okay inside no matter what unfolds, then something very different takes place. You no longer need to manage life for

your own comfort, so you can turn your attention outward: *How can I help?* That's the shift, and that's where real service begins.

Look at life: If a person has fallen down, you help them up. Not because you're trying to be a good person, but simply because that's what is needed in that moment. If a butterfly is trapped in your car, you help it out. There's nothing personal about it—it's just the natural flow of serving what's in front of you. That's what a life of service looks like. It's not about what you want or don't want—it's about what life is presenting you and how you can help.

The highest life you can live is one in which every moment that unfolds before you is better off because it interacted with you. That's it. No big philosophy, no complicated concepts—just this simple truth: whatever moment comes to you, leave it better off than you found it. You don't do this because you need something in return; you do it because you don't need anything from the moment. When you are whole inside and don't need life to fix or fulfill you, then all that's left is to serve.

So yes, the goal is to serve. But don't start with "How can I serve?" Start with "Can I handle this moment exactly as it is?" If the answer is no, then work on that. Work on letting go of the part of you that resists, that needs things to be a certain way. When you reach the place where nothing needs to be different, service happens naturally. It's not something you do—it's simply what flows from a being who is free.

22-6

You teach that each moment in life is experienced uniquely by each individual. What is the purpose of looking at life from this perspective?

When you look at your life, you'll see that every moment was experienced uniquely by you. No one else has ever had the exact sequence of moments you've had, and no one else ever will. In essence, you are God's emissary sent to experience these moments of creation. If you're not paying attention and miss the moment passing before you, no one will ever have experienced it. And even if you do experience it, you tend to resist it and judge it instead of appreciating it. You say, "I don't want this moment; I want that one." That's the problem; you think you know which moments are supposed to happen. But the truth is, the moments unfolding are exactly what's supposed to be happening—not in a moral sense, but based on the law of cause and effect. If

you stop resisting them and start honoring them, life will become an incredible teacher for you.

Every moment you experience is a gift. It was made just for you. Think about that. Out of all the infinite possibilities, you are the only one who has ever had this exact moment in this exact way. The question is, will you respect it? Will you honor it? Will you see that life is shaping you, sculpting you like a great artist chiseling away at marble? Life isn't here to build up your personal self—it's here to break down the barriers that separate you from the truth. If you allow it to do its work—if you let go of your preferences and open yourself to what's actually happening—you'll begin to see the divine intelligence behind it all.

You struggle because you think life should be a certain way, that it should conform to your desires. The real path is to surrender to what is—to recognize that every moment serves your spiritual evolution. It's all unfolding exactly as it should, and your job is not to fight it, but to embrace it. When you do that, gratitude naturally arises. You stop seeing life as a series of obstacles and start seeing it as a gift, as a direct expression of the divine calling you home. This is the power of surrender.

22-7

I am elderly and wish to continue finding purpose in my life. How do I move forward and be motivated to live fully and serve?

We are so pleased that you are ready to move forward. Here is a beautiful daily prescription for life that will allow you to live fully and serve:

1. When you wake up in the morning, remind yourself that the purpose of this day is to let go of whatever comes up that causes resistance in you. Commit to relaxing through events, thoughts, and emotions that are creating resistance. The overall purpose of your life, and death, is to go back up with less than you came down with. Now can you see you have a very important job to do with this day? Take that job seriously—it is the reason you took birth.
2. Honor the moment unfolding before you, and see if there is anything you can do to uplift it as it passes by. Remember, no one

has ever seen that moment before, and no one ever will. It's your moment. Treat it with respect, honor, and love. Give something to it as it passes by, even if that something is just a smile or the wink of an eye. Acknowledge how special you and the moment are to have shared this experience together. That includes not only people you come in contact with, but also the weather, the trees, the sun, and all of nature as it passes by. Just imagine if there was nothing in front of you, and learn to appreciate all the somethings that are there.

3. When the day is done and it is time for sleep, sit up in bed and quietly look within. See if anything from the day has not yet passed through you. Realize it was just an event on a tiny planet spinning through vast, empty space. Let it go. Release it into the vastness of the billions of stars in your galaxy, of which your Sun is only one. The bothersome event only matters because you resisted it. Let it go; free yourself. There is great love, inspiration, and purpose inside of you. Let go of all these human frailties and soar up into your greatness. Do not hold this day's pain inside you—or all that pain will be there in the future. Just honor its existence, give it a kiss on the head, and let it pass through you without resistance. This is not always easy, but it is what gives your life the purpose you seek. You have inner work to do—embrace it with great enthusiasm.
4. Repeat this process daily.

22-8

Many people are very anxious about the topic of death. What happens to consciousness after death?

The important question is not what happens to consciousness after death, but why do you even want to know? What is it in you that feels the need to conceptualize something you haven't experienced yet? If you were entering a new relationship, would you really like to know what every interaction was going to be like? No, you'd want the joy of experiencing the moments for yourself, openly and fully. Death is the same way. You are going to find out

what happens—you can be sure of that. You don't need to clutter your mind with ideas that can't possibly capture what you haven't experienced. All you really need to know is that death is a once-in-a-lifetime experience, and when the time comes, you'll see for yourself.

If you want to contemplate death, however, you first have to understand the nature of consciousness. Unlike your body, consciousness is not made of atoms. Right now, your consciousness is staring at the world through the lens of your body. But when the body is no longer there, consciousness won't be staring at the physical world anymore. That doesn't mean consciousness will cease to exist. Have you ever noticed how, even in dreams, you are still conscious? Your body is lying in bed, but your awareness is engaged in experiencing the dream. Likewise, when you get lost in thought, you don't take your body with you. The mind, the personality, they're not bound by physicality in the way we often assume. That at least gives you a clue as to what aspect of your being could remain after the death of the body.

What does that mean for you today? It means that if you're carrying a heavy, negative mind when you leave this world, you might find yourself still entangled in it. If your mind is filled with unresolved fears, regrets, or attachments, and there's nothing left to distract you from them, that could feel like hell. But if your mind is open, clear, and at peace—if you've done the inner work to let go of your past struggles—then what's left? Just the beautiful, expansive openness of your true being. That's why the great spiritual teachings emphasize letting go. And that's why the masters have always encouraged raising your consciousness while you're still here. Not because of some rigid doctrine or belief system, but because they understand that the state in which you live is the state in which you leave.

Don't let the thought of death be something that weighs on you. Don't let it be a source of fear. Instead, live in a way that when the time comes, you're ready to go. Free yourself from the mental noise now. Then, when you get to that once-in-a-lifetime experience, you can step into it with grace, with peace, and with the openness to experience what's next—whatever that may be. Trust me, you will find out.

22-9

How do you deal with grief when someone close to you passes away?

When someone close to you passes away, grief is a natural experience. You formed a deep energetic connection with that person, and now it feels like that connection is gone. The energy inside of you, which used to flow freely through the heart, suddenly has nowhere to go. The heart closes down, attempting to protect itself, and the energy flow starts hitting those blockages, causing great pain and discomfort. Meanwhile, your entire self-concept becomes shattered because you can no longer define yourself based on your relation to that person. This causes a feeling of deep loss and confusion because, in a very real sense, you have lost the ability to relate to the world as you once did. That's what grief is—the energy inside you reorganizing itself because it can no longer flow the way it used to.

What is the best way to deal with such a deep sense of loss? First, you have to accept it. Grief is not something to resist, deny, or judge. It's not a psychological problem—it's the natural result of a loss of connection. You don't need to fight it or try to make it go away. The mind will want to get involved, telling stories, replaying moments, questioning what could have been different. That is just its way of releasing some of the blocked energy. In truth, it really doesn't help that much. If you can stay present with the discomfort, allowing it to surface and move through you, that is the surest way to process grief without leaving long-term scars.

The key is to give grief space without sinking into it. That's the mistake people often make—they either suppress grief, or they drown in it. You don't need to do either. Instead, sit in the seat of awareness and allow the grief to come up to you; don't go down to it. And have compassion for your heart. It's going through a change—welcome the discomfort, while remaining clear and open to the experience.

Grief is part of the process of spiritual cleansing; don't be afraid of it. If you need to, you can help rechannel the energy by breathing it upward. Focus on the center of your heart where the pain is, and take slow deep breaths inward and upward, releasing the energy into the vast universe with each breath. If you give the energy flow the space it needs, it will find its way to a higher place. Your heart will heal—not by closing, but by opening even more.

22-10

I recently lost my child to a serious illness. I'm feeling overwhelmed with grief. Are there spiritual practices that can help me release the pain of grief?

We are very sorry to hear about your loss. It's a beautiful question you've asked about how to release the pain while you grieve. The death of a loved one is difficult for anybody, and it takes time to heal.

This is how a spiritual person navigates the grieving process: they go through the human pain like any other person—except they do not resist the experience. If the heart hurts, they honor the heart's right to feel those real feelings, and they just deeply relax and breathe through the heart. Breathe the pain upward, toward the point between your eyebrows—the spiritual eye. This creates a sense of openness and acceptance.

In the end, a spiritual person honors what their human heart is going through, while at the same time using the experience to explore the depths of their being. They do the same thing with the mind. The mind is going to try to cope with the pain by talking about what could or should have been. A centered person understands the mind and why it does what it does. They just relax behind it with a sense of compassion for the pain of humanness. Honor the mind's right to cleanse, but don't get lost in it. Behind it all is the peace of knowing that all things pass in time, if you let them, and you become greater for having gone through them consciously.

The key is to relax from a place deep inside. Honor what you are going through, but keep gently raising yourself. This is not just how an evolved spiritual person goes through difficulty—it is how one evolves spiritually.

Beyond Mind: Intuition, Prayer, and God

There comes a point on the spiritual journey where the mind simply isn't enough. You've thought, analyzed, and tried to figure it all out—but real freedom doesn't come from thinking your way there. It comes from going beyond the mind, into the quiet place where intuition, surrender, and divine presence naturally arise. Intuition is not a voice in your head telling you what to do; it's a knowing that comes when all the voices stop. Prayer is not asking for life to be your way; it's asking for the wisdom and strength to accept life's way. And God is not something you understand with thought—it's something you experience when you cease being caught in thought. In this chapter, we'll explore your questions about how to go beyond the personal mind and open to the deeper wisdom and love that has always been available to you from within.

23-1

What is intuition, and how can you distinguish it from mental projections?

Intuition isn't just another thought in your mind—it is your higher consciousness speaking directly through you. When you seek intuition from within your thoughts, you're looking for it in all the wrong places. True intuition transcends the thinking mind entirely.

The moment you become concerned with distinguishing real intuition from mental projections, you've already introduced personal motive. You are seeking guidance for making the right decision or avoiding a mistake. But this very motive contaminates the purity of intuition. When your personal mind is attempting to use intuition to solve its personal problems, you can be sure it will be your personal mind you're listening to. Genuine intuition does

not come through coercion or mental striving—it simply unfolds naturally, without any inner effort.

The path to accessing true intuition is simple: remain present, stay open, and allow life to unfold naturally. When you release your attachment to controlling outcomes, you will remove the obstacles that block intuitive wisdom. You don't need techniques to access intuition—you simply need to get out of the way. Let go of the personal self, with all its preferences and concerns, and truth will be effortlessly available. The deep wisdom of intuition emerges when your consciousness ceases to be bound to the ego-mind.

23-2

Does intuition require that I quiet my mind first?

If you relentlessly practice relaxing and releasing the incessant mental chatter, things will become quieter inside. You will reach a state where you are just there noticing what is going on around you, both inside and out. Thoughts and feelings will arise in front of you, but they will not capture your attention enough to pull you into them. Yet without thinking, you will know things. You will just know that you know, to the core of your being. That is intuition.

If that intuition is inspiring you to manifest externally, very logical thoughts will arise to support that manifestation. Those thoughts have their root in the intuition, not in your personal psyche. You will eventually notice that the personal, psyche-driven thoughts bubble up from below where you sit inside, while the impersonal, intuition-driven thoughts come from above. This will eventually become as clear as day to you. *The Surrender Experiment* deals with the subtlety of this topic. You will get a lot from that book.

23-3

How can I differentiate between intuition and the mind's interference?

The first thing you need to understand is that intuition is quiet. It doesn't argue with you, and it doesn't try to convince you. The personal mind, on the other hand, is very loud. It talks and talks, trying to justify itself, trying to make sure you listen. It will even claim it is your intuition: "Trust your gut! You just know this is right!" But if it's loud—if it's filled with emotion, past

experiences, fears, or desires—that is not intuition. That is your psyche. That is the voice inside your head, and that is what you need to let go of.

True intuition isn't based on past experiences or personal fears. It's not reminding you of how you got hurt before or warning you that something bad might happen again. That's the mind trying to protect itself. Intuition is deeper than that. It doesn't arise from personal likes and dislikes, from what you want or don't want. It's not tangled up in your conditioning. Instead, it's a quiet knowing that simply is. It doesn't have to convince you—it just arises naturally.

If you really want to touch intuition, first let go of all the noise. When a thought, a fear, or a strong desire comes up, relax and release it. If it's not true intuition, it will pass. If it is real, it will still be there after you've let go of everything else. You don't have to worry about missing something important—truth doesn't disappear just because you relax. In fact, the only way to clearly perceive truth is by letting go of the personal noise that distorts it.

Life has a natural flow. If you stop trying to impose your personal preferences on reality, you will start to notice that things unfold in harmony. The outside world will align with what is deeper inside of you, and you won't have to struggle to figure it out. That's how you tell the difference between mind and intuition. If you're caught up in thoughts and emotions, it's the mind. If it's quiet, clear, and unwavering, it's intuition. Let go of the noise, and you will see.

23-4

I would like to know the role of prayer and surrender in situations involving serious illness, human suffering, and natural disasters. Does prayer really help?

Yes, you are helping others when you pray. Your heart energy is like light; it travels vast distances and carries the heartfelt vibration of the sender. If you sincerely strive to let go of your personal preferences, fears, and desires that keep you bound to yourself, you will begin to feel God's healing energy moving through you.

It is true that there is great suffering that goes on in this world. The willingness to recognize that fact and to keep your heart and mind open allows you to be a beacon of light in the darkness. If you get lost because you cannot

handle the realities of life, you become part of the problem, not the solution. Heartfelt compassion is a very high form of prayer. The light that emanates from your heart when you are open is a truly powerful healing force.

23-5

Is prayer effective, and what is the highest form of prayer?

Of course, prayer is effective. But you have to ask yourself: *What am I praying for and why?* If you are using prayer to ask for things—I want a car, I want people to like me—that’s a certain kind of prayer. That’s you trying to manipulate the universe to fit your personal preferences. The highest prayer is not about getting things for yourself; it’s about letting go of yourself. It’s about transcending your small, personal self and connecting with something much greater. The most meaningful prayers are for self-realization, for liberation, for removing the obstacles between you and God. “Not my will but thy will be done” is the highest prayer—it leads you beyond your personal wants and fears into something vast and infinite.

Praying for others is beautiful as well because it helps them and also moves your focus off your personal needs. The most transformative prayers are the ones that lift you beyond yourself altogether. You don’t have to pray for reality to be different. You can surrender to God’s will. You can say, *Help me let go. Help me rise above this constant noise of my mind.* When you pray like this, you open yourself up to something much greater than what your mind thinks it wants.

The most powerful prayer is not in words—it is in the action of letting go, again and again. It is allowing yourself to merge with the expansiveness of the universe—with God. As you do this, you will find that happiness and peace arise naturally because you stopped clinging to the small self that always wants something. You will become a beacon of light in this world, a channel for the light everyone is praying for.

23-6

What about prayer to attract to ourselves what we think we need? Or should prayer only be used to help others?

When you pray for others, you're engaging in something much higher than simply asking for what you personally want. When you ask for things for yourself—whether it's material possessions, better circumstances, or even just comfort—you're reinforcing the idea that you are not okay. You're saying, *I need this to be happy*. That's a form of taking. You're trying to rearrange the world so it fits your preferences, so you can finally feel okay. If you look at it honestly, that's a never-ending cycle. You get one thing, but then you need the next, and then the next. It keeps you trapped in a state of always needing something outside yourself.

Praying for others, for peace, for the well-being of the world—this is giving. It's not about making the world fit your desires; it's about offering something from within yourself. The less it has to do with your personal attachments—your family, your friends—the purer that giving becomes. When you sincerely say, *May everyone be well, may everyone be free, may all beings find peace*, you are moving beyond yourself. Little by little, this is the stairway to heaven. You are letting go of “me” and expanding into something greater.

Ultimately, as you grow spiritually, you begin to see that reality is not personal. The world is unfolding as it does because of the nature of things. Water is blue, flowers are red, and grass is green. When you stop resisting that, when you stop constantly trying to manipulate reality to fit your personal needs, something beautiful happens—you come into harmony with life. In that harmony, you become a blessing on the earth. You are no longer adding negativity, resistance, or struggle—you are adding peace.

Here's the real secret—when you reach a certain state of inner peace, your very presence helps others. You don't have to do anything. You contribute to the energy of the world in a meaningful way just by being. That's why the great sages affect everything around them, simply by existing. It's like the saying, “A high tide raises all ships.” A high being raises all people. In some traditions, monks and meditators dedicate their practice to uplifting all of humanity. It's not just a belief; it's a real effect. The deeper you go into your own peace, the more you naturally give that peace to the world.

So, yes, pray, meditate, send love—whatever practice moves you. Just understand the deeper truth: When you are whole and complete within yourself, giving happens naturally. It just flows out of you, and that is what blesses the world.

23-7

Can belief in God be rationally established in the mind, or is it to be experienced beyond the mind?

You are correct that the mind cannot understand God, and it won't help to keep thinking about it. The mind wants to know and understand what God is, so it does what the mind does best: it builds beliefs, concepts, and ideas, all based on our past experiences. But our past experiences don't include God-realization, so what can we do?

All the great ones from all religions have taught that God is everything that is, was, and ever will be. Fortunately, you do not have to use your mind to either believe or not believe in God. You can simply work on relaxing and releasing whenever your personal thoughts come up, and then focus on who is aware of the thoughts. You are in there, noticing the mind talking about everything. You are even noticing the mind talking about God! Keep relaxing when the personal mind is busy talking, as well as when you feel emotional reactions, and you will begin to experience a beautiful, silent clarity that is far beyond the mind.

The seat of consciousness is the core of your being—it is your soul, and it can directly experience its connection to God. This experience is far beyond the mind's belief structure. Yet it naturally exists when the noise of the personal mind is no longer distracting you. When you interact with life from this place of deep clarity, you will find yourself living in a constant state of joy and love. Once you stop listening to the personal, it all becomes spiritual, and you will naturally feel your connection with Divinity. You will not have to think about it—you will be experiencing it.

23-8

They say God is love. Is that true, and can I experience that directly?

There are many different levels of love. The love that is experienced as need is a human emotion caused by the heart being blocked to the inner flow of shakti. When the heart is unconditionally open, you will never feel the need for love because your heart will remain full of love regardless of what is happening. Such an open heart is difficult for people to achieve because they have stored pain from the past that creates blockages to the inner energy flow. This is why people often need special outside conditions in order for their heart to open. Let's call that human love. It is still beautiful, especially compared to the other human emotions, but it is conditional, and it can create dependencies and attachments.

Spiritual love is very different. Once the heart learns to remain open, even under difficult circumstances, the flow of unhampered energy through the heart feeds the indwelling soul directly. Because you are now fulfilled inside, you don't have to constantly control the outside. You are deeply content experiencing the inner flow of love.

Eventually, you will want to explore the source of this beautiful energy. The only way to explore the source is by falling into it. When you do so, you will become completely immersed in overwhelming love, joy, and bliss. This is the point where the shakti flow changes direction. You will begin to feel a tremendous upward flow pulling you beyond your sense of individuality. It feels like God is calling you home. And that is exactly what is happening.

The great ones have let go completely, and their drop of consciousness has merged back into the ocean of consciousness. This is Christ's "I and my Father are one." This is Buddha's Nirvana. This is Islam's Sufi *Fanā*, the complete dissolution of the ego/self in the presence of God. This is the Jewish Kabbalah's *Bitul HaYesh*, dissolving the ego/self into Divine nothingness. This is Enlightenment—the meaning of all of life.

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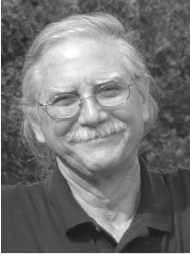
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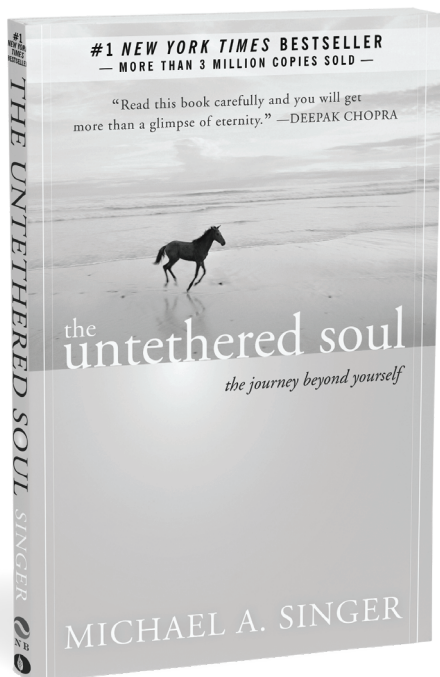
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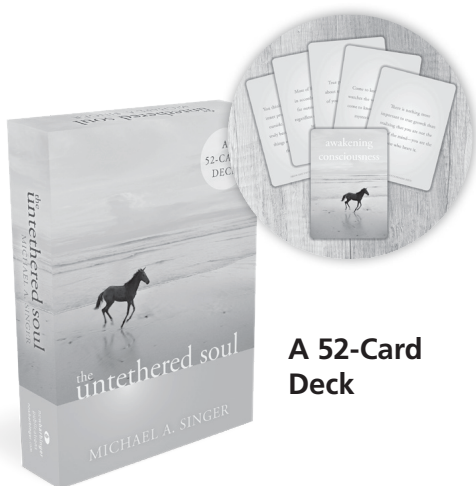
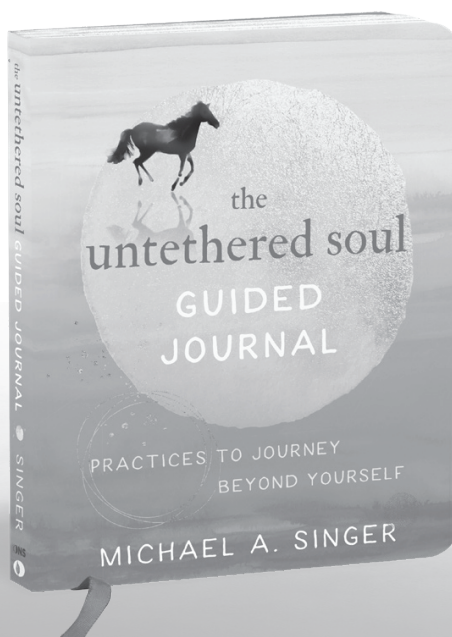
MICHAEL A. SINGER is author of the #1 *New York Times* bestseller, *The Untethered Soul*, and the *New York Times* bestsellers, *Living Untethered* and *The Surrender Experiment*, all of which have been published worldwide. He had a deep inner awakening in 1971 while working on his doctorate in economics, and went into seclusion to focus on yoga and meditation. In 1975, he founded Temple of the Universe, a now long-established yoga and meditation center where people of any religion or set of beliefs can come together to experience inner peace. Along with his nearly five decades of spiritual teaching, Singer has made major contributions in the areas of business, education, health care, and environmental protection. Visit www.untetheredsoul.com for more information.

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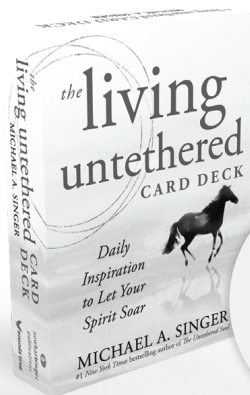
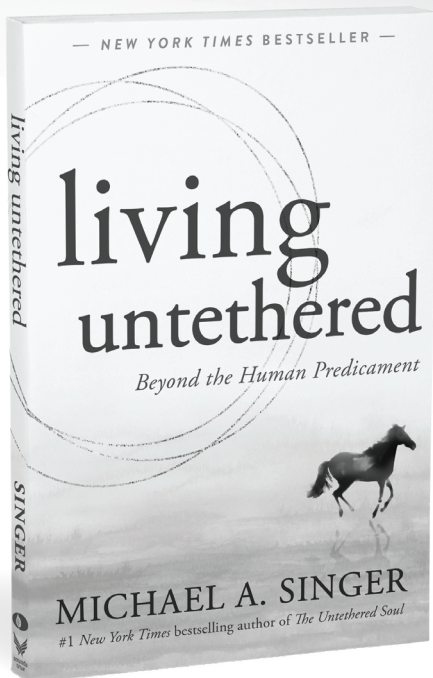
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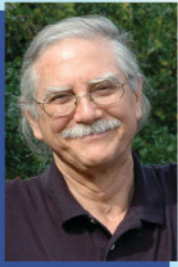


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WHAT IF THE LIFE YOU'VE BEEN SEARCHING FOR IS ALREADY WITHIN YOU?

From the *New York Times* bestselling author who transformed millions of lives with *The Untethered Soul* comes a profound new guide to inner freedom and spiritual clarity. In *Wisdom Untethered*, Michael A. Singer offers direct, compassionate answers to some of life's deepest challenges: how to find peace amid chaos, how to handle the mind's endless chatter, how to let go of emotional pain, and how to live from the vast awareness that you truly are.

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